a homage to luciano berio

interconnection

for electronic track and six instruments

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description

The six, biographically organised, sections connect fluidly and are not marked in the score. The content, however, makes clear the point by which the transitions have occurred, if not the precise moment of that occurrence.

I. musical prison

This section portrays Berio's experience of growing up in a musical family in Oneglia, a remote province in an artistically stifling Italy (quoting a Prelude and Fugue by his father, Ernesto Berio), the passing by of WW2, and his eventual discovery of the music of Luigi Dallapiccola, who would become a major point of both musical and spiritual reference for Berio through his melodic approach to serialism and his politically conscious music. Based on a three-note melodic cell F-E-C#, from Dallapiccola's opera *Il Prigioniero* ("The Prisoner"), the music then shifts to quote Berio's *Chamber Music*, a setting of Joyce's poem, which he wrote as a response to Dallapiccola's musical idiom.

II. I felt I was walking in a kind of new land

Opening with extracts from *Sequenza III for voice,* this section introduces a new chapter in Berio's creative development starting from his interest in the human voice, his visits to the USA and the Darmstadt School in West Germany in the early 1950s which introduced him to electroacoustic music, and his joint establishment of the experimental electronic faculty Studio di fonologia musicale in Milan in 1955. Recordings of electronic music that Berio encountered by Stockhausen, Ussachevsky and Cage are combined with a reading of Joyce's poem *At That Hour* and Berio's own *Omaggio a Joyce*, using text from *Sirens* in *Ulysses,* which was revolutionary in its liberation of meaning from words, and its synthesis of poetry, technology and music.

III. cathy

This section celebrates the creative collaboration between Berio and mezzosoprano Cathy Berberian—the accompanying music is *Loosin Yelav* from *Folk Songs*, a song cycle which he wrote in tribute to Berberian's voice. It also depicts Berio's gradual disillusionment with electronic music, by opening with extracts from his electroacoustic work *Visage*, and ending with *Circles,* a purely acoustic experimentation of the voice through the poems of E.E. Cummings.

IV. self-portrait

The third movement of Berio's *Sinfonia* serves as the basis of this section—the music which the live ensemble plays is based on the Mahler Scherzo, layered with musical quotations from Stravinsky, Berlioz, Berg and Schubert. This music then interacts with the 1969 World Premiere recording of *Sinfonia,* with melodies being repeated and delayed to further blur a sense of time, meaning and understanding. Yet as fragmented and disjointed as it is, this section also highlights how Berio thought of his work as a "documentary", and a surprisingly personal one: a journey through his own

inherited musical traditions and an attempt to understand them, to “find unity among very different things”.

V. the smallest detail

This section focuses on Berio’s later solo works for the piano, namely *Erdenklavier* and *Wasserklavier* from his *Six Encores for Piano,* and his *Sonata for Piano* written in 2000. Far removed from the exuberant quality of his work in the 60s, the two encores are connected through elemental themes of water and earth. Berio talks briefly of his home in Radicondoli, Italy, to which he retreated after decades in the USA, and of “roots”, highlighting his fascination with folk material and “the smallest detail, in connection with the larger world.”

VI. the past is not a prison

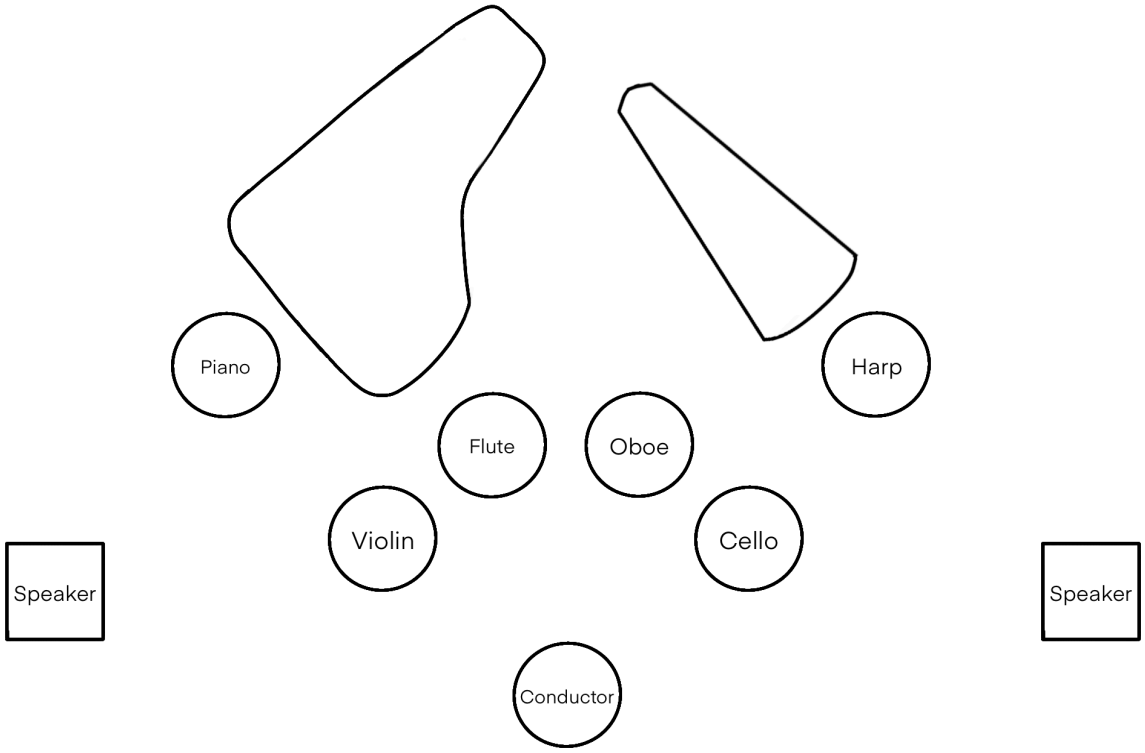
The second movement of *Coro* runs throughout this section, with the live ensemble echoing the electronic track and playing fragments of melodies from the first movement, *Today is mine*. Berio speaks of his relationship with history and how he sees it as a source of continual exploration and inspiration. The third movement of *Sinfonia* then returns as Eco talks of the connections between Berio and the contemporary world. The piece ends as a palimpsest of previous recordings of *Sinfonia*, as each tenor voice thanks different conductors who have recorded it throughout history.

performance notes

The live players should never overpower the electronic track, or vice versa. Where possible, the performers should strive for blending of their acoustic sound to the electronic track. The audio system should support stereo panning.

An assistant will be needed to start the audio track. The extensive timestamps marked in the score will aid the conductor in coordinating the live ensemble with the track.

The marked time always corresponds to the downbeat of the bar, unless otherwise shown.



sources

Works are listed in order of appearance in the piece.

vocal

Luciano Berio - A Contemporary Maestro (2000) - dir. Reuven Hecker
Il Duce (1937) - Mussolini speaking in Palermo Harbour
Luciano Berio, Interview (1972) - interview with Hans Heg for the Holland Festival
Cathy Berberian reading Sirens - unedited vocal sample from *Air Wars* by Crystal Castle (2007)
At That Hour, James Joyce - reading by Ole Irenaeus Wieroed
Cathy Berberian talking, rehearsing, singing, laughing, explaining (1979) - Fragments from a Dutch radio show
Music is the Air I Breathe (1997) - dir. Carrie de Swaan, on the life of Cathy Berberian
Voyage to Cythera (1999) - dir. Frank Scheffer
A Conversation with Igor Stravinsky (1957) - from *The Wisdom Series* by the National Broadcasting Company
Les leçons des peuples amérindiens selon Claude Lévi-Strauss (1991) - Interview on France 3
Paris May 1968 Student Protests - archival footage from DiFilm

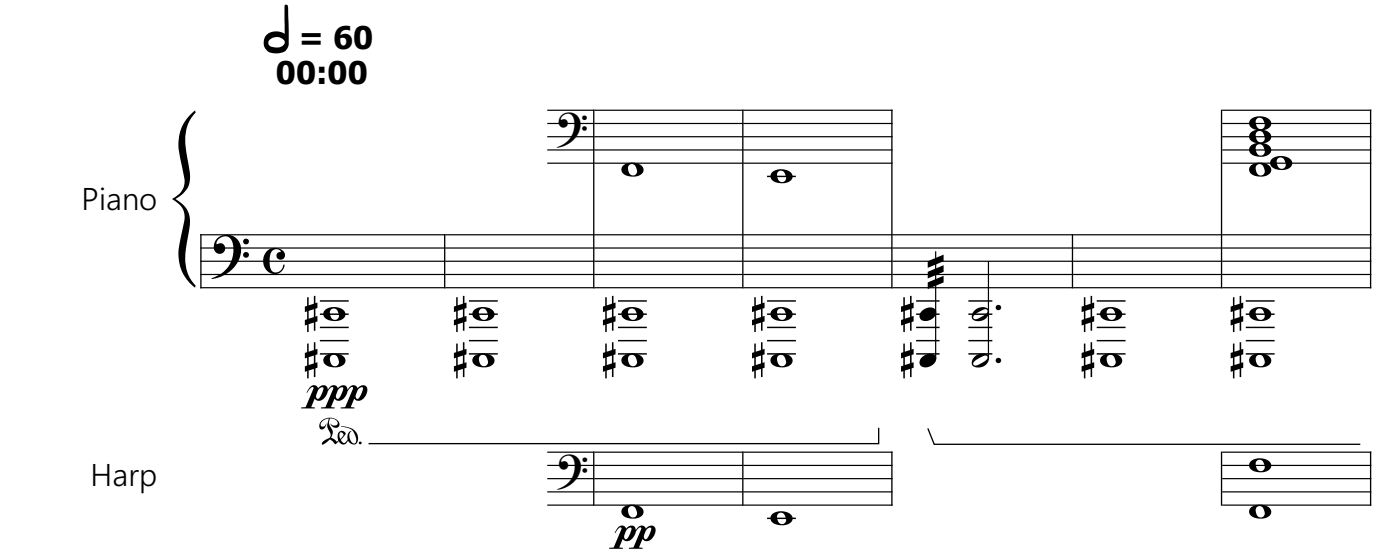
musical

Sonic Contours (1952) - Luening & Ussachevsky
Sequenza III for female voice (1958) - Berio, performed by Cathy Berberian
Imaginary Landscape No.1 (1939) - Cage
Gesang der Jünglinge (1955) - Stockhausen
Thema - Omaggio a Joyce (1958) - Berio
Visage for tape (1961) - Berio
Circles (1960) - Berio
Sinfonia, movement 3 (1968) - world premiere recording by New York Philharmonic, conducted by Luciano Berio, 1969
Coro, movement 2 *"Venid a ver"* (1974-6) - Berio
Sinfonia, movement 3 (1968) -

Orchestra of the Academy of Santa Cecilia, Rome, conducted by Antoniou Pappano, 2007
CBSO, conducted by Simon Rattle, 1987
Czech Philharmonic, conducted by Semyon Bychkov, 2018
Gothenburg Symphony Orchestra, conducted by Péter Eötvös, 2005
Chicago Symphony Orchestra, conducted by Pierre Boulez, 1995
Royal Concertgebouw Orchestra, conducted by Ed Spanjaard, 2010
SBSO, conducted by Eduardo Leandro, 2016
UC Davis Symphony Orchestra, conducted by Christian Baldini, 2015

To go away from this little town, provincial town, musically speaking

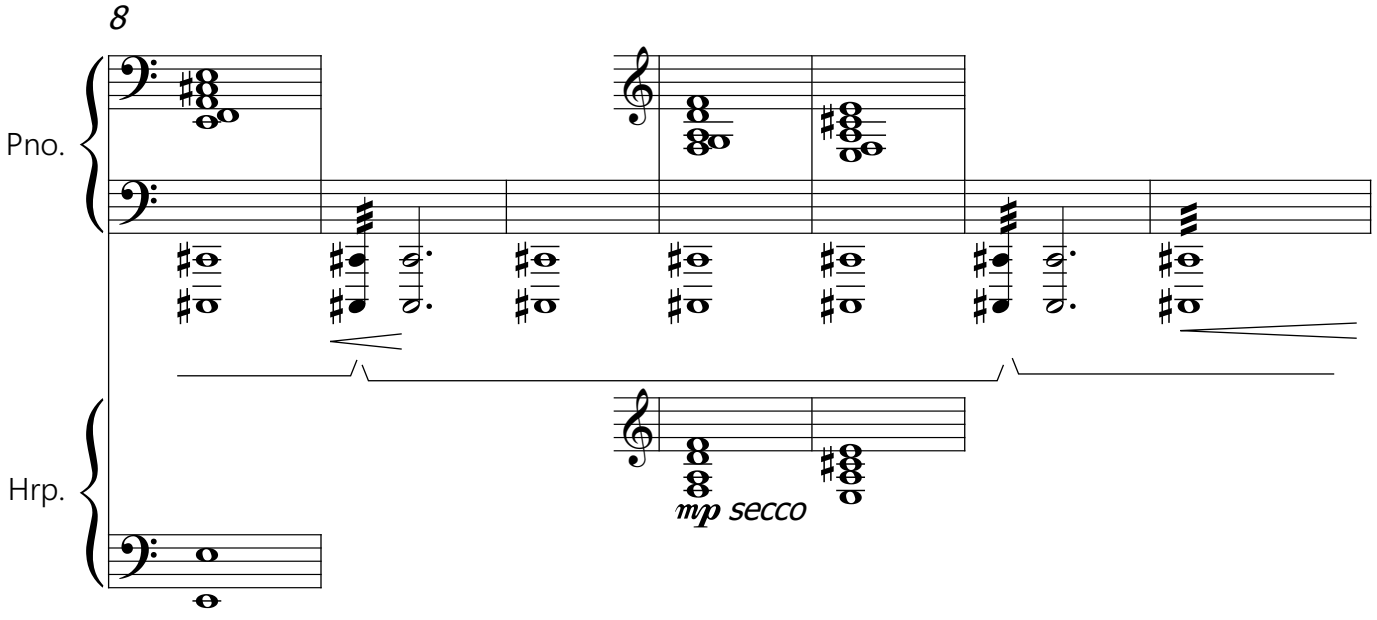
We were completely cut off

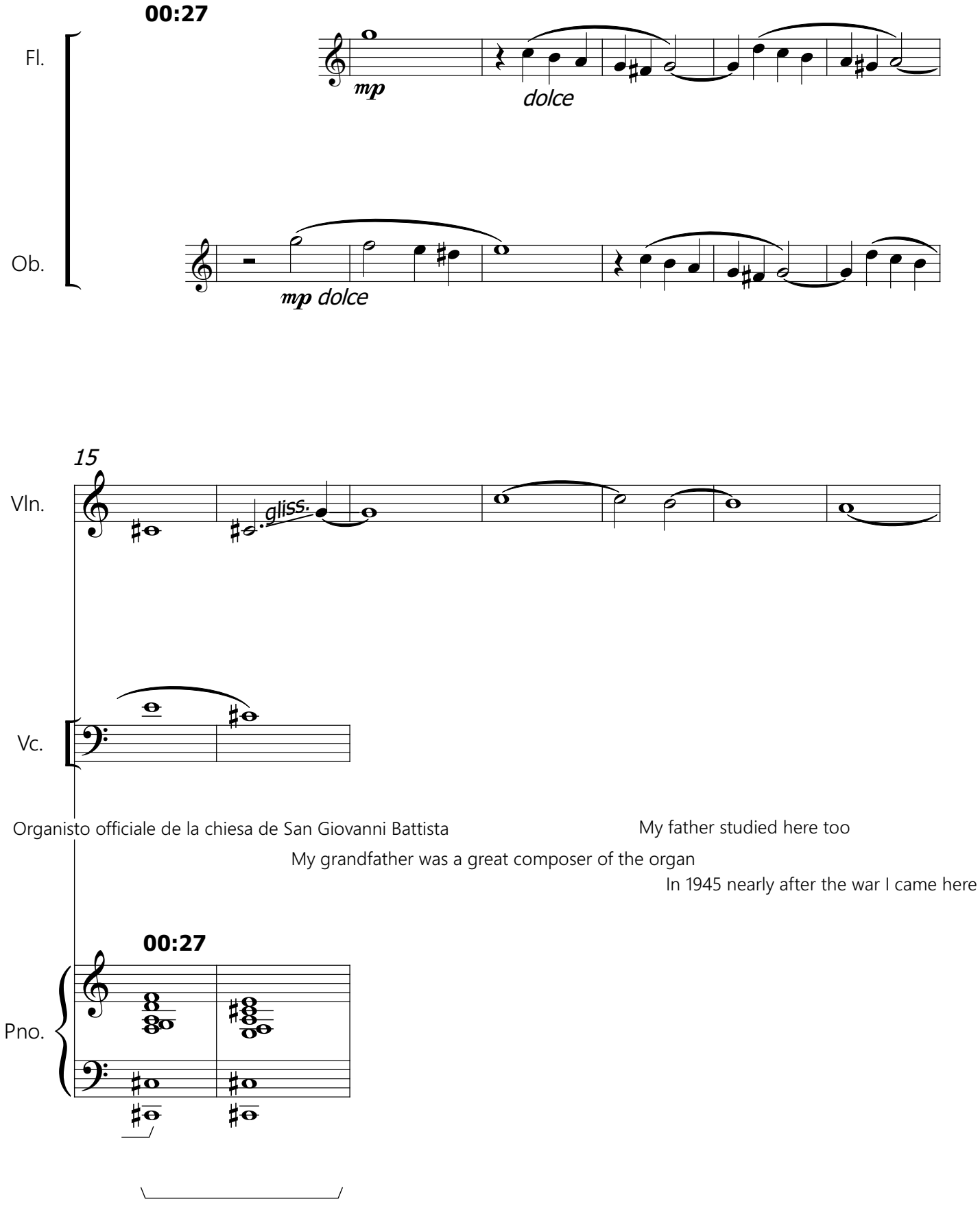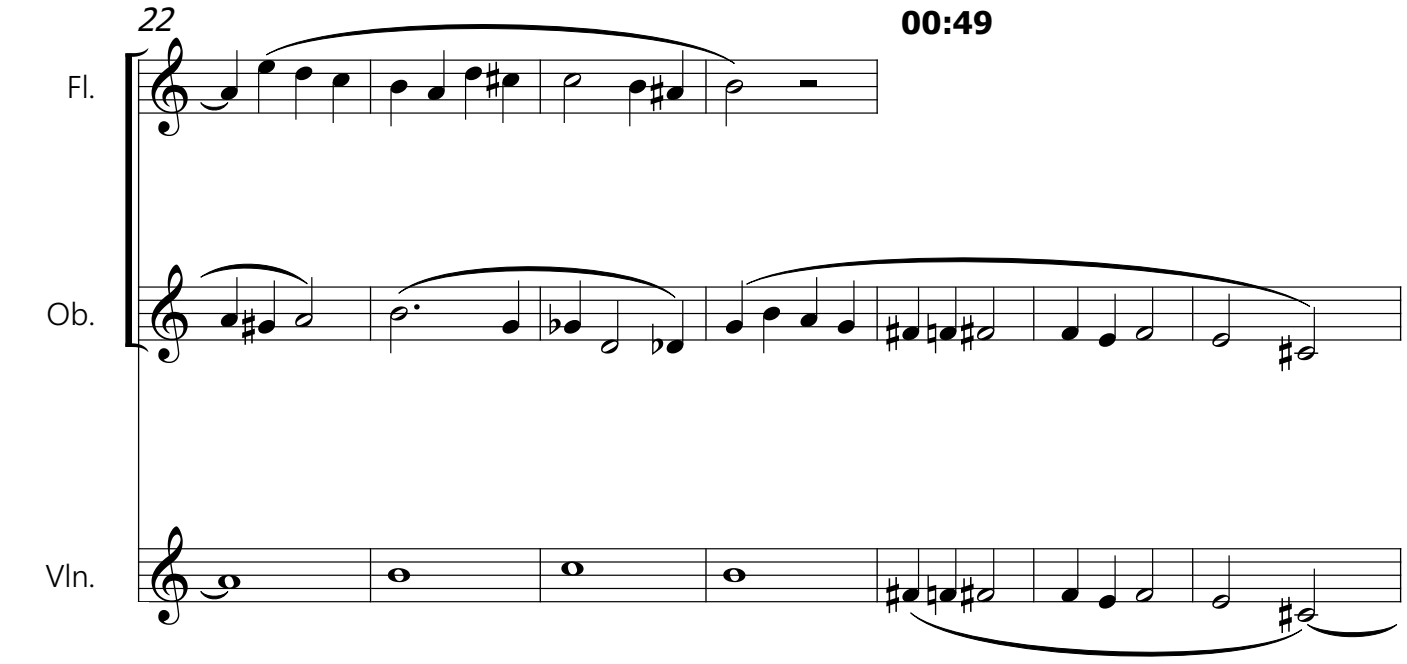




From that musical... prison

In the house everyone was making music, my father, my grandfather and so on




00:27
Fl.
mp
dolce
Ob.
mp dolce
15
Vln.
gliss.
Vc.
Organisto officiale de la chiesa de San Giovanni Battista
My father studied here too
My grandfather was a great composer of the organ
In 1945 nearly after the war I came here
00:27
Pno.





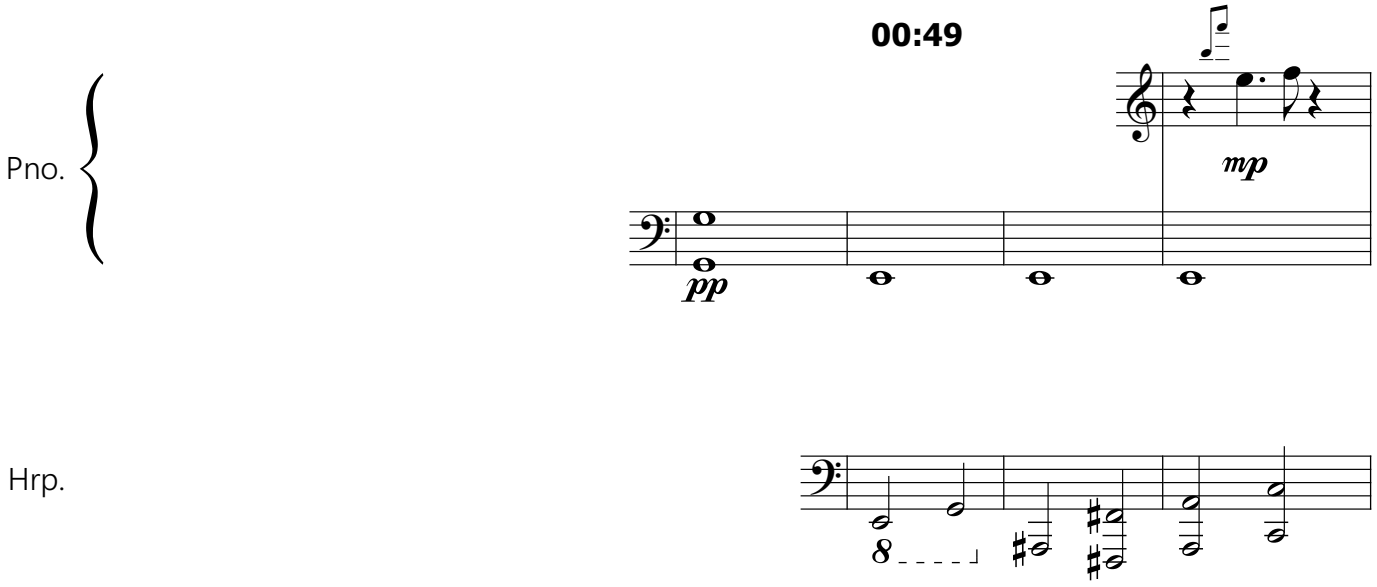
To come to Milan was very important for me
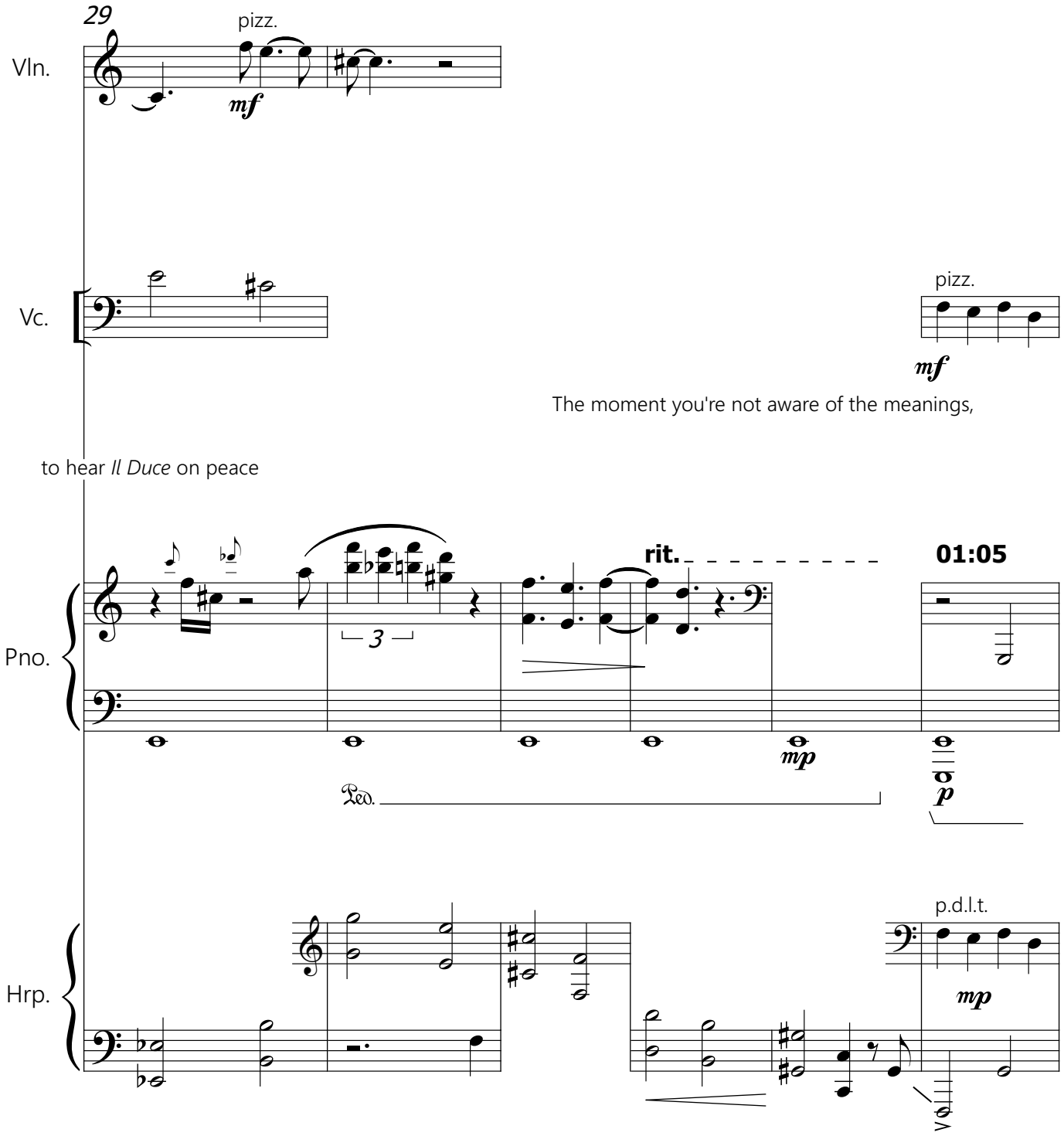
Beautiful tree, magnolia tree

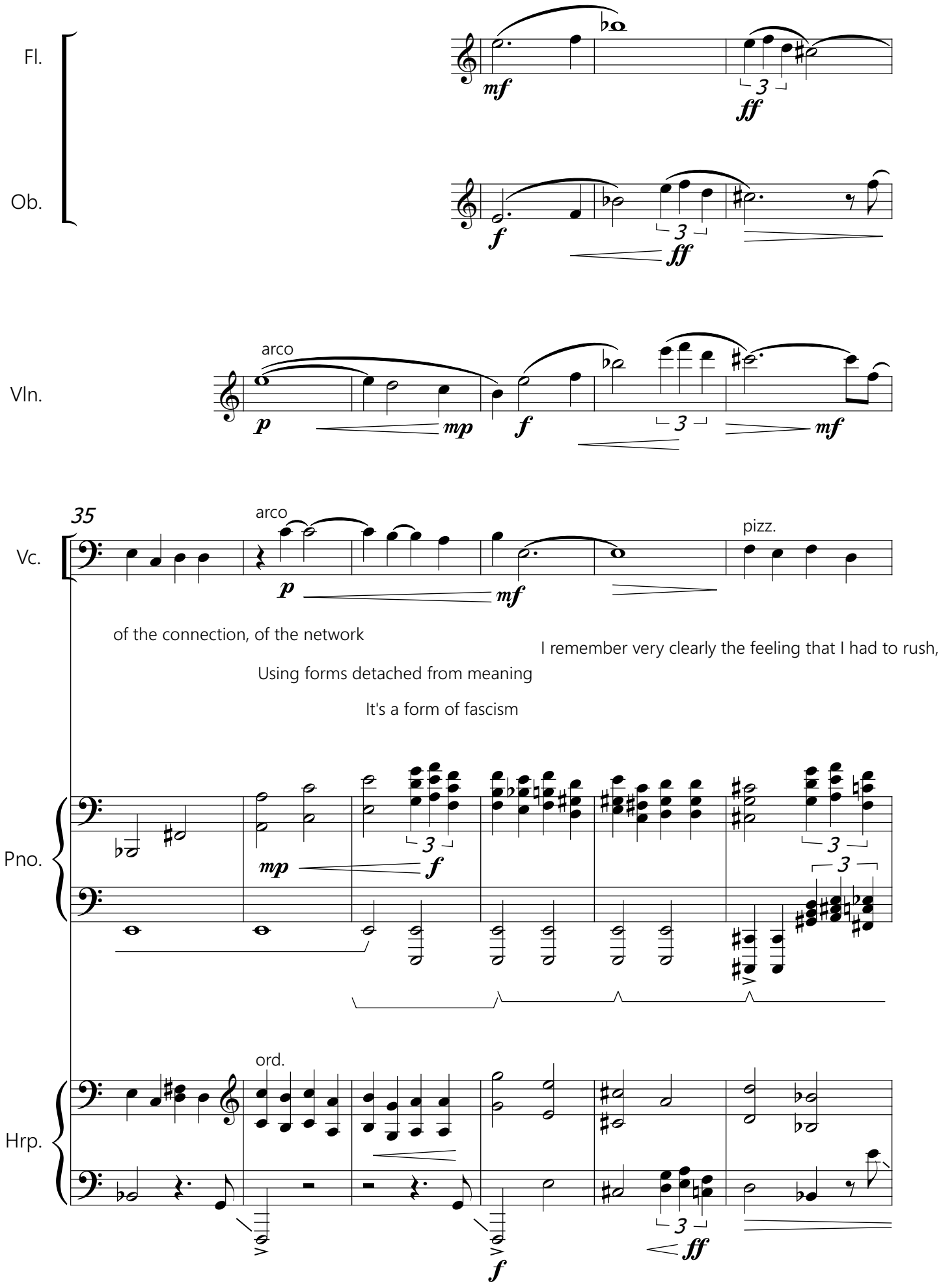
With the war, with fascism

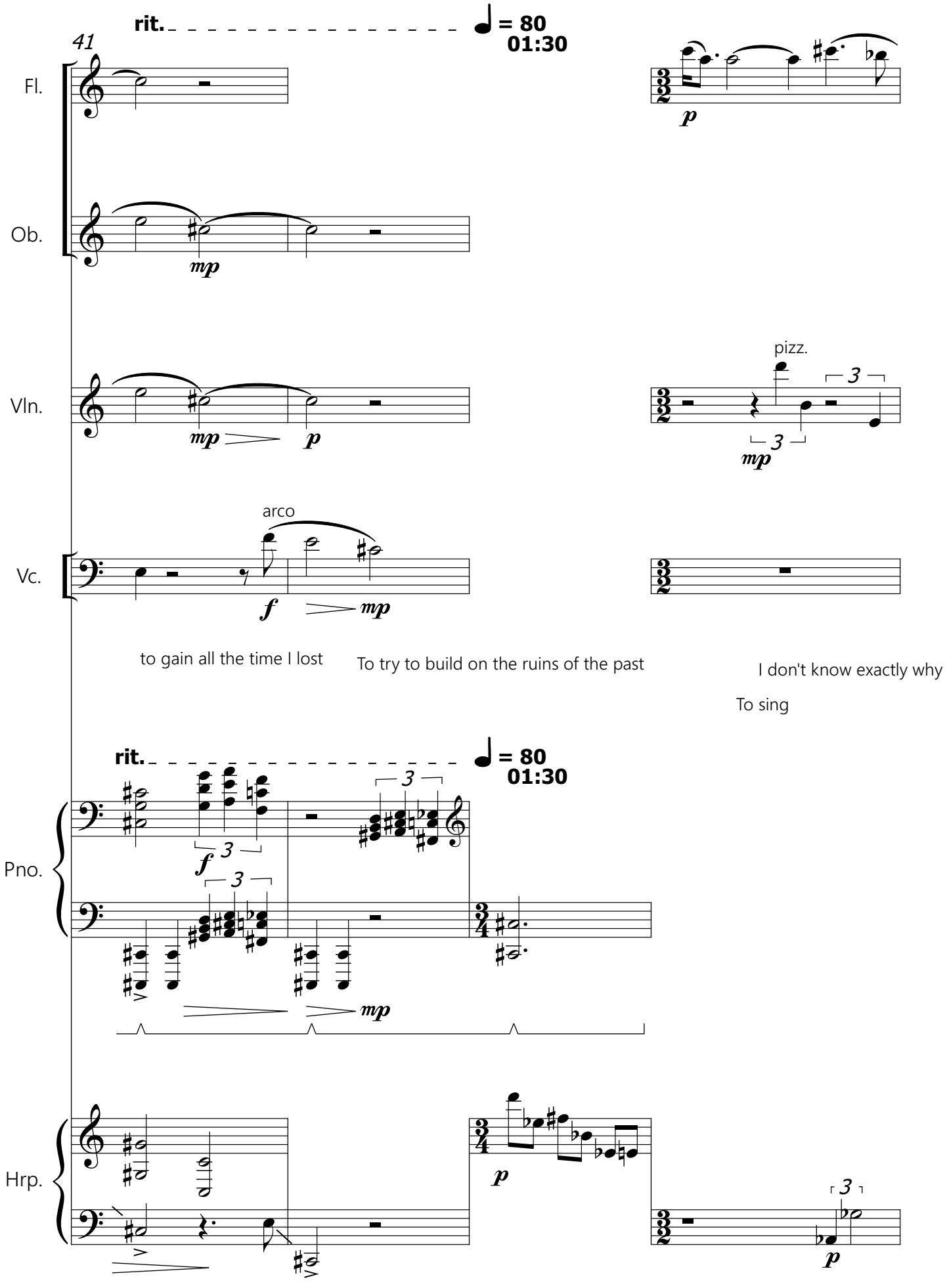
A name to conjure with: Mussolini

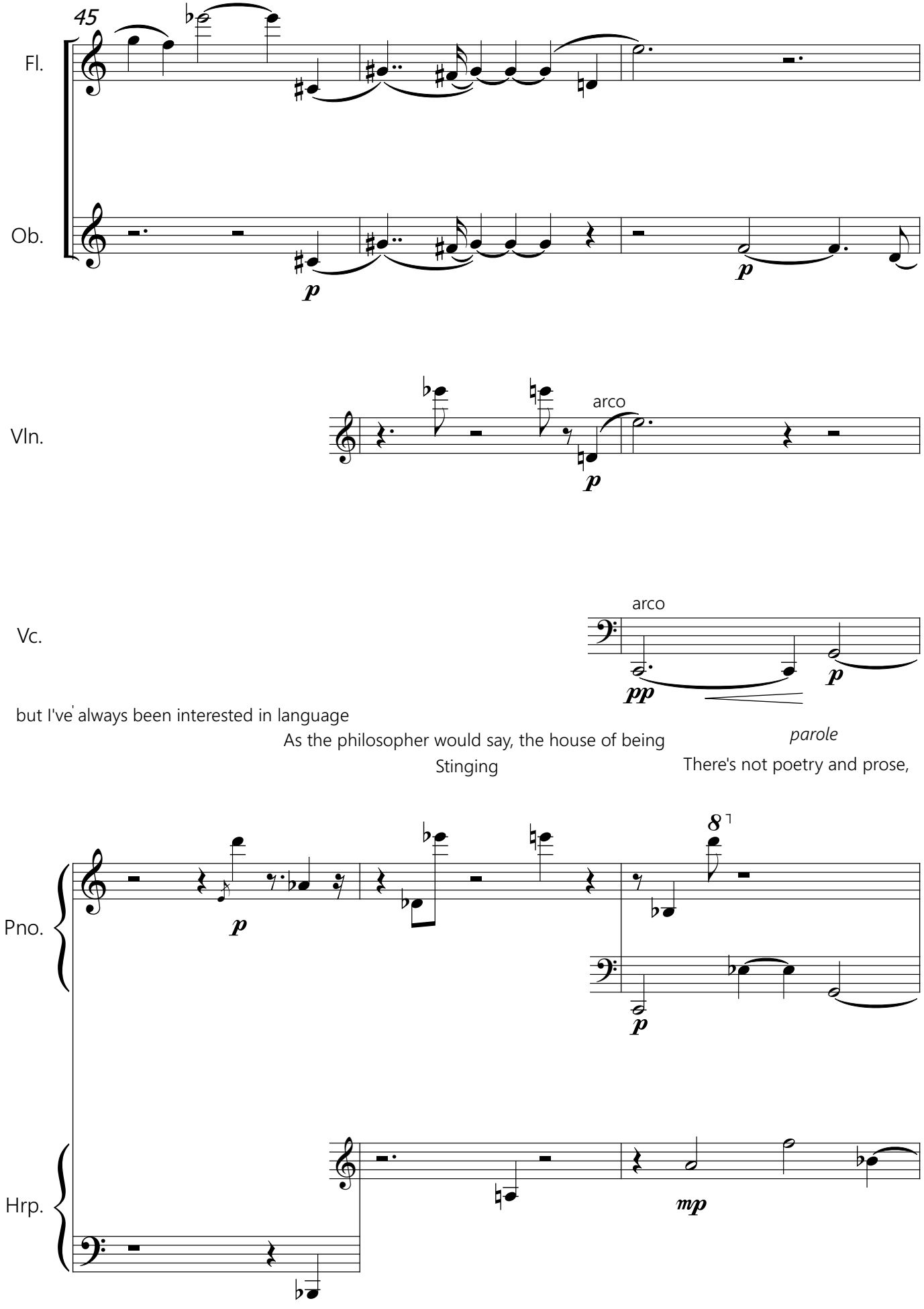
Prepare for war
With a background of battleships,

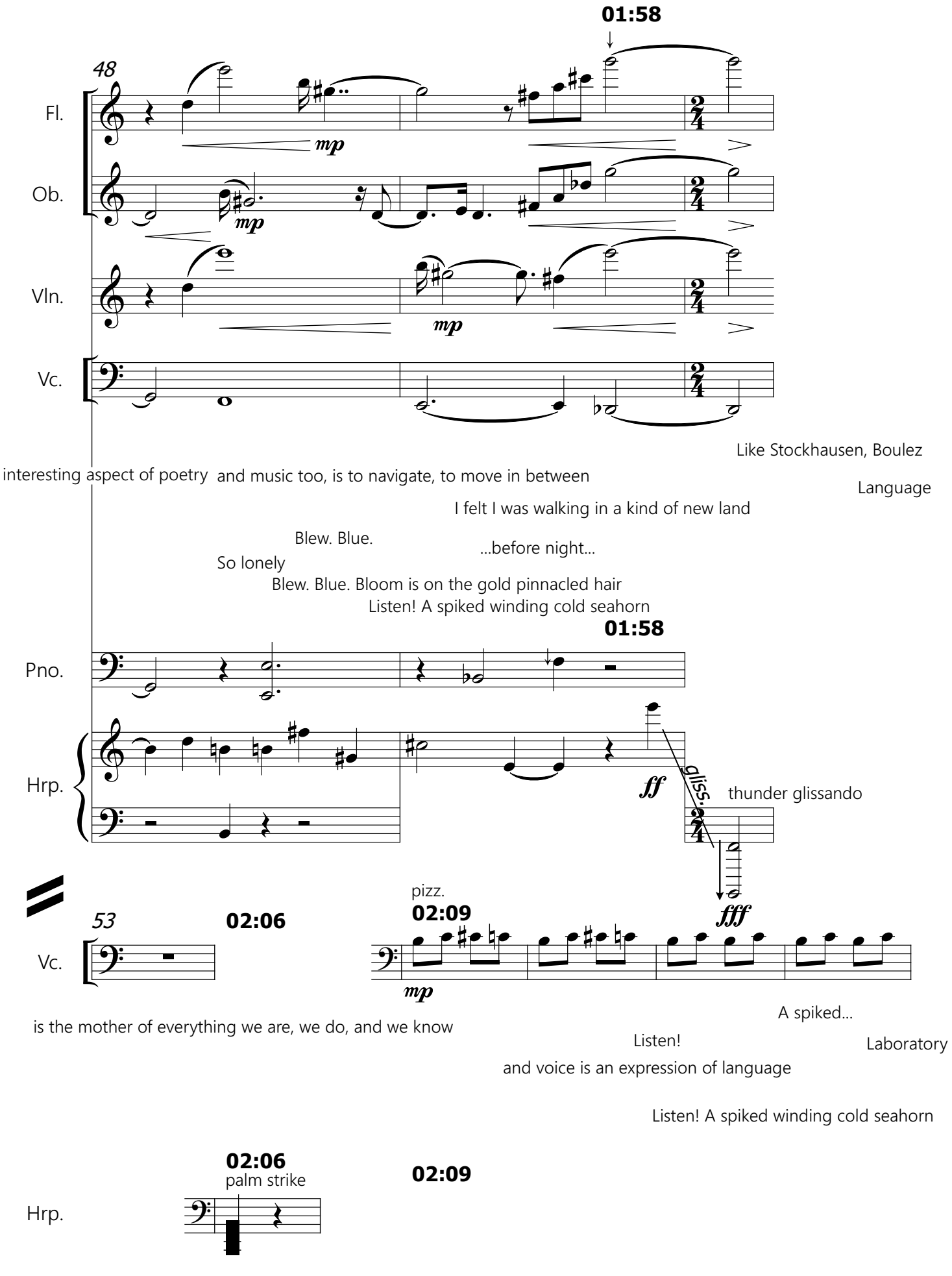


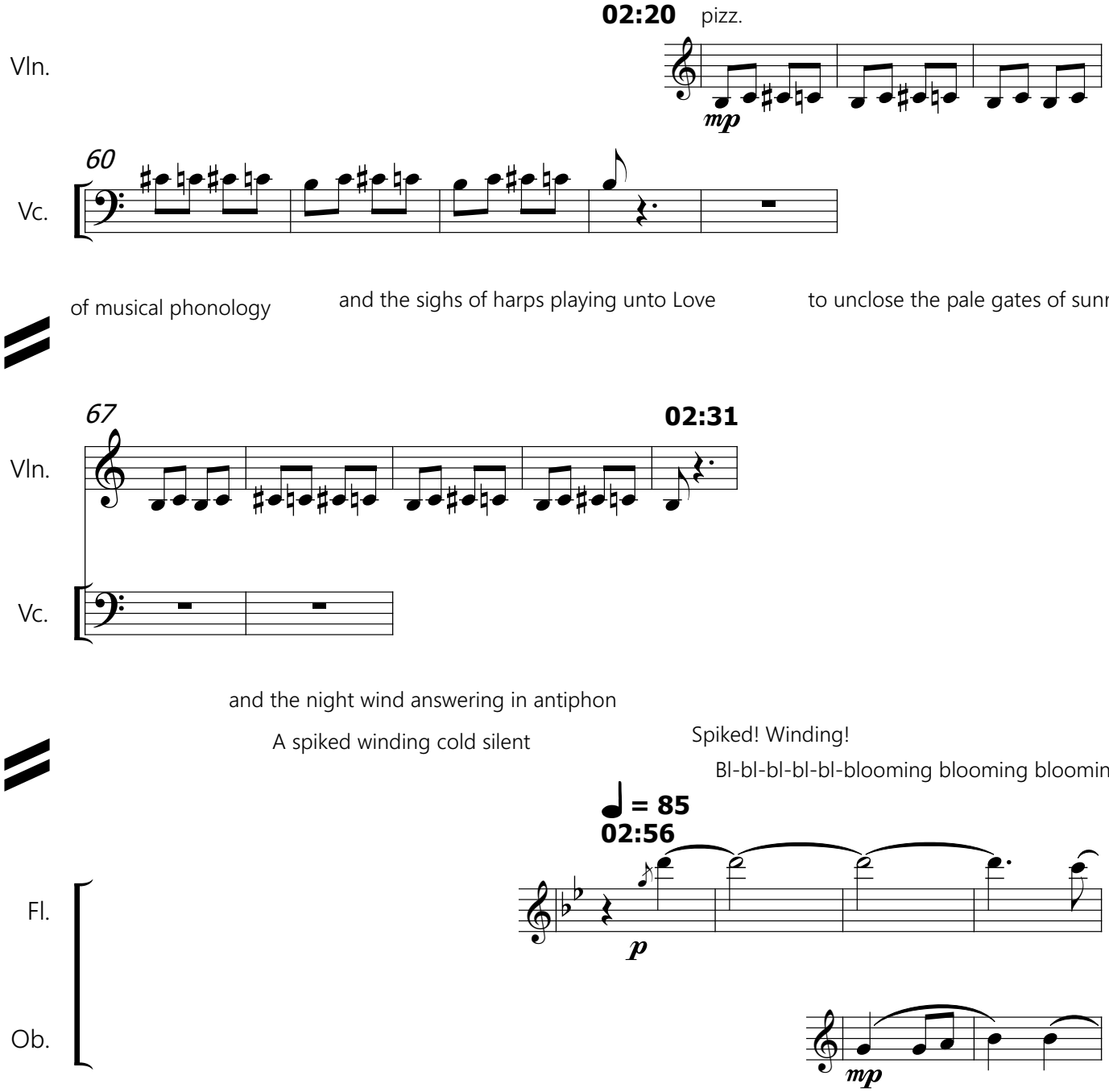

29
pizz.
Vln.
mf
Vc.
pizz.
mf
The moment you're not aware of the meanings,
to hear *Il Duce* on peace
Pno.
rit.
01:05
3
mp
p
Ped.
Hrp.
p.d.l.t.
mp

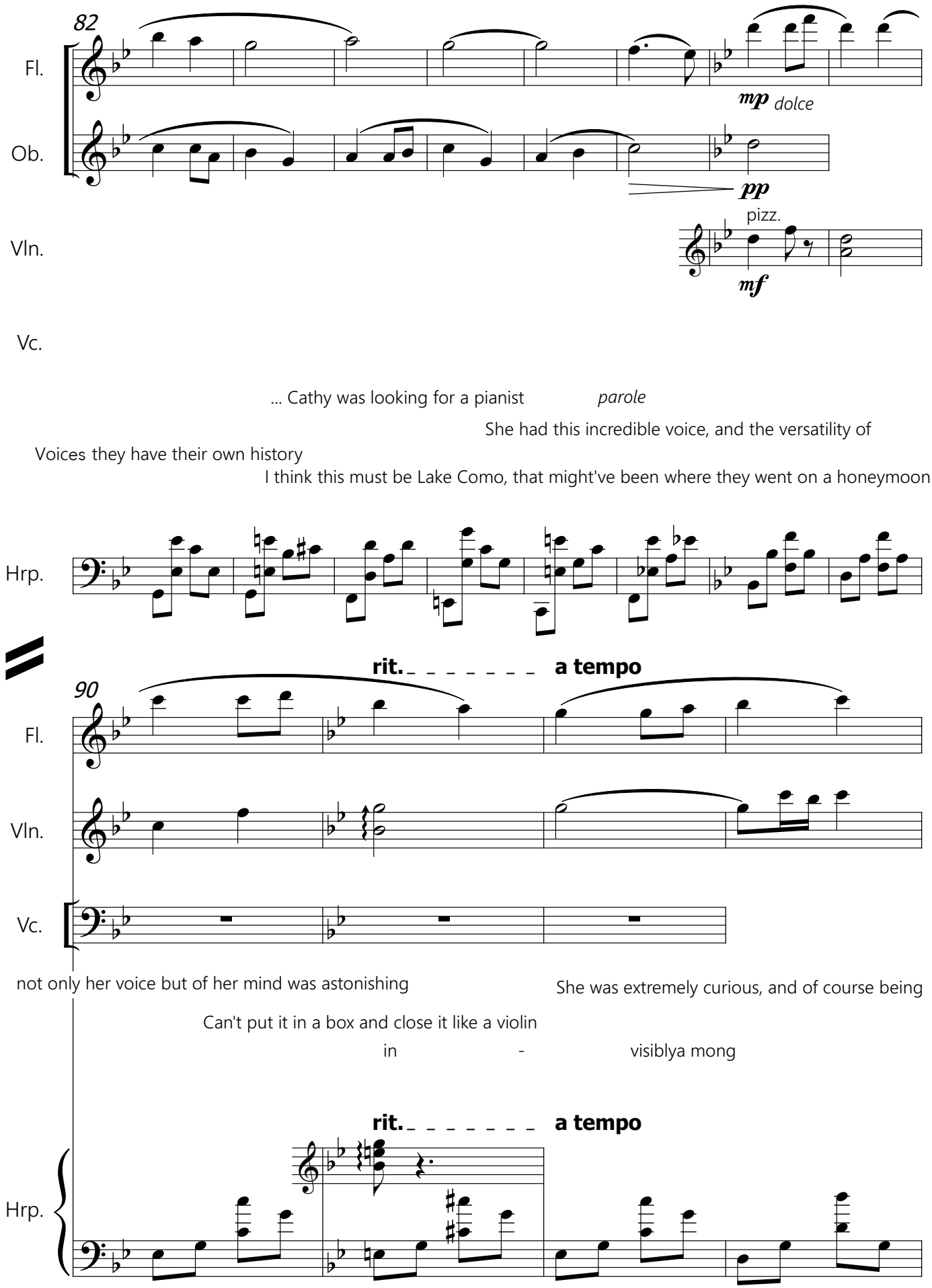

Fl.
Ob.
Vln.
arco
Vc.
35
arco
pizz.
of the connection, of the network
Using forms detached from meaning
It's a form of fascism
I remember very clearly the feeling that I had to rush,
Pno.
Hrp.
ord.
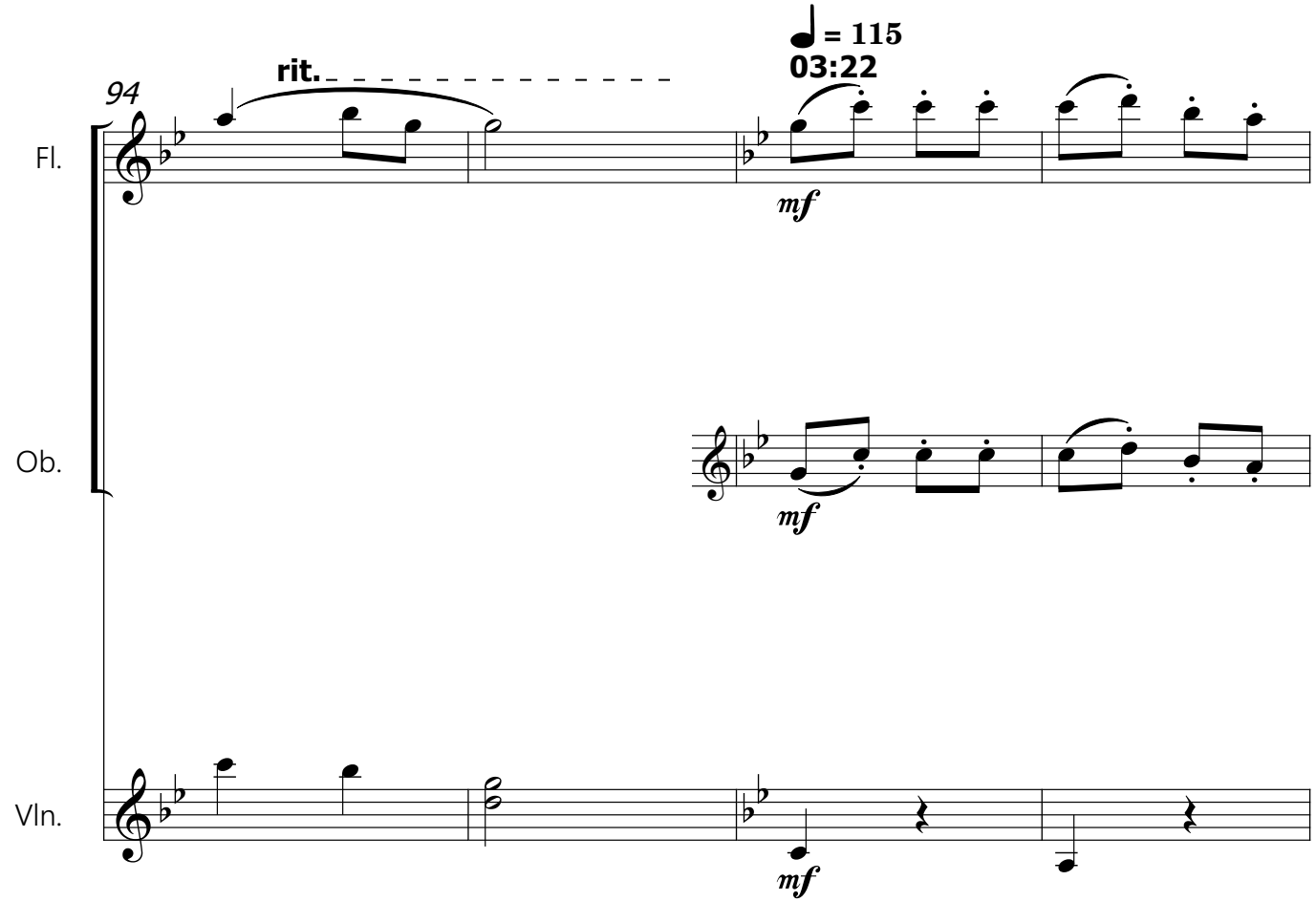

rit.
= 80
01:30
41
Fl.
Ob.
Vln.
Vc.
Pno.
Hrp.
pizz.
arco
to gain all the time I lost
To try to build on the ruins of the past
I don't know exactly why
To sing


45
Fl.
Ob.
p
p
Vln.
arco
p
Vc.
arco
pp
p
but I've always been interested in language
As the philosopher would say, the house of being
Stinging
parole
There's not poetry and prose,
Pno.
8
p
p
Hrp.
mp


01:58
48
Fl.
Ob.
Vln.
Vc.
mp
Like Stockhausen, Boulez
interesting aspect of poetry and music too, is to navigate, to move in between
Language
I felt I was walking in a kind of new land
Blew. Blue.
...before night...
So lonely
Blew. Blue. Bloom is on the gold pinnacled hair
Listen! A spiked winding cold seahorn
01:58
Pno.
Hrp.
ff
gliss.
thunder glissando
53
02:06
Vc.
pizz.
02:09
fff
mp
is the mother of everything we are, we do, and we know
A spiked...
Listen!
Laboratory
and voice is an expression of language
Listen! A spiked winding cold seahorn
02:06
palm strike
02:09
Hrp.


02:20
pizz.
Vln.
mp
60
Vc.
of musical phonology
and the sighs of harps playing unto Love
to unclose the pale gates of sunrise
67
02:31
Vln.
Vc.
and the night wind answering in antiphon
A spiked winding cold silent
Spiked! Winding!
Bl-bl-bl-bl-bl-blooming blooming blooming
♩ = 85
02:56
Fl.
p
Ob.
mp
Blew. Blue.
Blew. Blue. Bloom is on the gold pinnacled hair
Blew. Blue.
'49...
With Circles,
Hisssssssss.
it's a milestone in vocal music
That's Cathy
♩ = 85
02:56
Hrp.
p


82
Fl.
Ob.
Vln.
Vc.
mp dolce
pp
pizz.
mf
... Cathy was looking for a pianist
parole
She had this incredible voice, and the versatility of
Voices they have their own history
I think this must be Lake Como, that might've been where they went on a honeymoon
Hrp.
rit.
a tempo
90
Fl.
Vln.
Vc.
not only her voice but of her mind was astonishing
She was extremely curious, and of course being
Can't put it in a box and close it like a violin
in
-
visiblya mong
rit.
a tempo
Hrp.

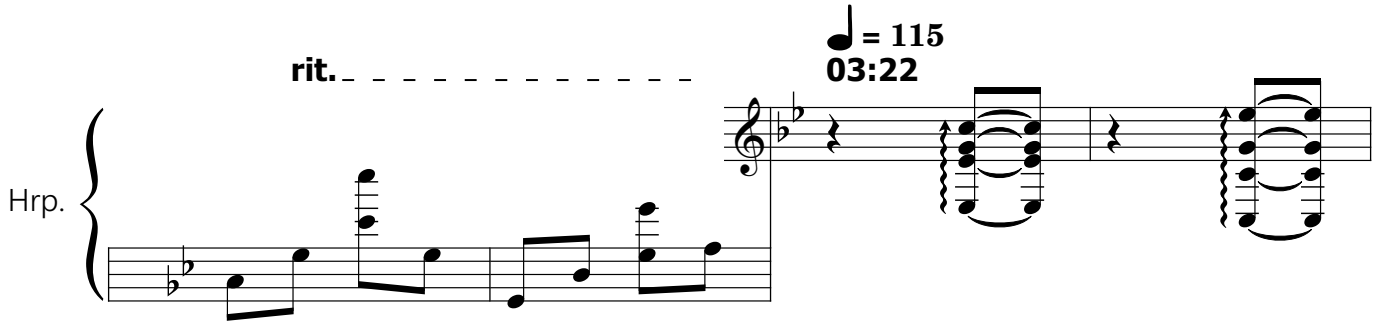


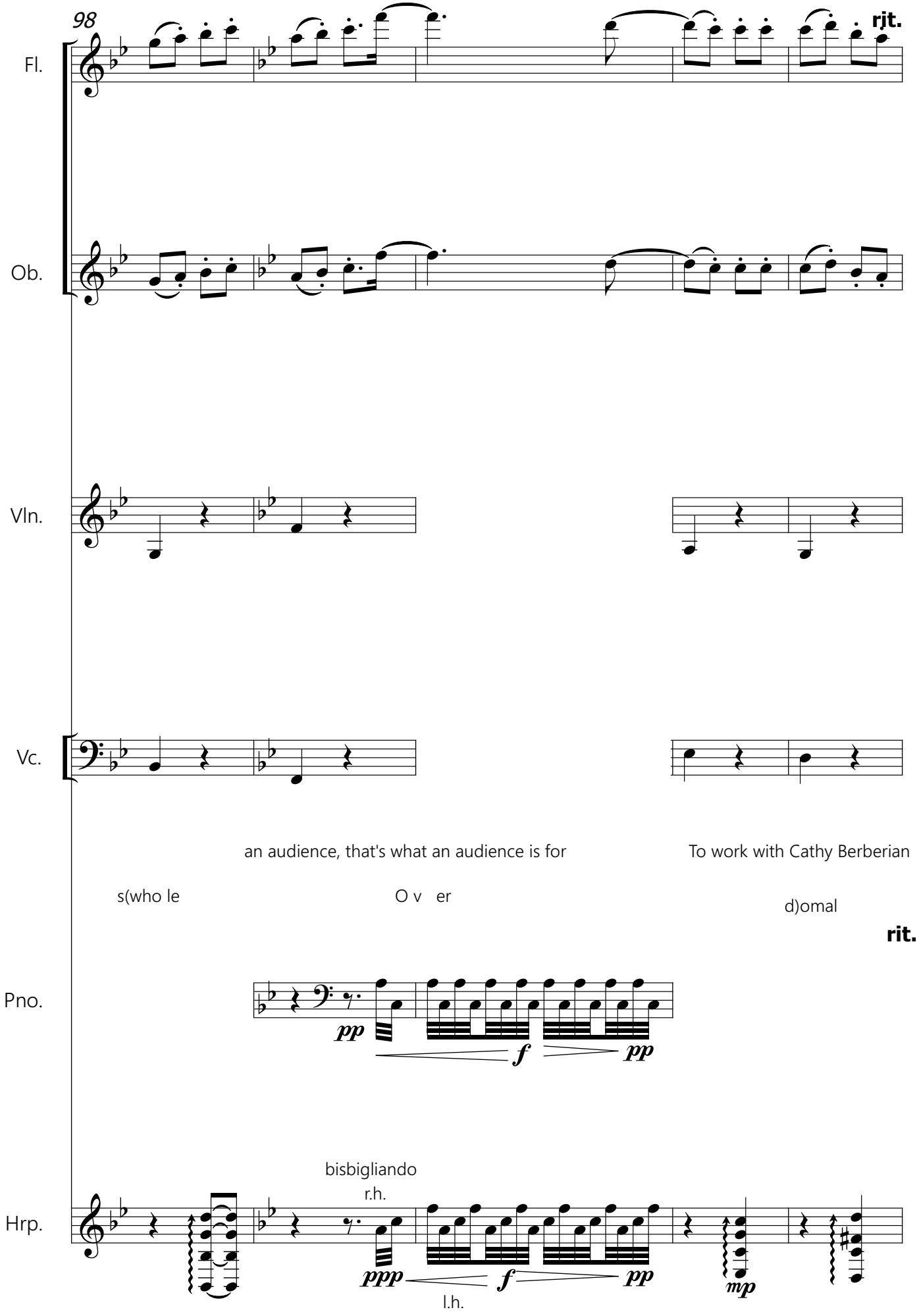
curious myself, we worked right together

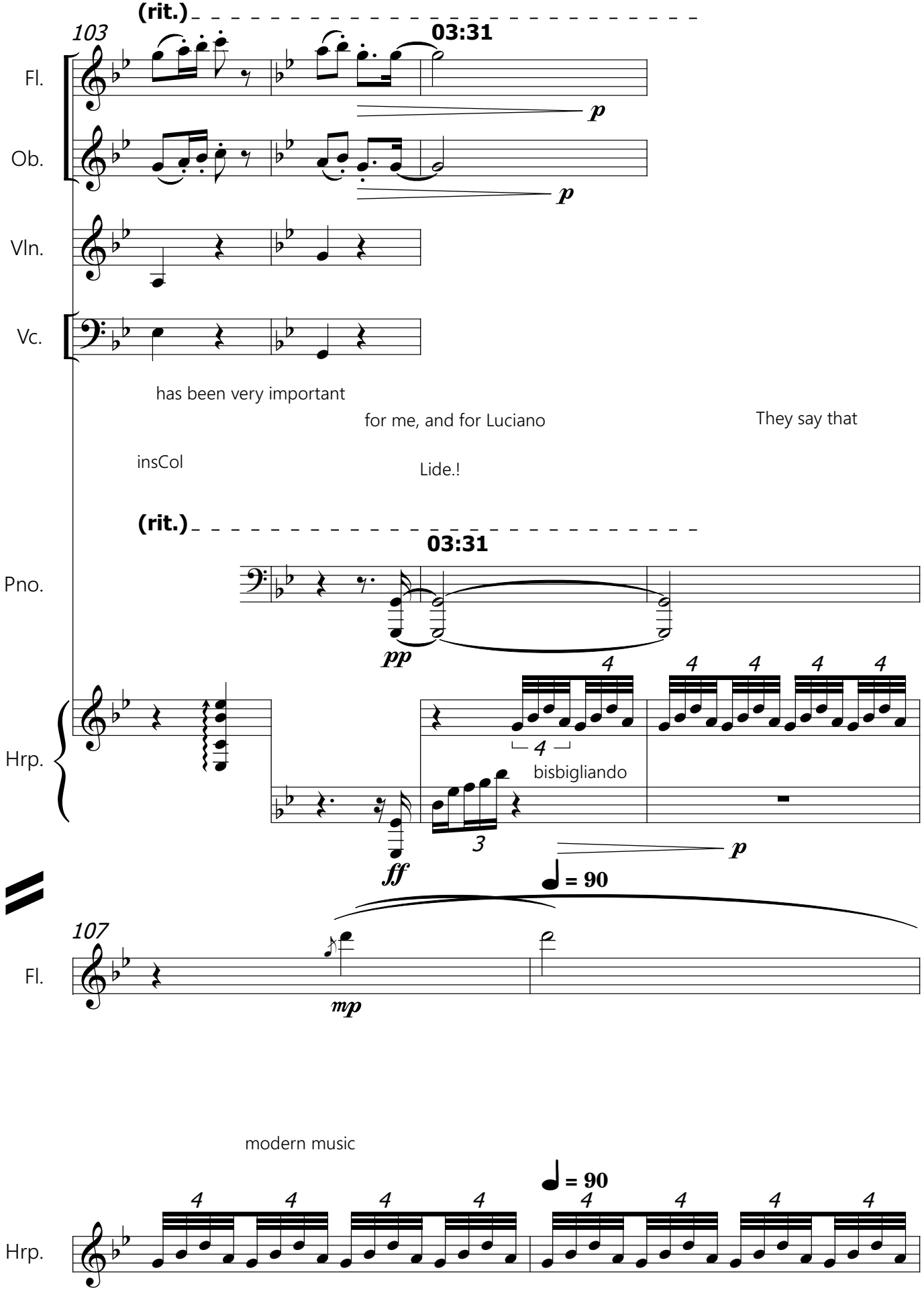
You always have to manipulate
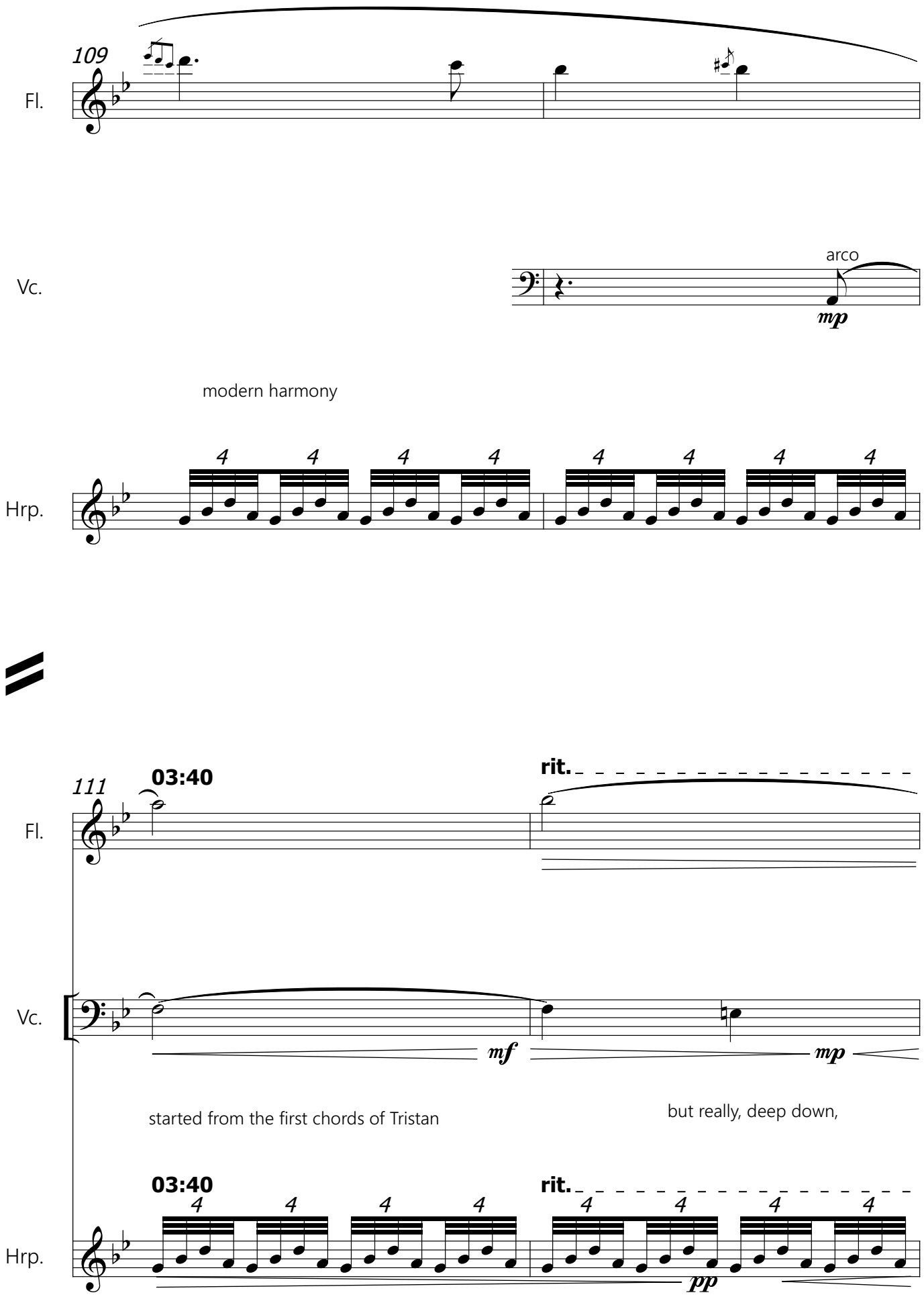
Am I boring you?

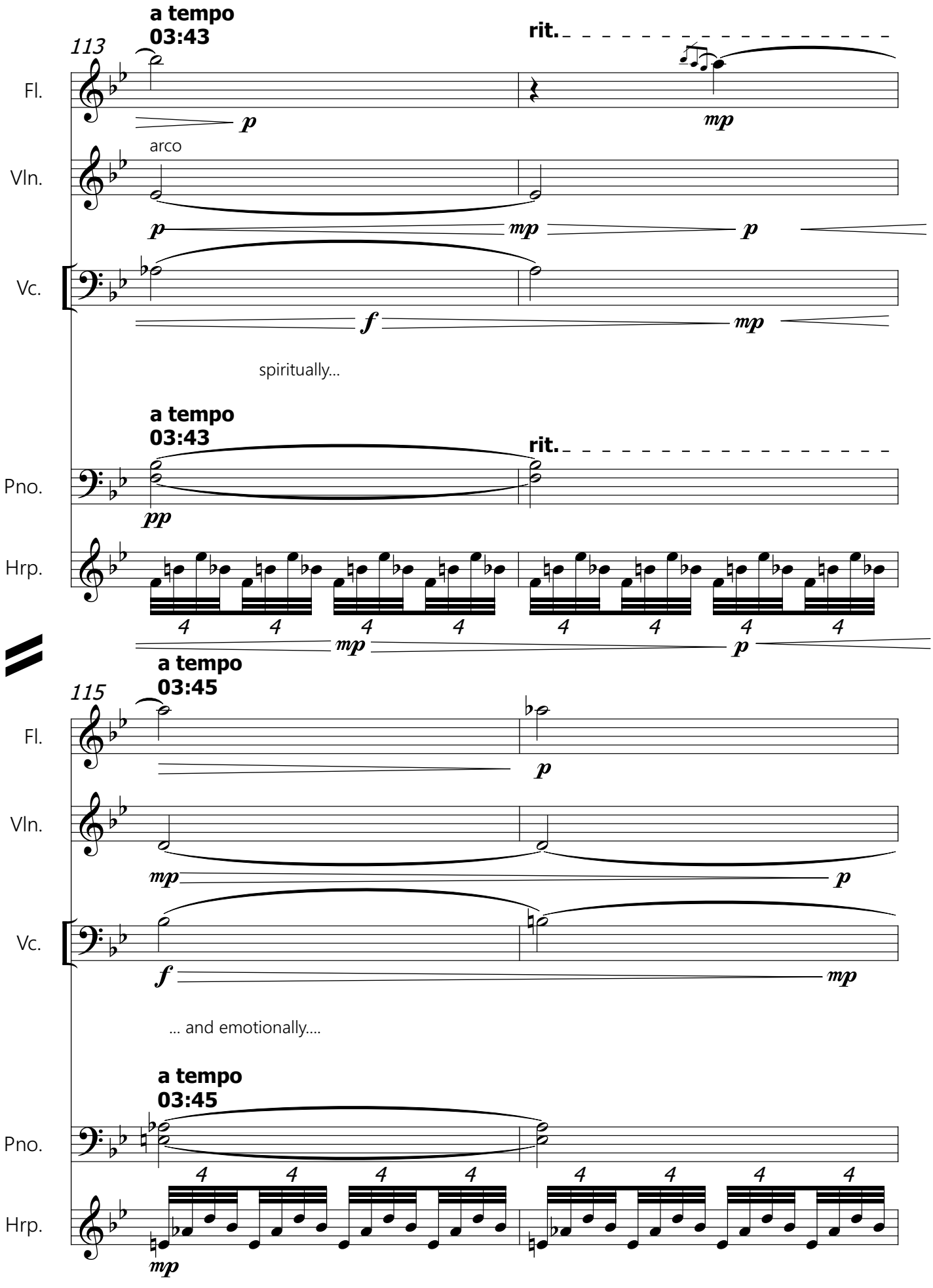
NessUn - rolli)ng yS troll
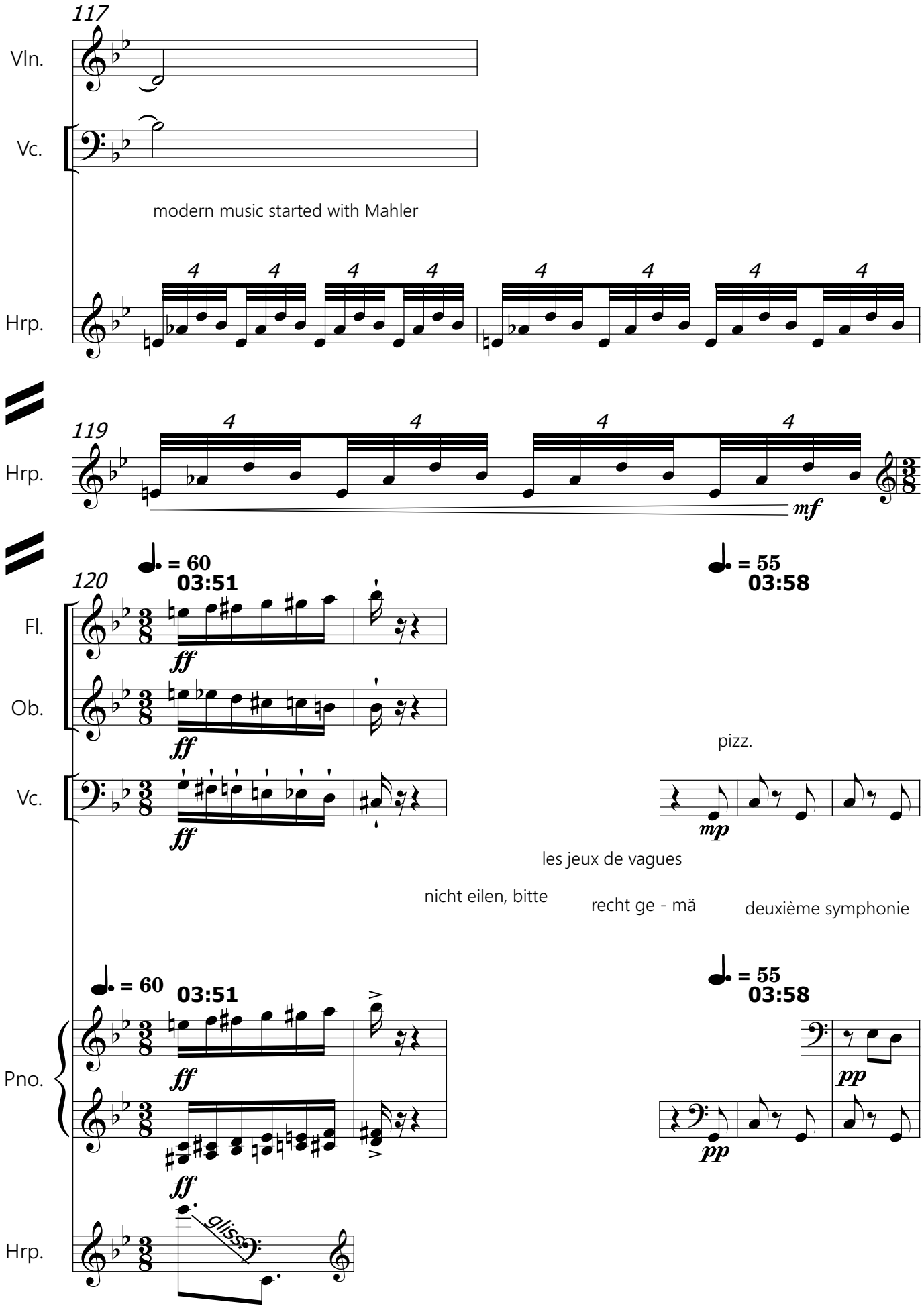


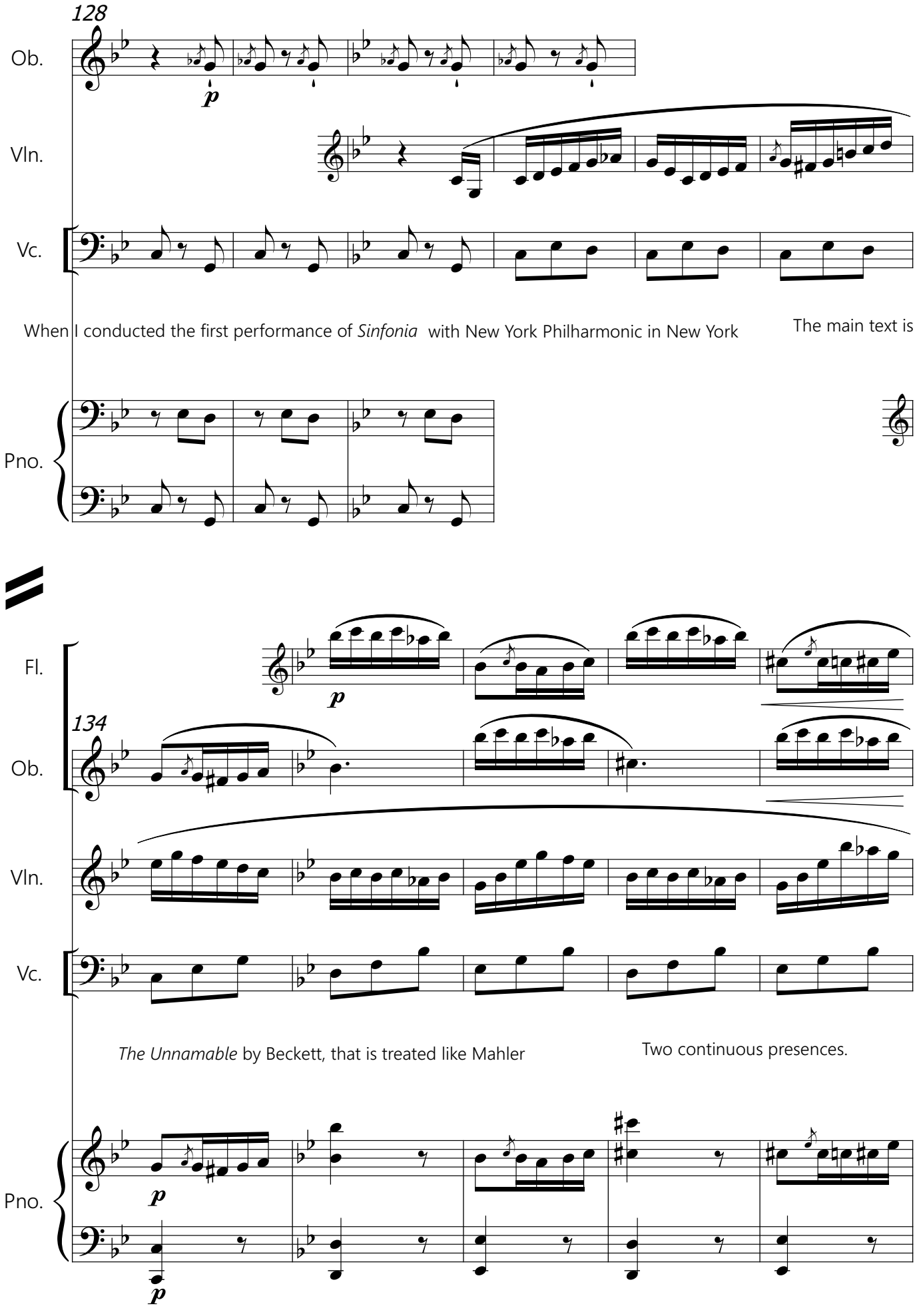

98
rit.
Fl.
Ob.
Vln.
Vc.
an audience, that's what an audience is for
To work with Cathy Berberian
s(who le
O v er
d)omal
rit.
Pno.
pp
f
pp
bisbigliando
r.h.
Hrp.
ppp
f
pp
mp
l.h.
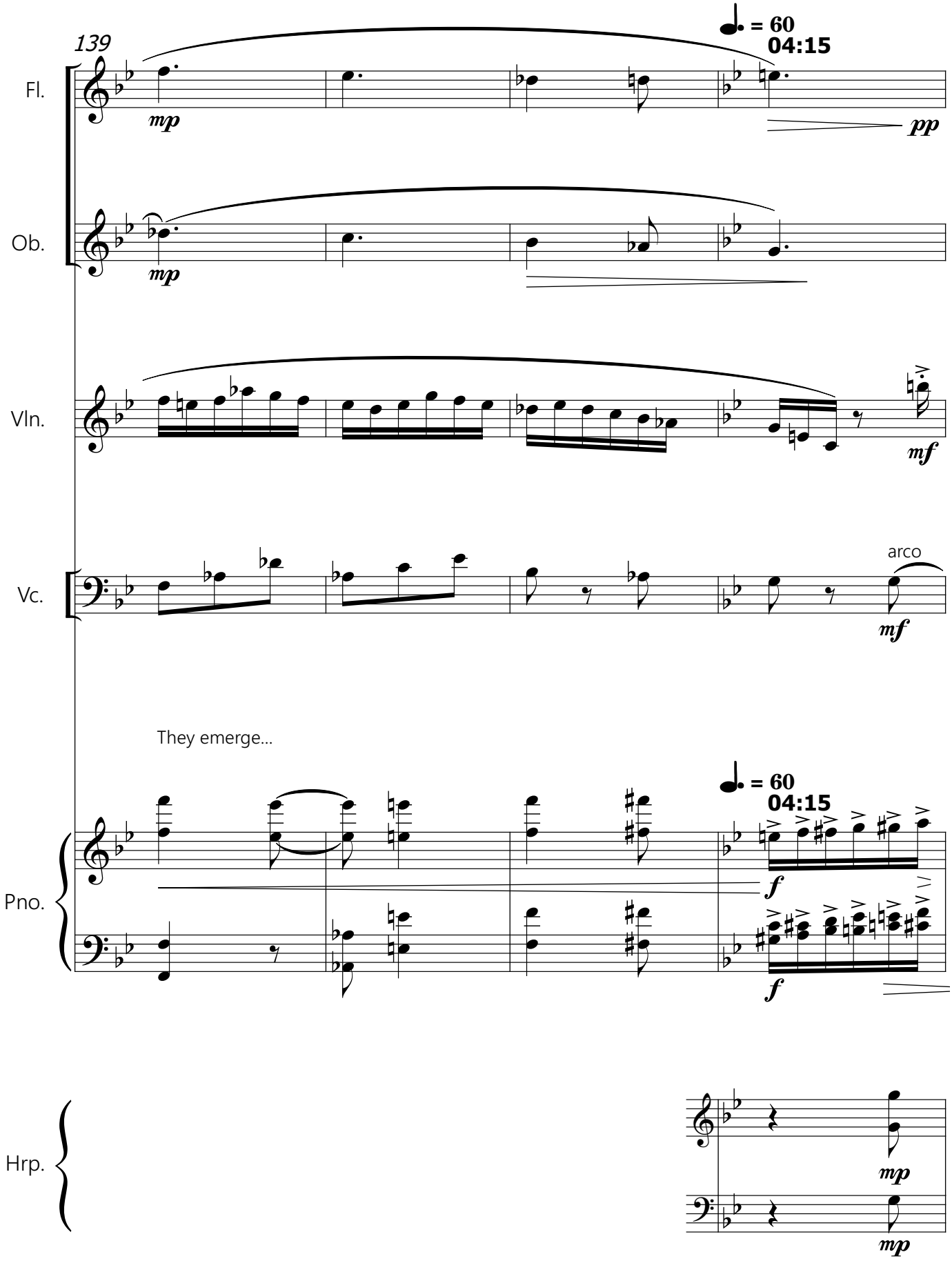

(rit.)
103
03:31
Fl.
Ob.
Vln.
Vc.
p
p
has been very important
for me, and for Luciano
They say that
insCol
Lide.!
(rit.)
03:31
Pno.
pp
Hrp.
4
4
4
4
4
4
bisbigliando
3
ff
p
= 90
107
Fl.
mp
modern music
= 90
Hrp.
4
4
4
4
4
4
4
4
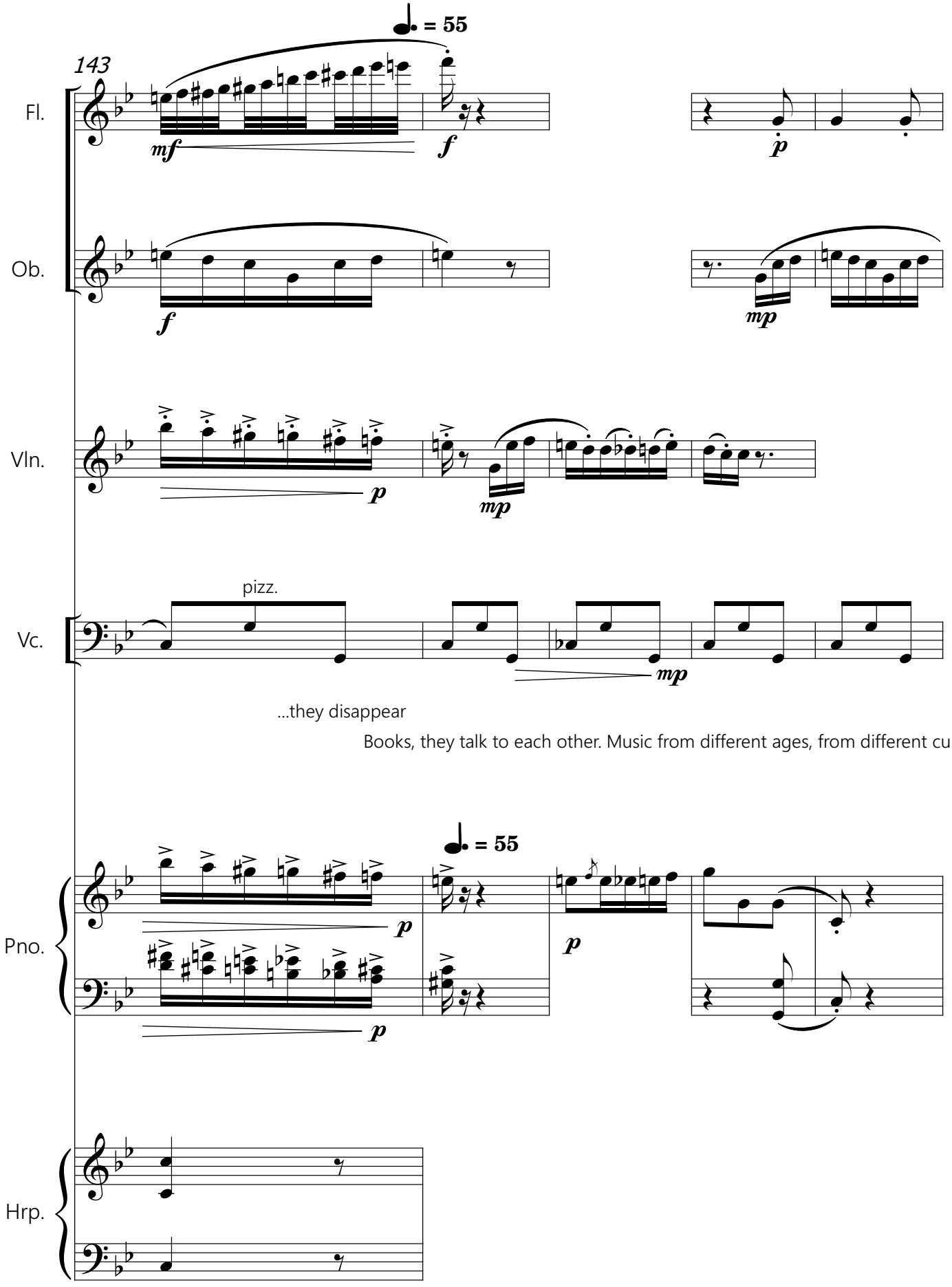

109
Fl.
Vc.
arco
mp
modern harmony
Hrp.
4 4 4 4 4 4 4 4
111
03:40
rit.
Fl.
Vc.
mf
mp
started from the first chords of Tristan
but really, deep down,
03:40
rit.
Hrp.
4 4 4 4 4 4 4 4
pp

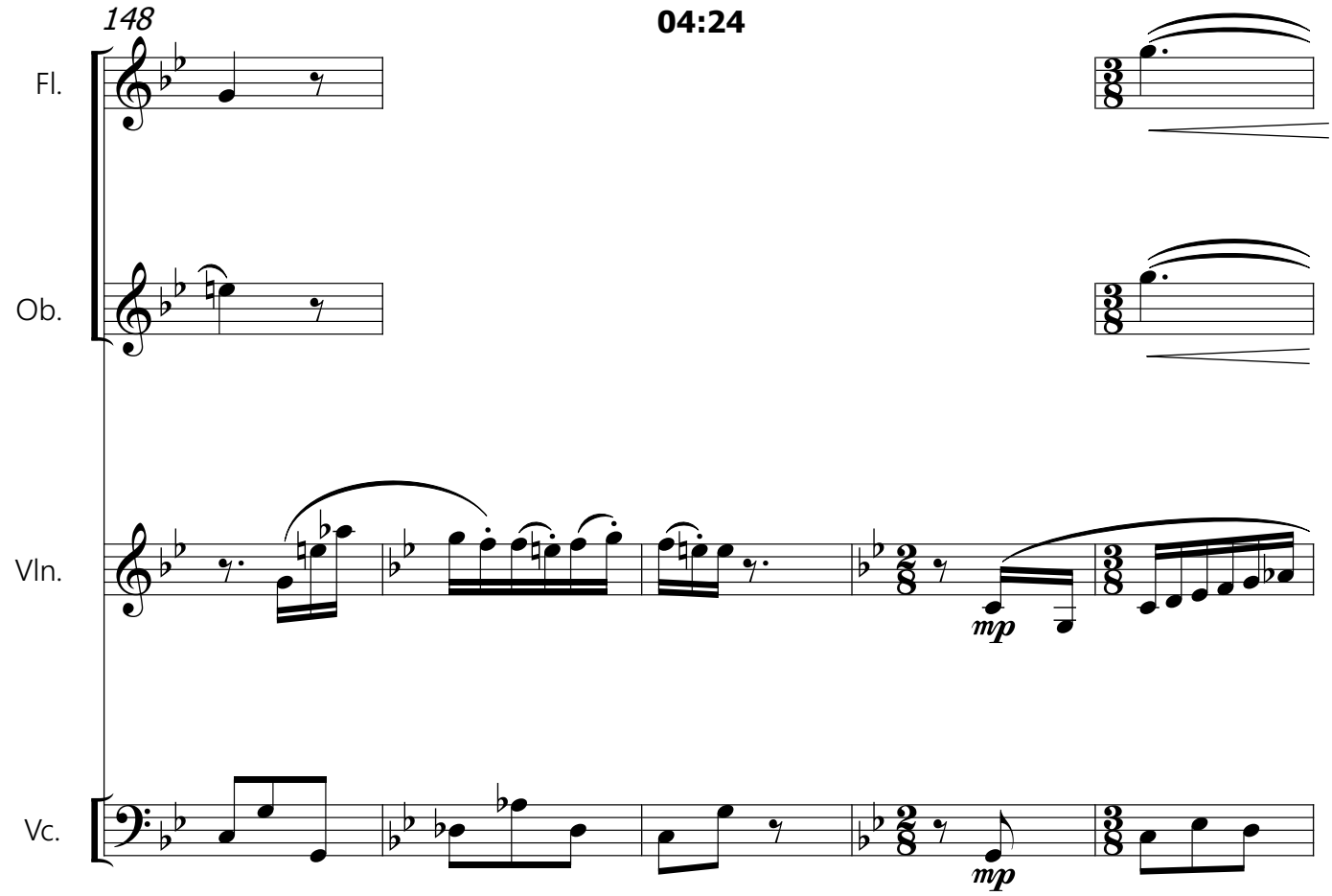

a tempo
03:43
113
rit.
Fl.
p
mp
arco
Vln.
p
mp
p
Vc.
f
mp
spiritually...
a tempo
03:43
rit.
Pno.
pp
Hrp.
4 4 4 4 4 4 4 4
mp
p
a tempo
03:45
115
Fl.
p
Vln.
mp
p
Vc.
f
mp
... and emotionally....
a tempo
03:45
Pno.
Hrp.
4 4 4 4 4 4 4 4
mp


117
Vln.
Vc.
modern music started with Mahler
Hrp.
119
Hrp.
mf
120
♩. = 60
03:51
♩. = 55
03:58
Fl.
Ob.
Vc.
ff
pizz.
mp
les jeux de vagues
nicht eilen, bitte
recht ge - mä
deuxième symphonie
Pno.
Hrp.
gliss.
pp


128
Ob.
Vln.
Vc.
When I conducted the first performance of *Sinfonia* with New York Philharmonic in New York
The main text is
Pno.
Fl.
134
Ob.
Vln.
Vc.
The Unnamable by Beckett, that is treated like Mahler
Two continuous presences.
Pno.


139
♩. = 60
04:15
Fl.
mp
pp
Ob.
mp
Vln.
mf
Vc.
arco
mf
They emerge...
Pno.
♩. = 60
04:15
f
f
Hrp.
mp
mp
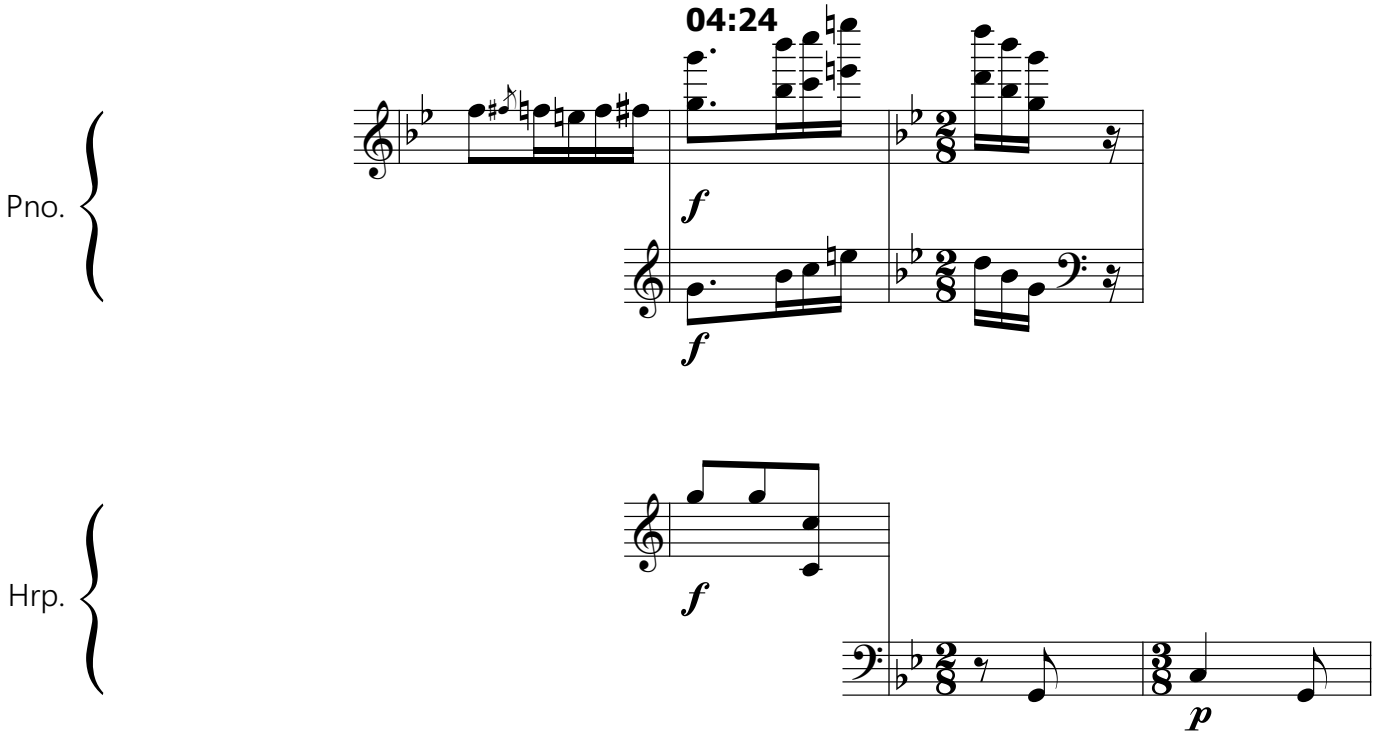

143
♩. = 55
Fl.
mf
f
p
Ob.
f
mp
Vln.
p
mp
Vc.
pizz.
mp
...they disappear
Books, they talk to each other. Music from different ages, from different cultures,
♩. = 55
Pno.
p
p
p
Hrp.

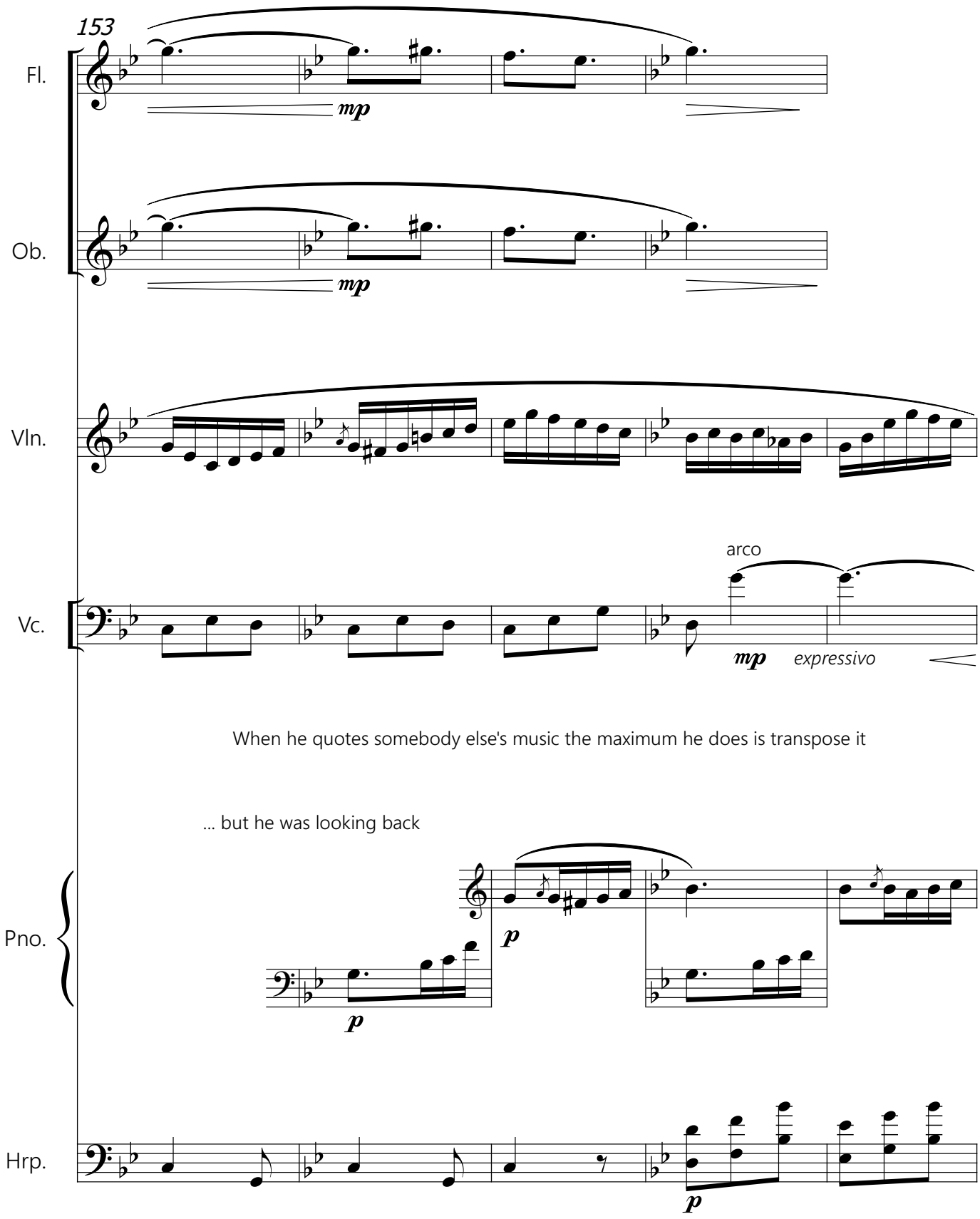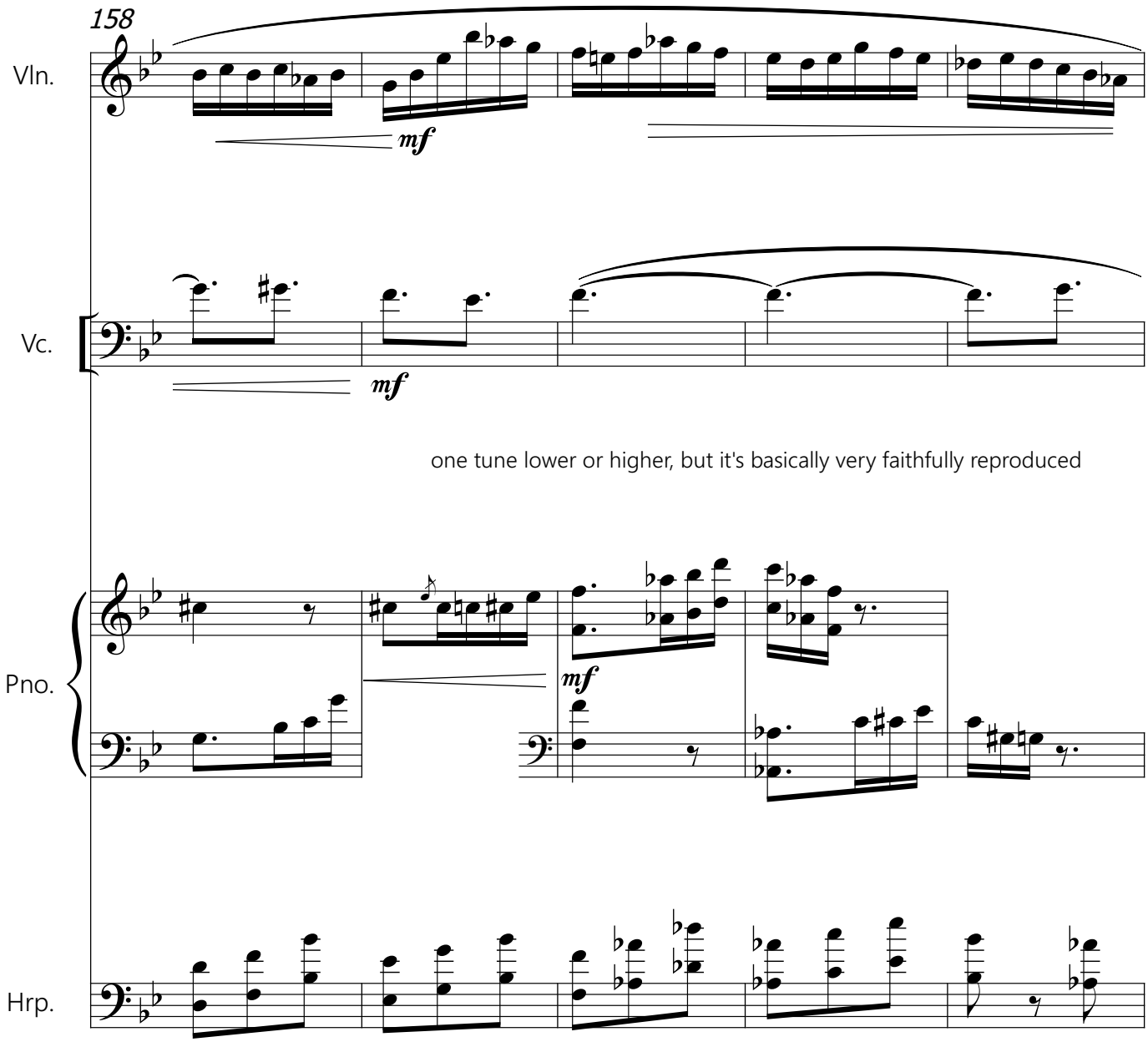


they talk to each other.
Trying to find relation between different, almost heterogeneous things

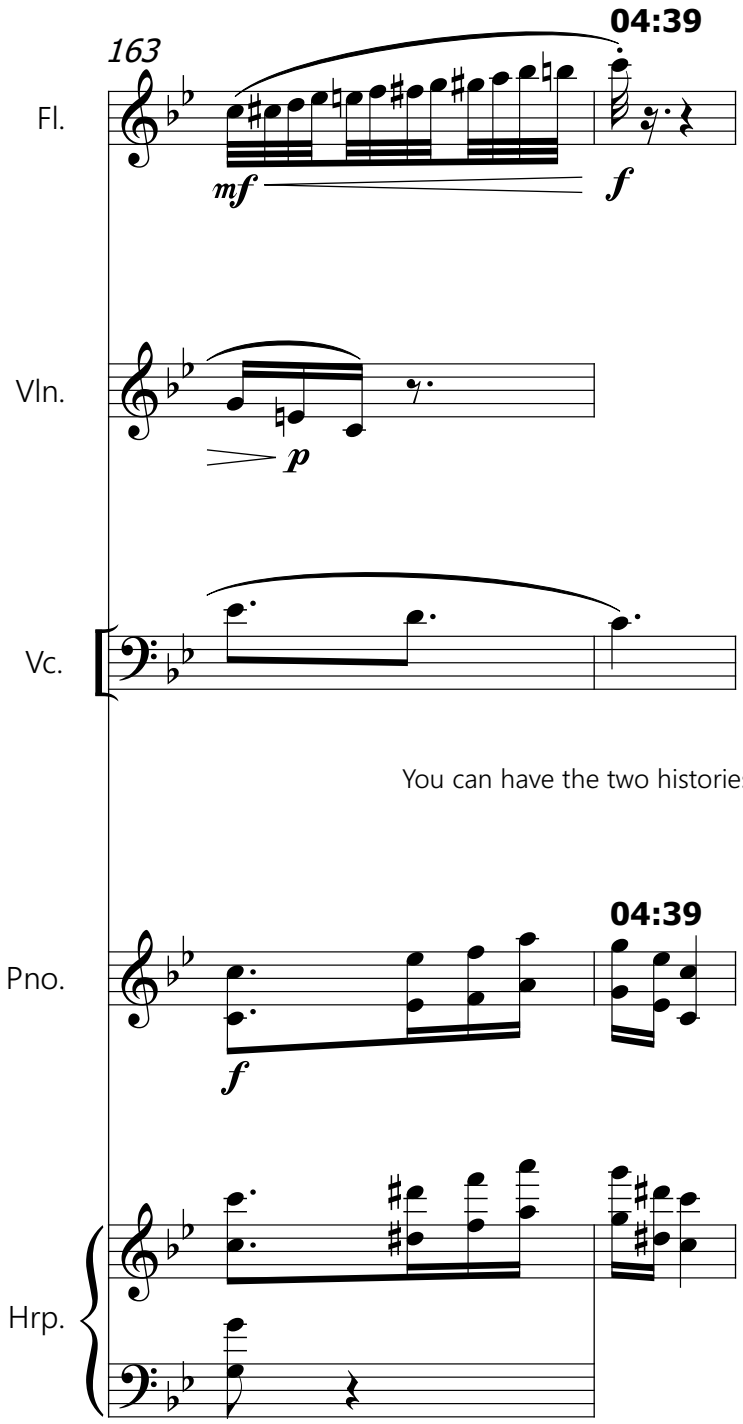
...instruments too.

To go further...
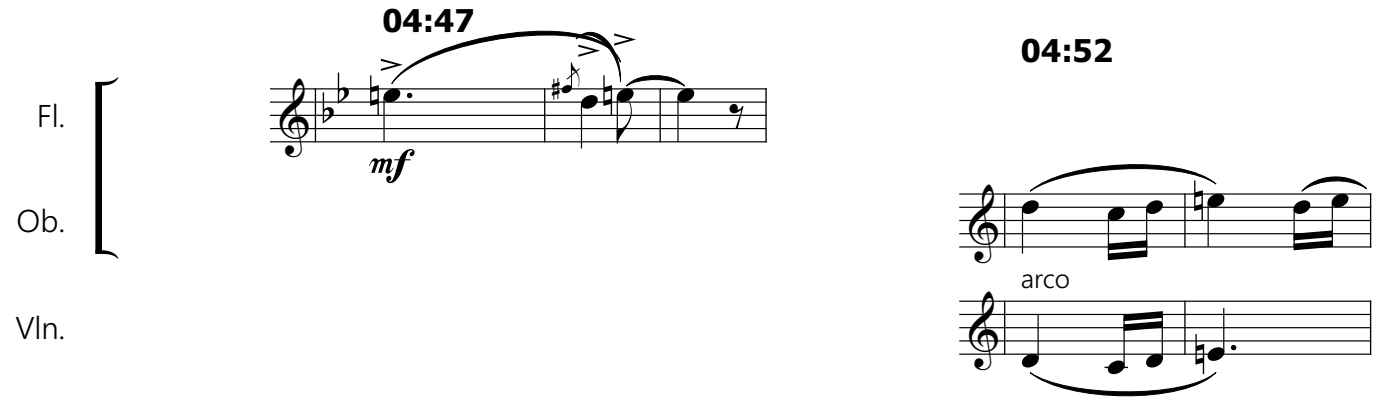



153
Fl.
mp
Ob.
mp
Vln.
Vc.
arco
mp
expressivo
When he quotes somebody else's music the maximum he does is transpose it
... but he was looking back
Pno.
p
p
Hrp.
p


158
Vln.
mf
Vc.
mf
one tune lower or higher, but it's basically very faithfully reproduced
Pno.
mf
Hrp.
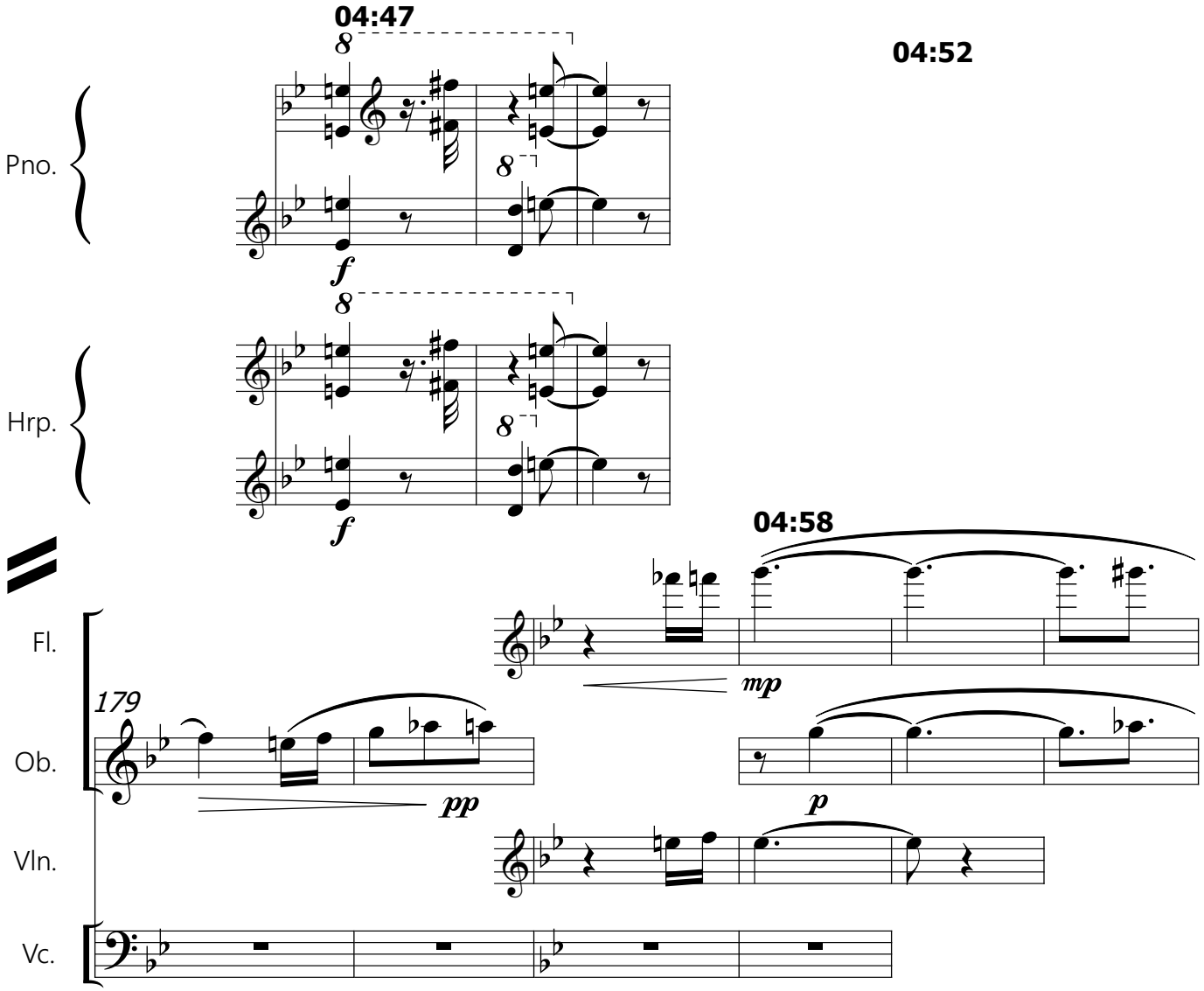


You can have the two histories talk to each other, comment to each other

Since I have a great respect for history



He went through incredible stages.
Keep going!

He started with full symphony orchestra, finally ended with four pianos
Here is the first sketch of *Les Noces* which
three thousand notes



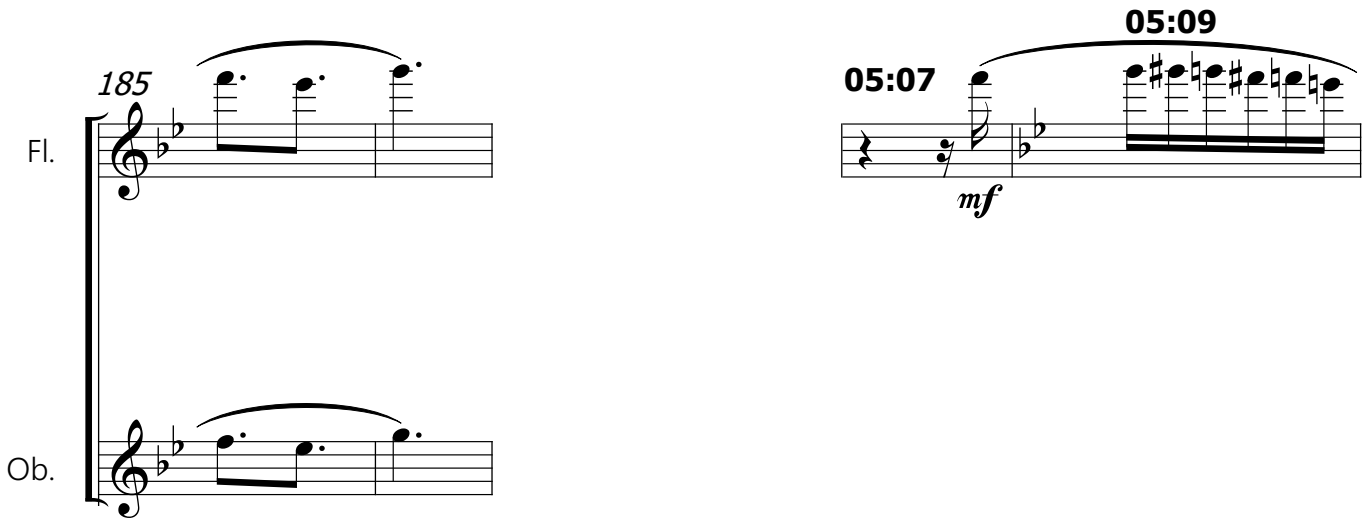
and percussion but he went through a series of transcriptions of the same idea.

is dated 1913

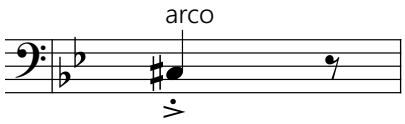
Mais nous essayons par ce passé tel

I may well be glad of them

Keep going!
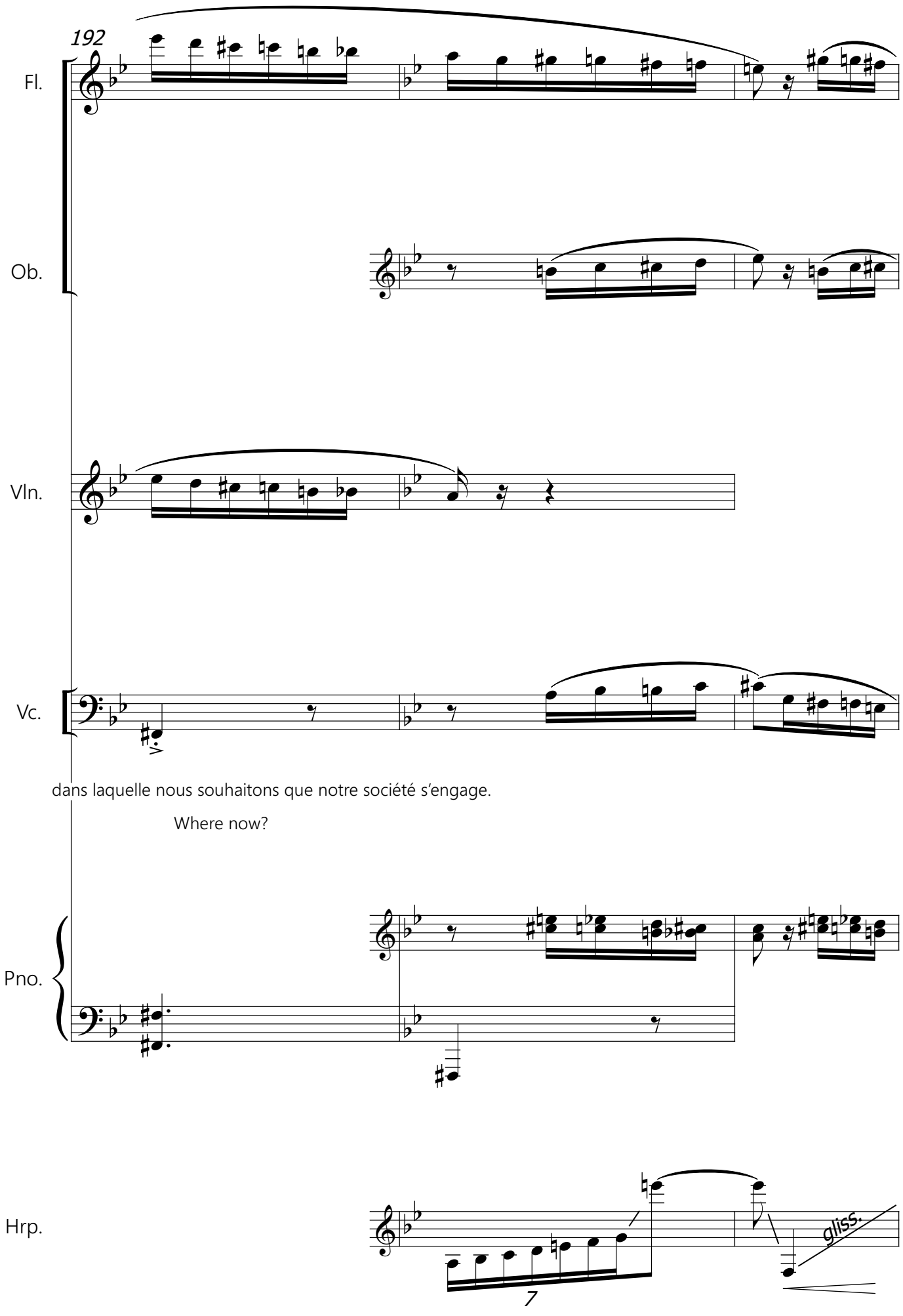






et de la direction
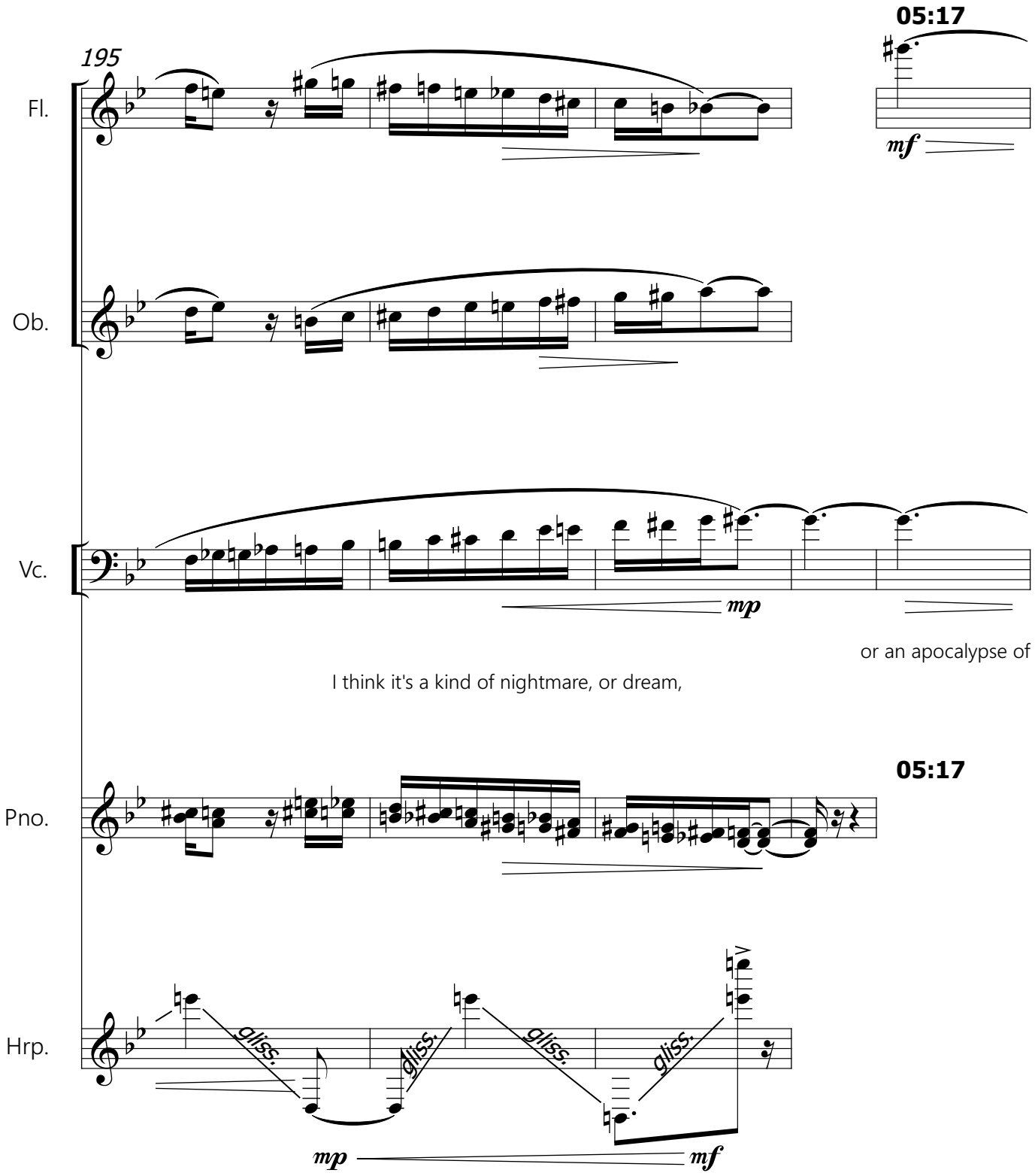
que nous l'imaginons de rendre compte de notre présent
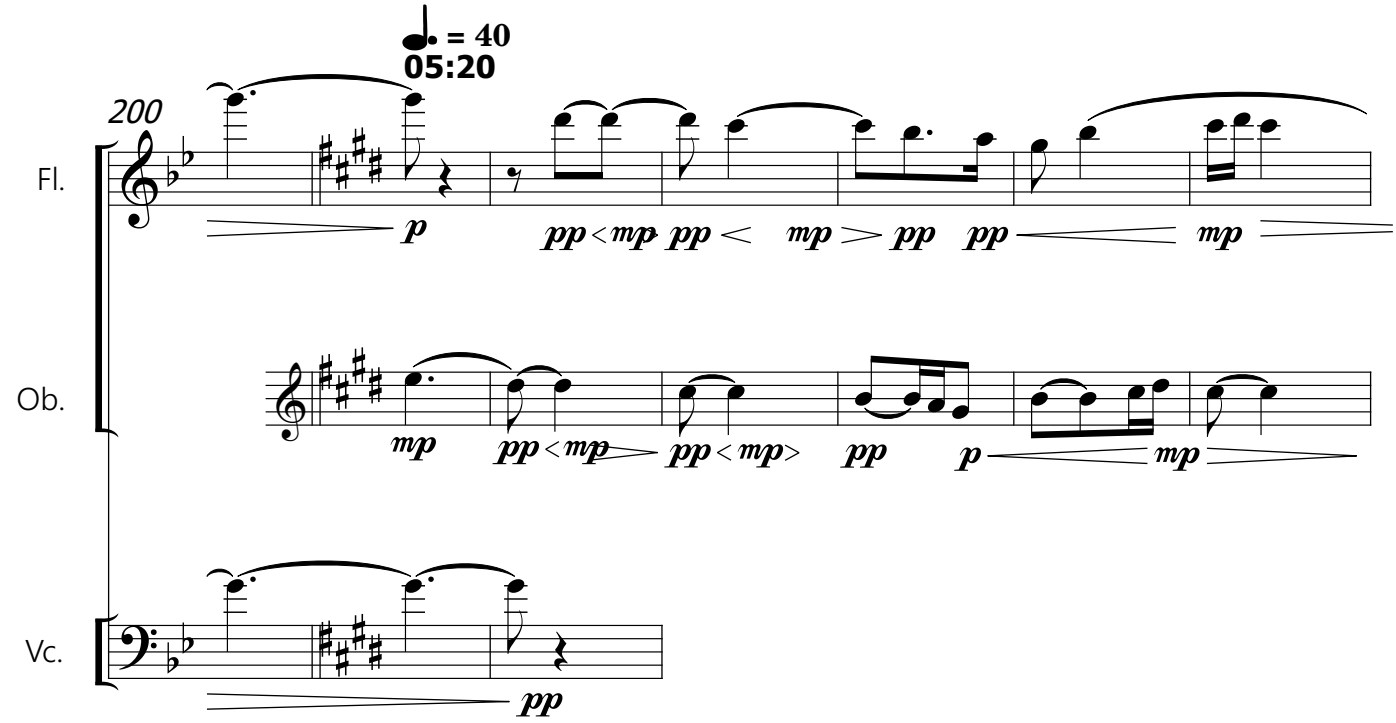
the obsession
the obsession

with the chromatic

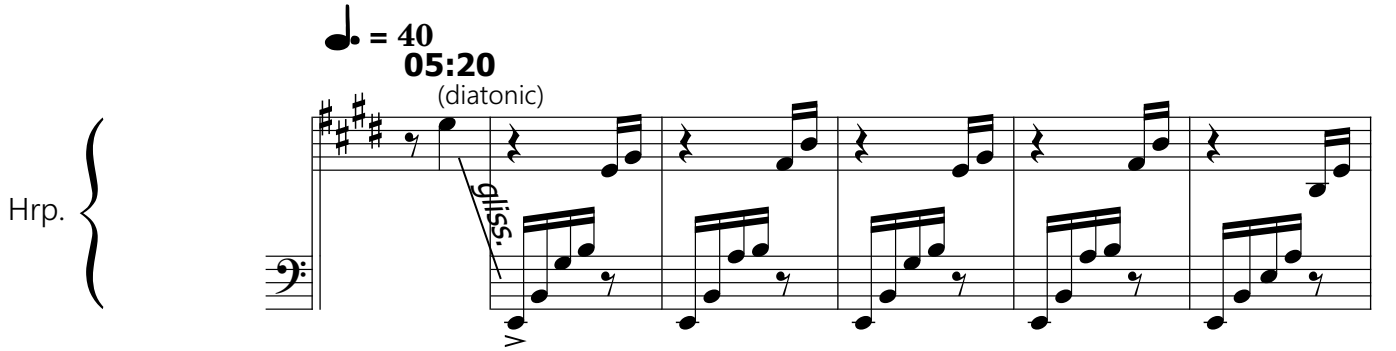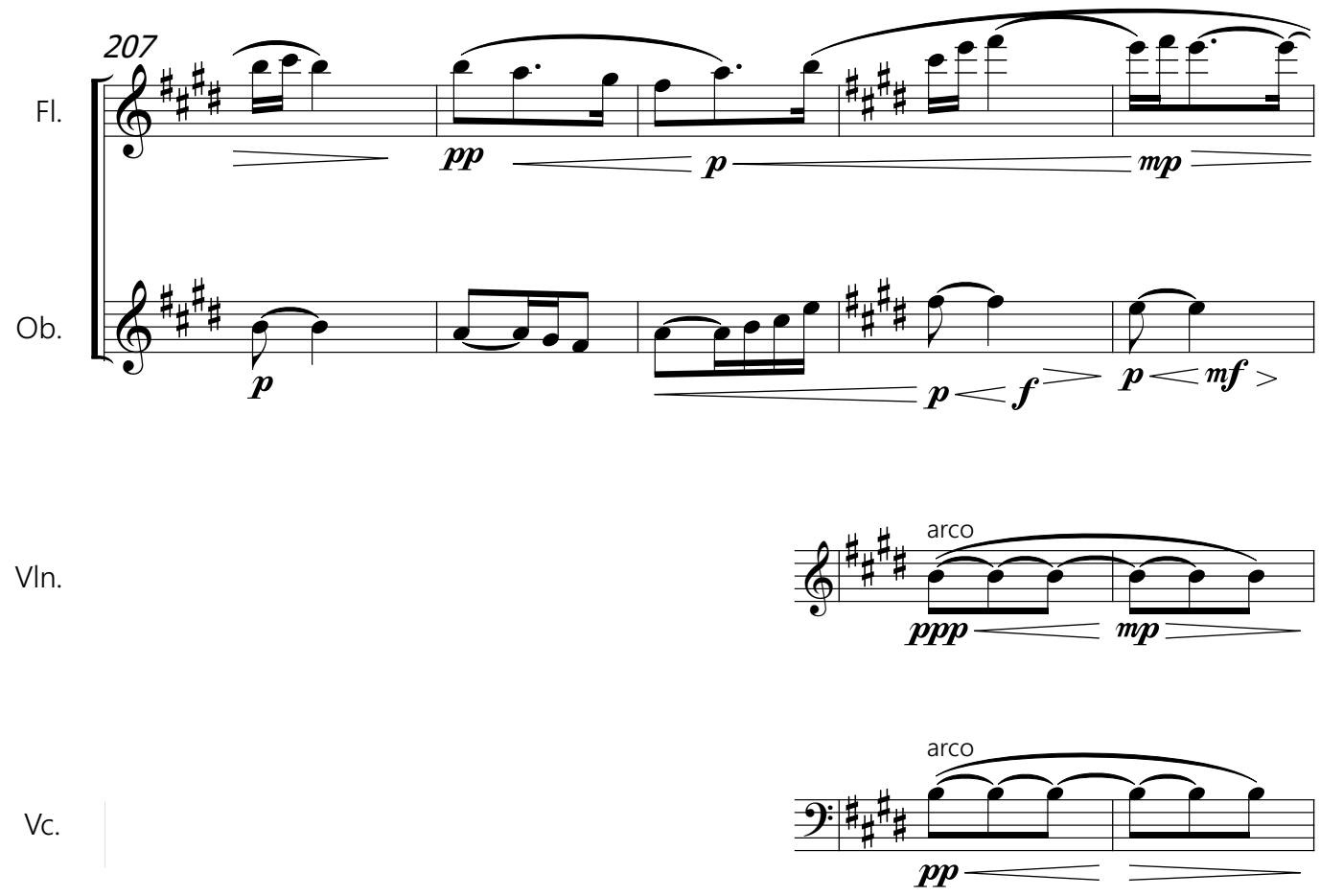



192
Fl.
Ob.
Vln.
Vc.
dans laquelle nous souhaitons que notre société s'engage.
Where now?
Pno.
Hrp.
gliss.
7


05:17
195
Fl.
mf
Ob.
Vc.
mp
or an apocalypse of
I think it's a kind of nightmare, or dream,
05:17
Pno.
Hrp.
gliss.
gliss.
gliss.
gliss.
mp
mf

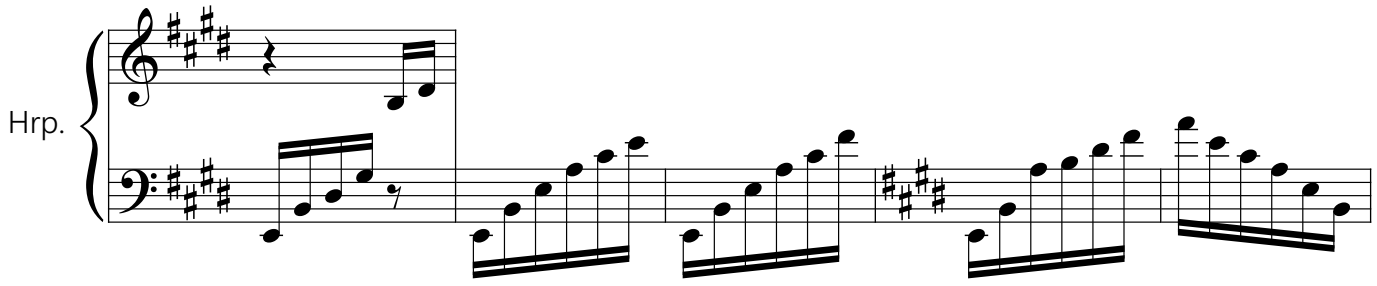


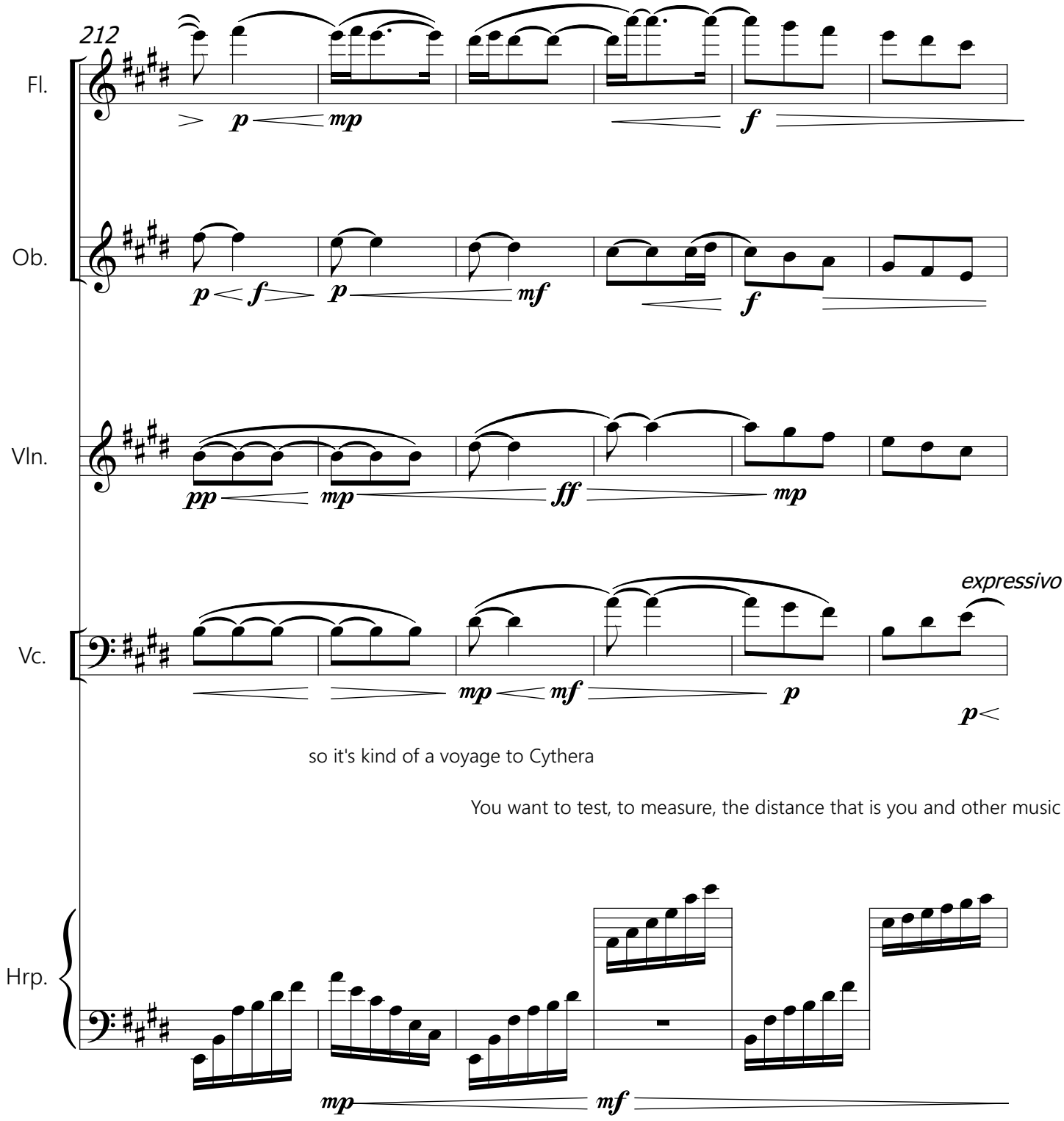
sentimentality, of emotions, which go through those quotations So, Mahler

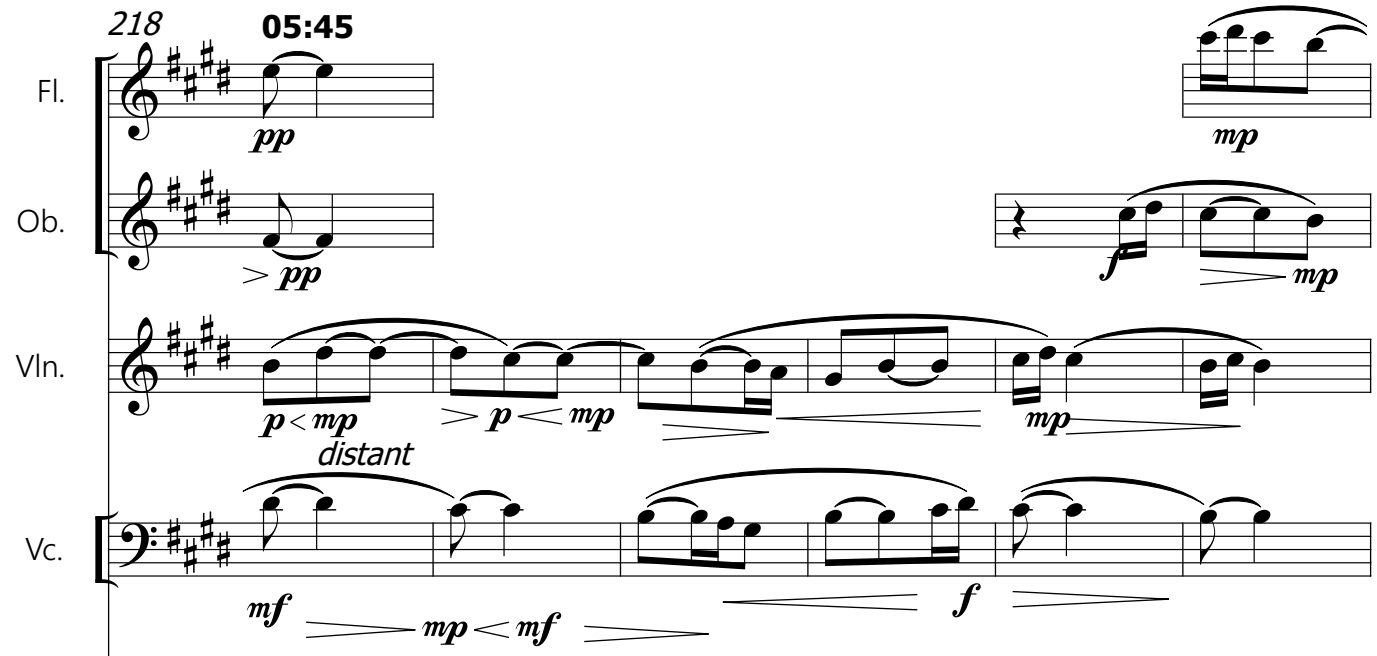




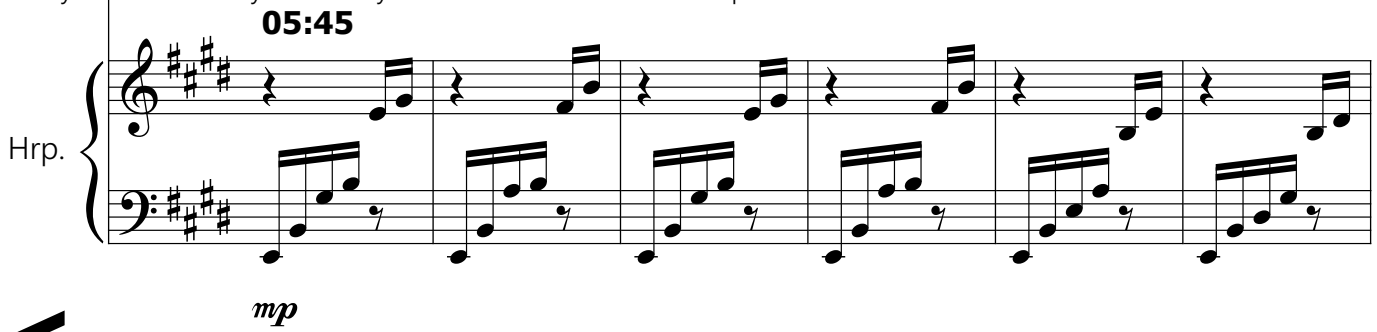
is this ship, travelling, a boat full of beautiful things and beautiful people and gifts and so on...

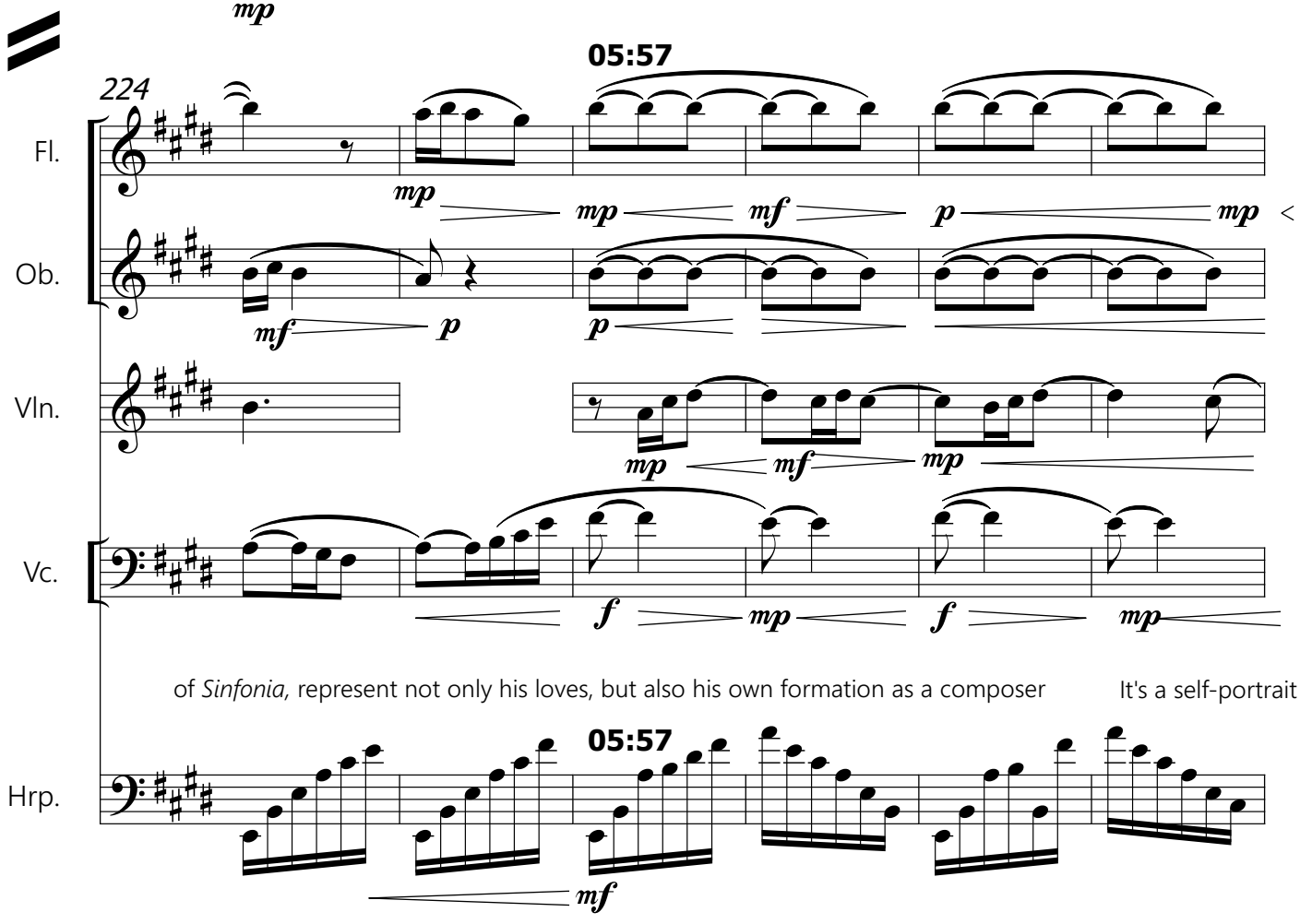



212
Fl.
Ob.
Vln.
Vc.
expressivo
so it's kind of a voyage to Cythera
You want to test, to measure, the distance that is you and other music
Hrp.

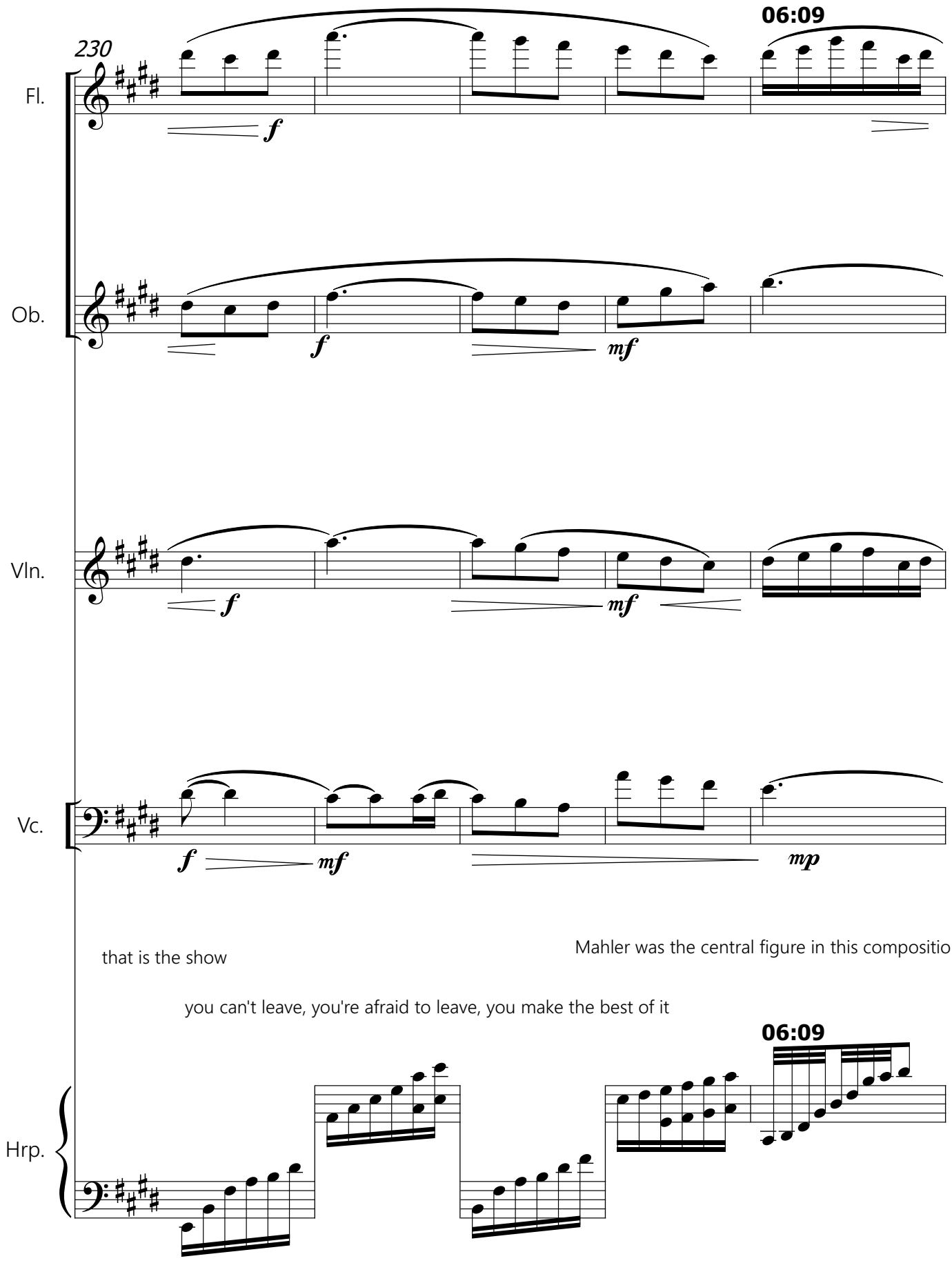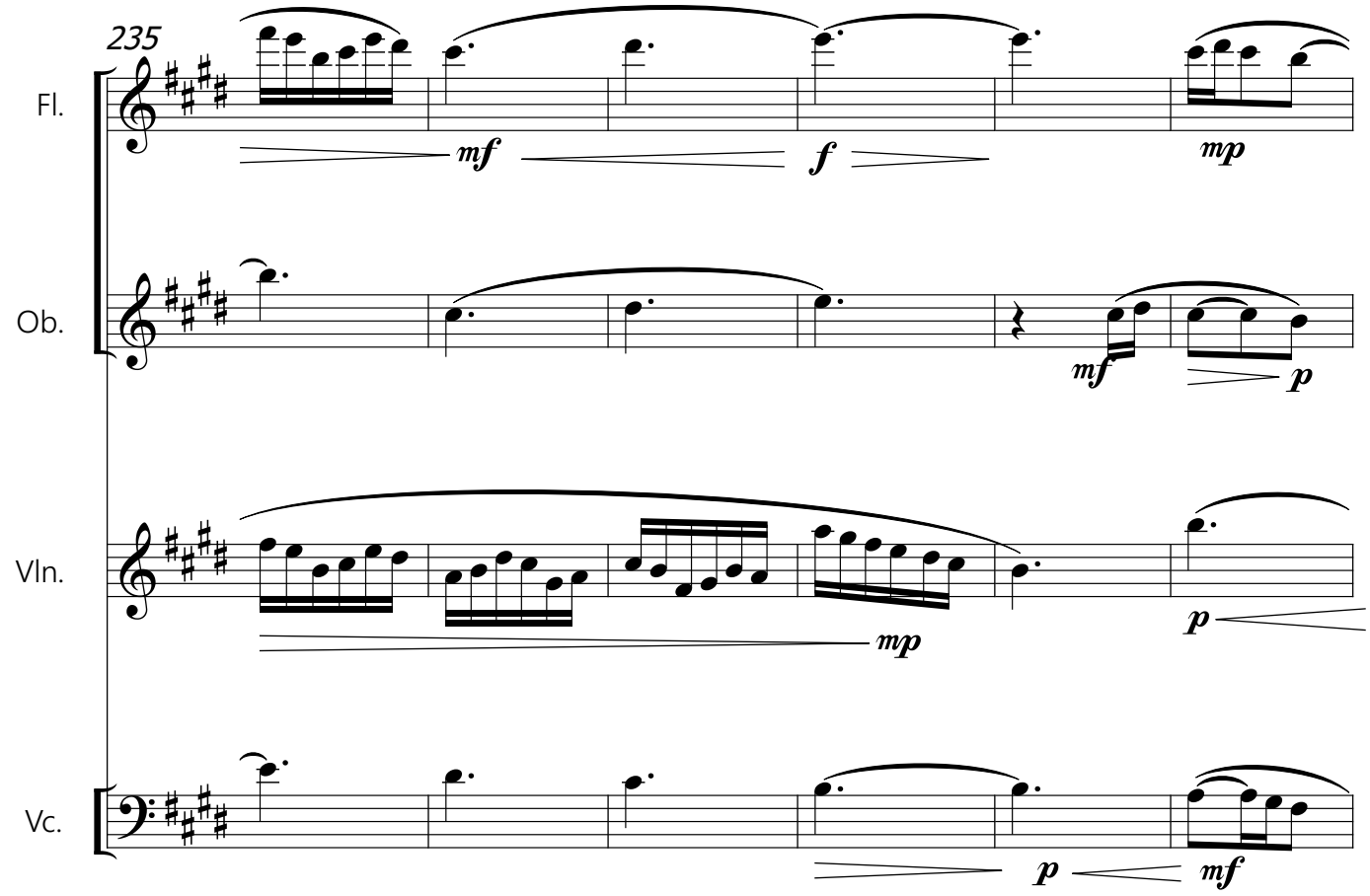


If you look carefully at the way Luciano used the fifteen composers which form this *unicum* which is the third movement





of *Sinfonia*, represent not only his loves, but also his own formation as a composer It's a self-portrait


06:09
230
Fl.
Ob.
Vln.
Vc.
Hrp.
f
mf
mp
that is the show
Mahler was the central figure in this composition,
you can't leave, you're afraid to leave, you make the best of it
06:09

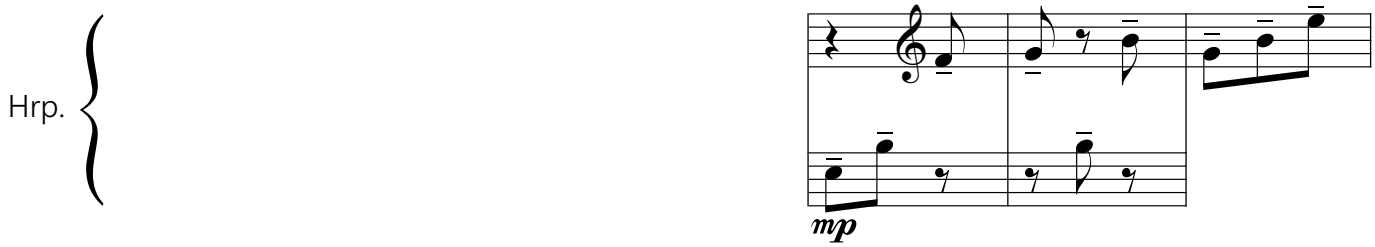


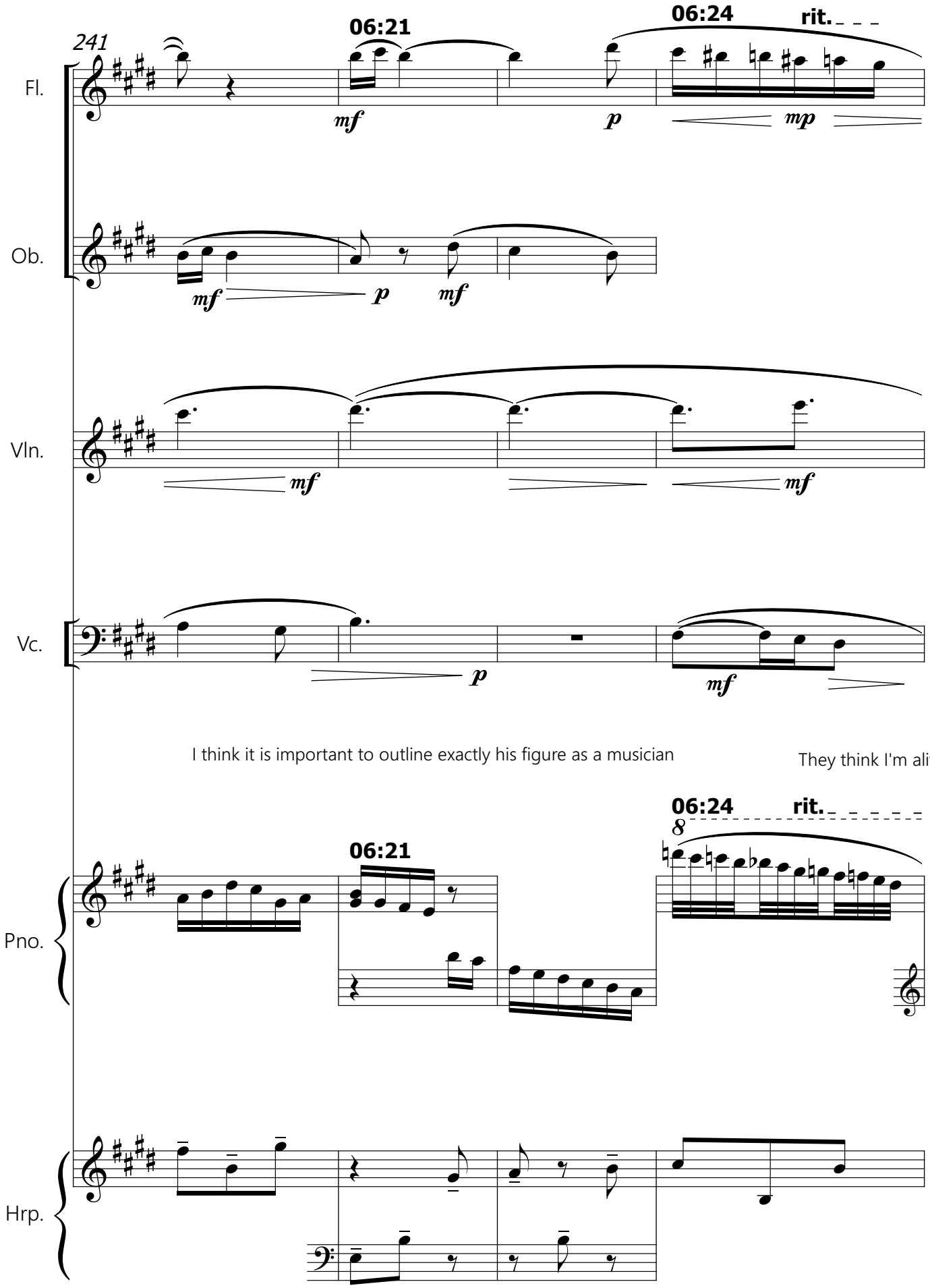
as he was in Berio's life, one of the major points of reference
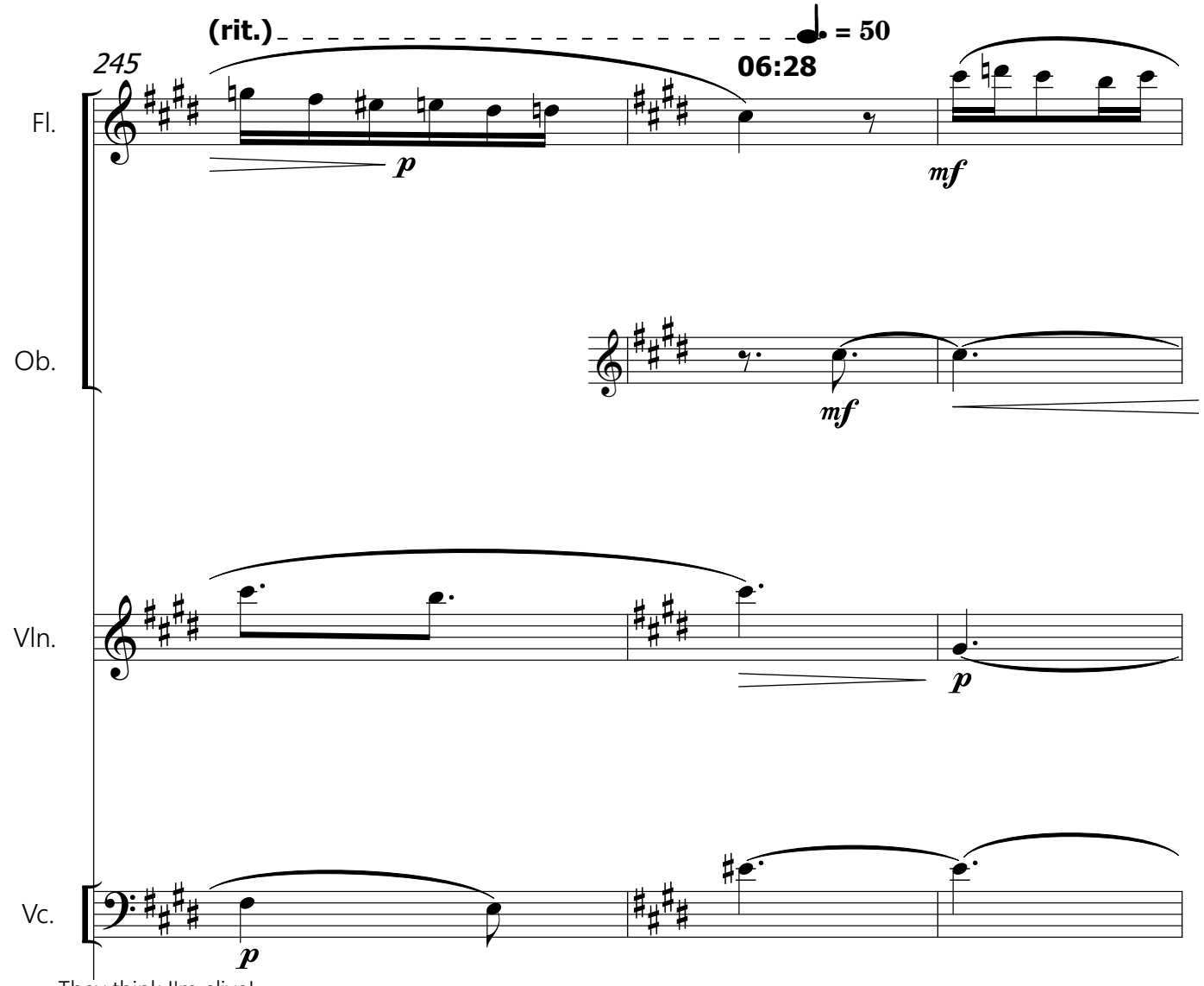
that is the show

To find unity among very different things



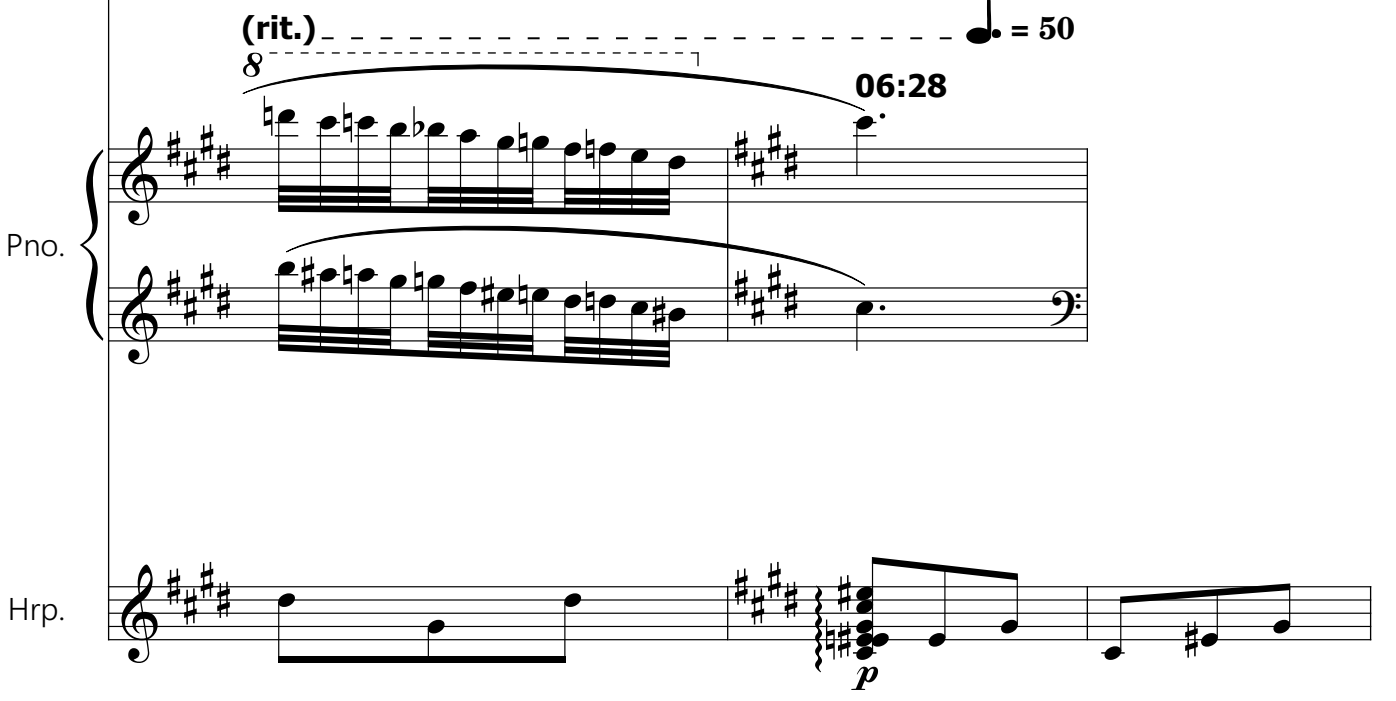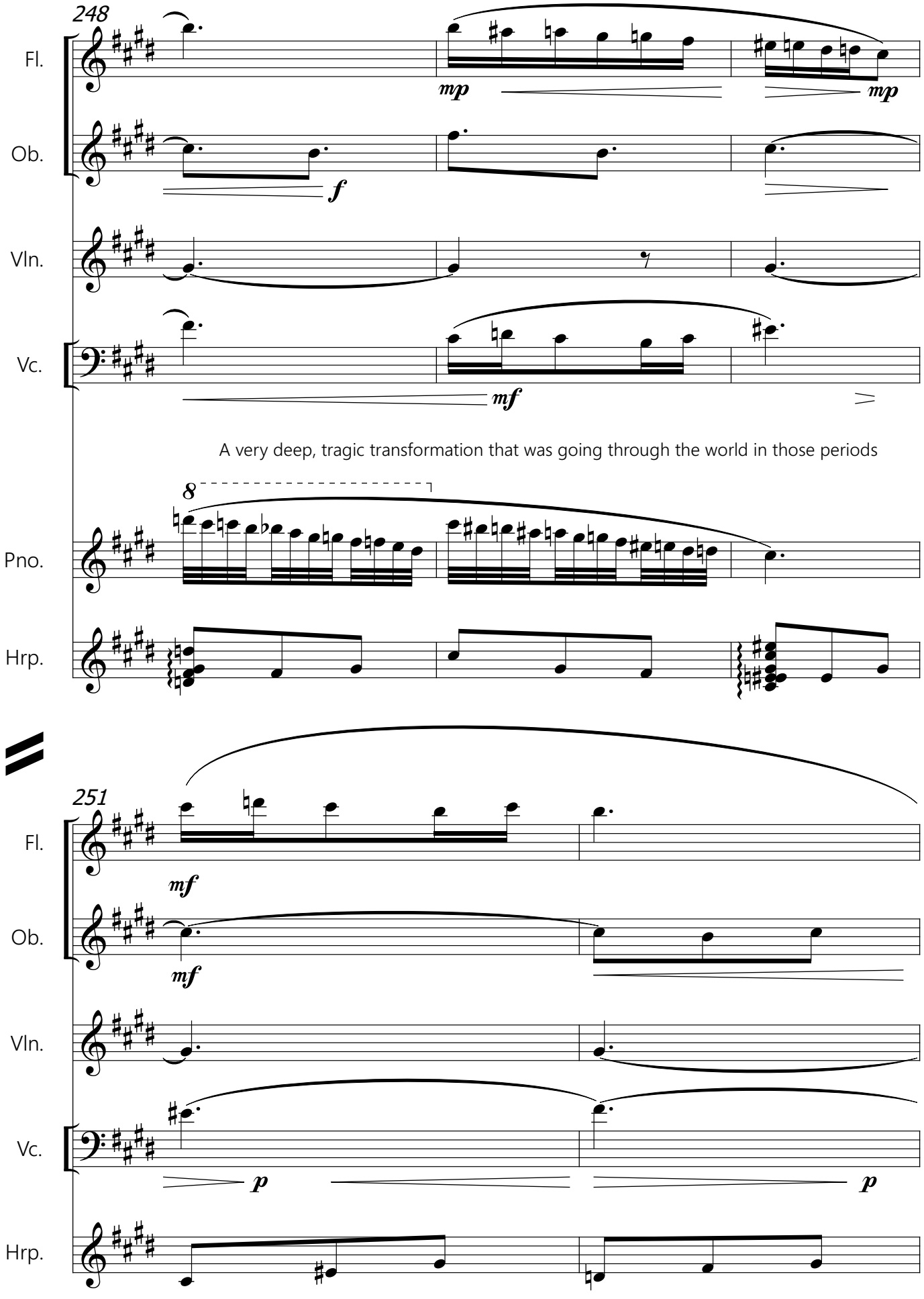



241
06:21
06:24
rit.
Fl.
Ob.
Vln.
Vc.
I think it is important to outline exactly his figure as a musician
They think I'm alive!
Pno.
Hrp.
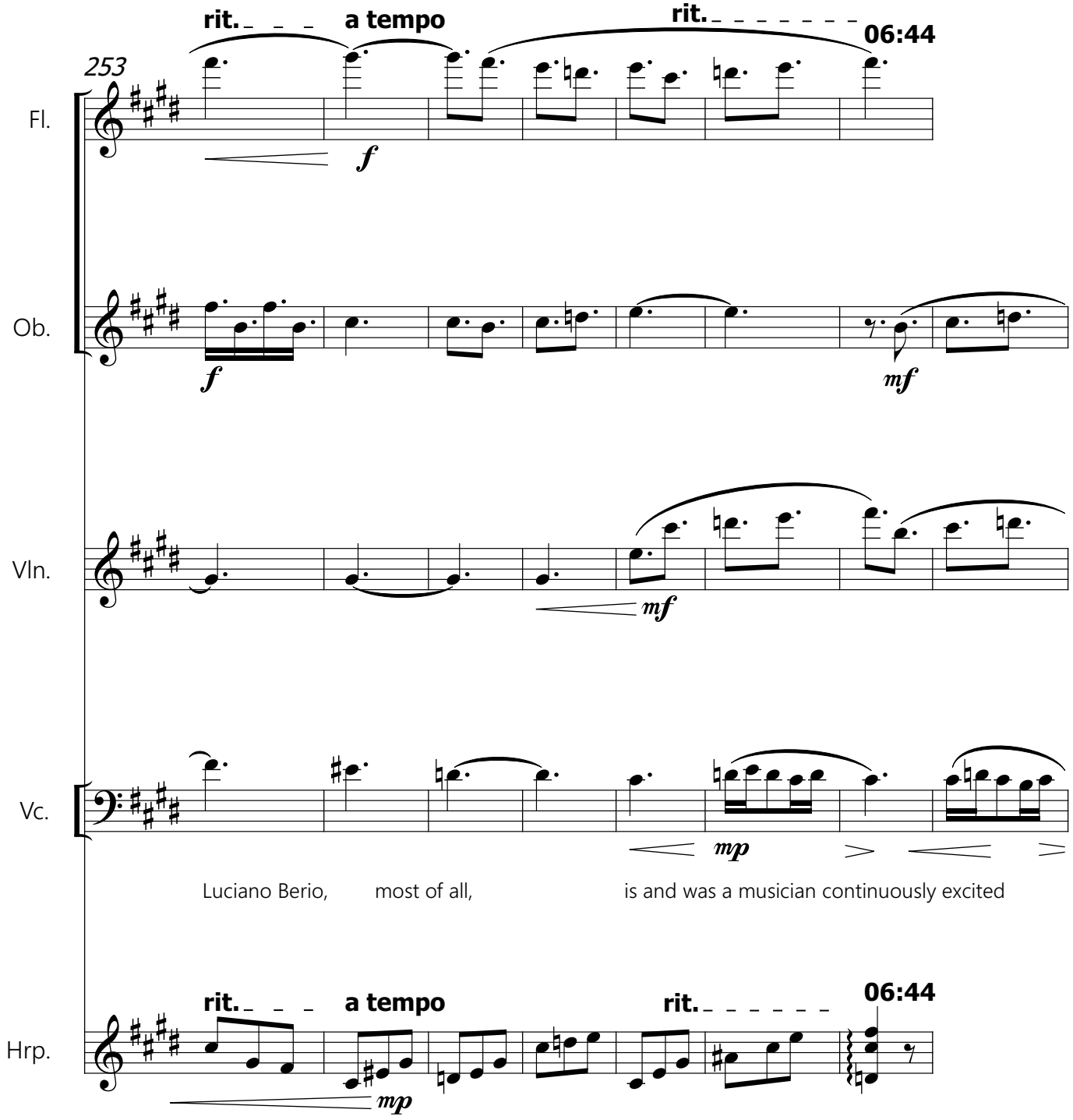


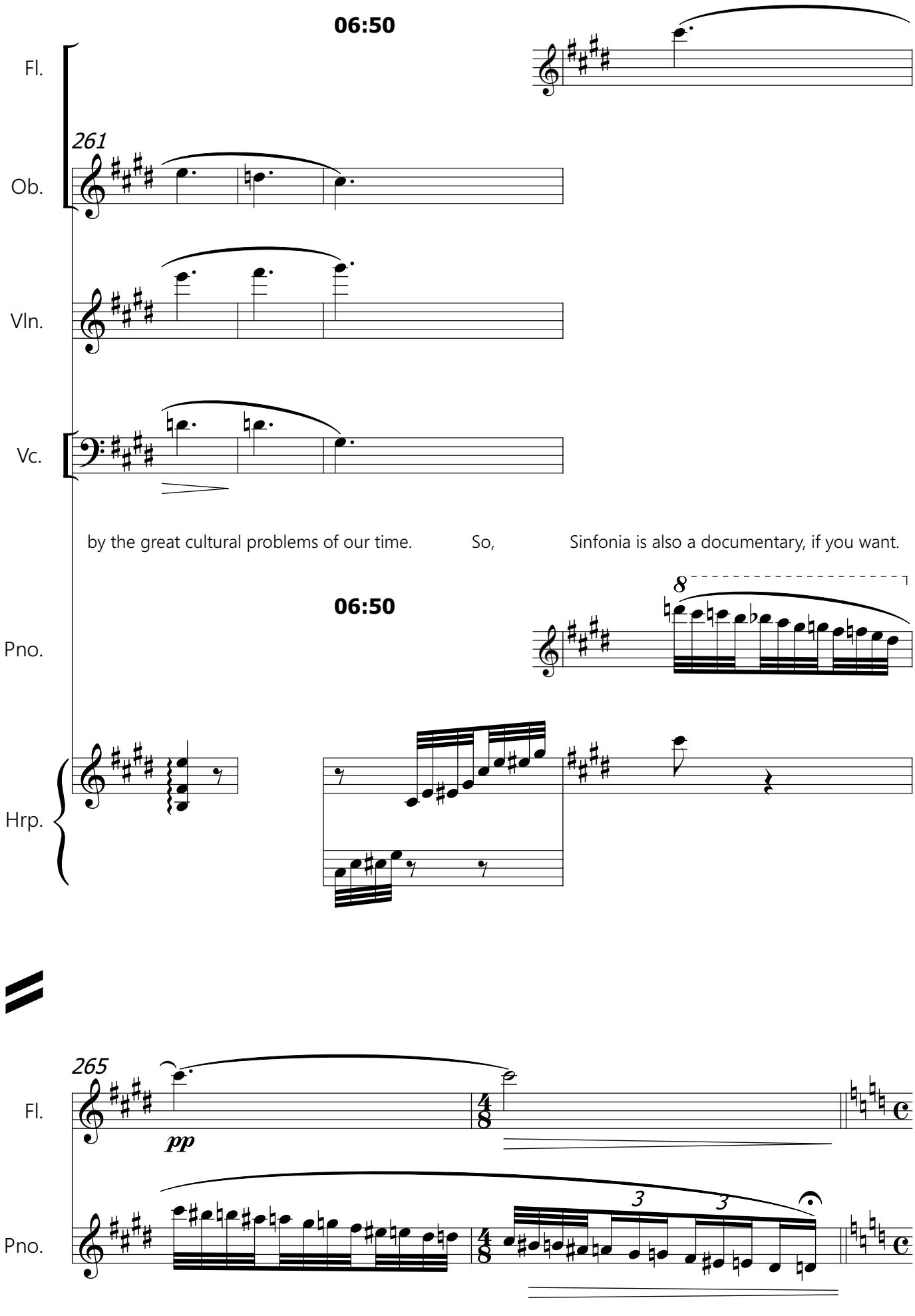
They think I'm alive!

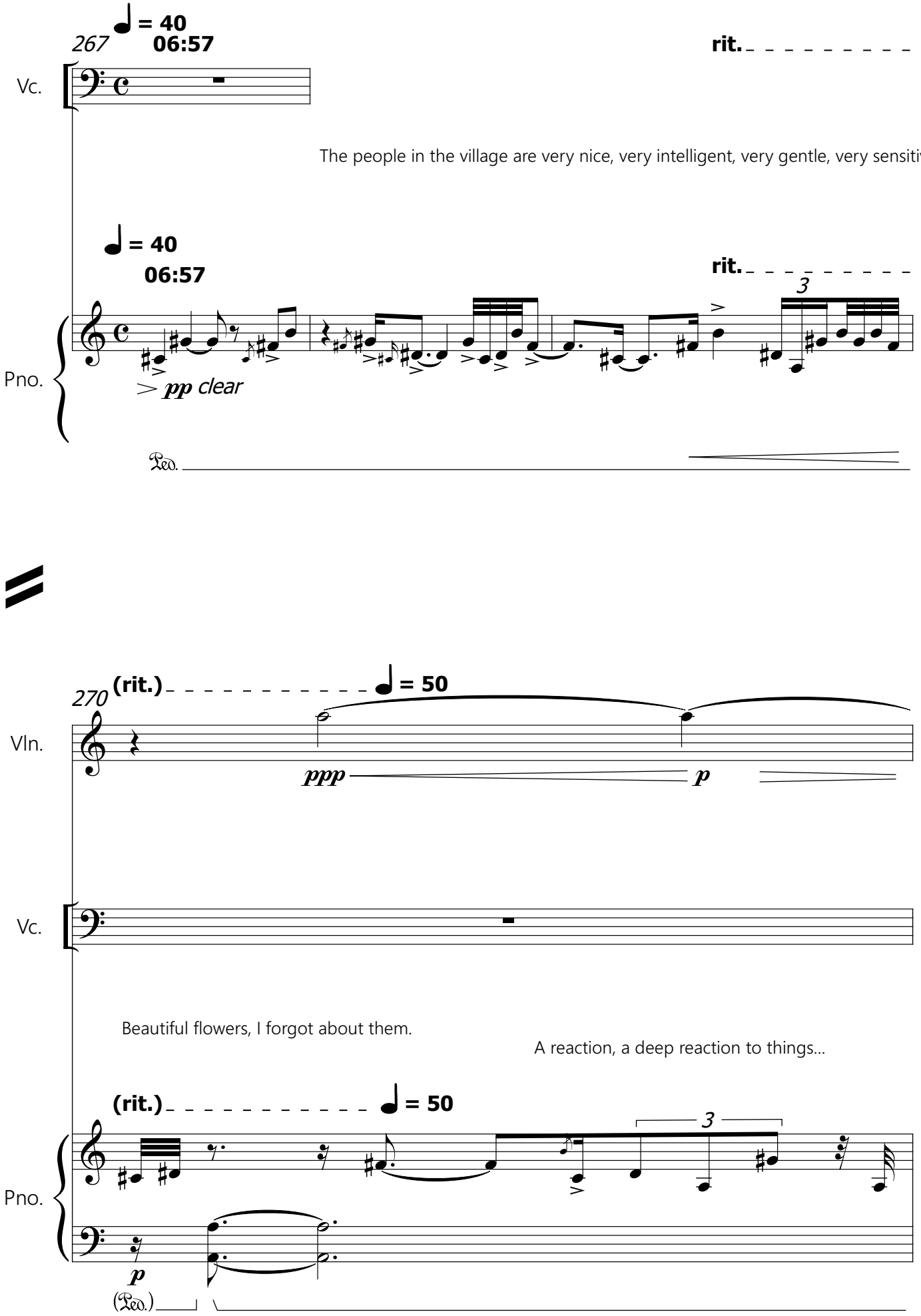
All the music from the beginning of this century tends to become a documentary of a process

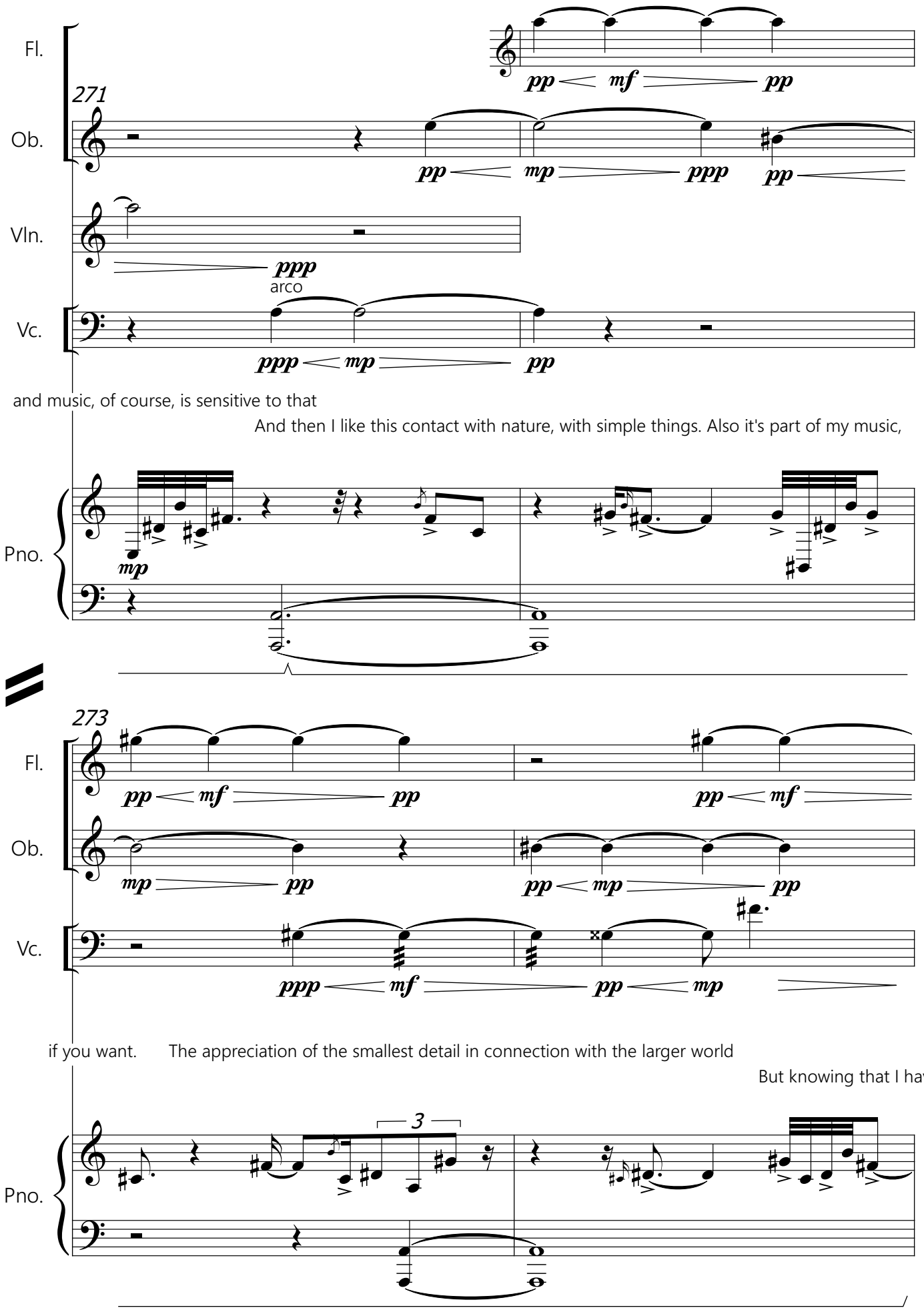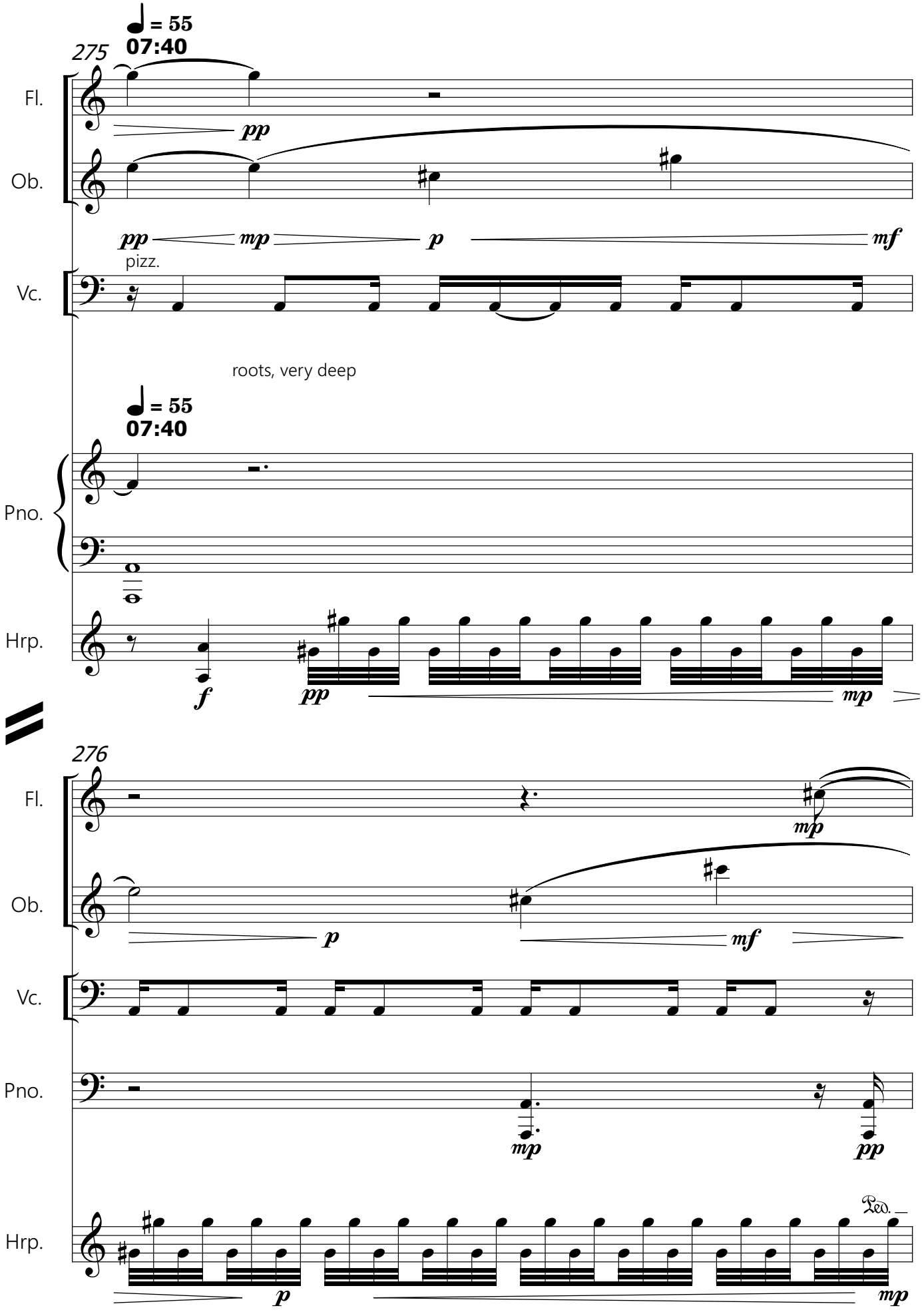



248
Fl.
Ob.
Vln.
Vc.
mp
mp
f
mf
A very deep, tragic transformation that was going through the world in those periods
8
Pno.
Hrp.
251
Fl.
Ob.
Vln.
Vc.
Hrp.
mf
mf
p
p

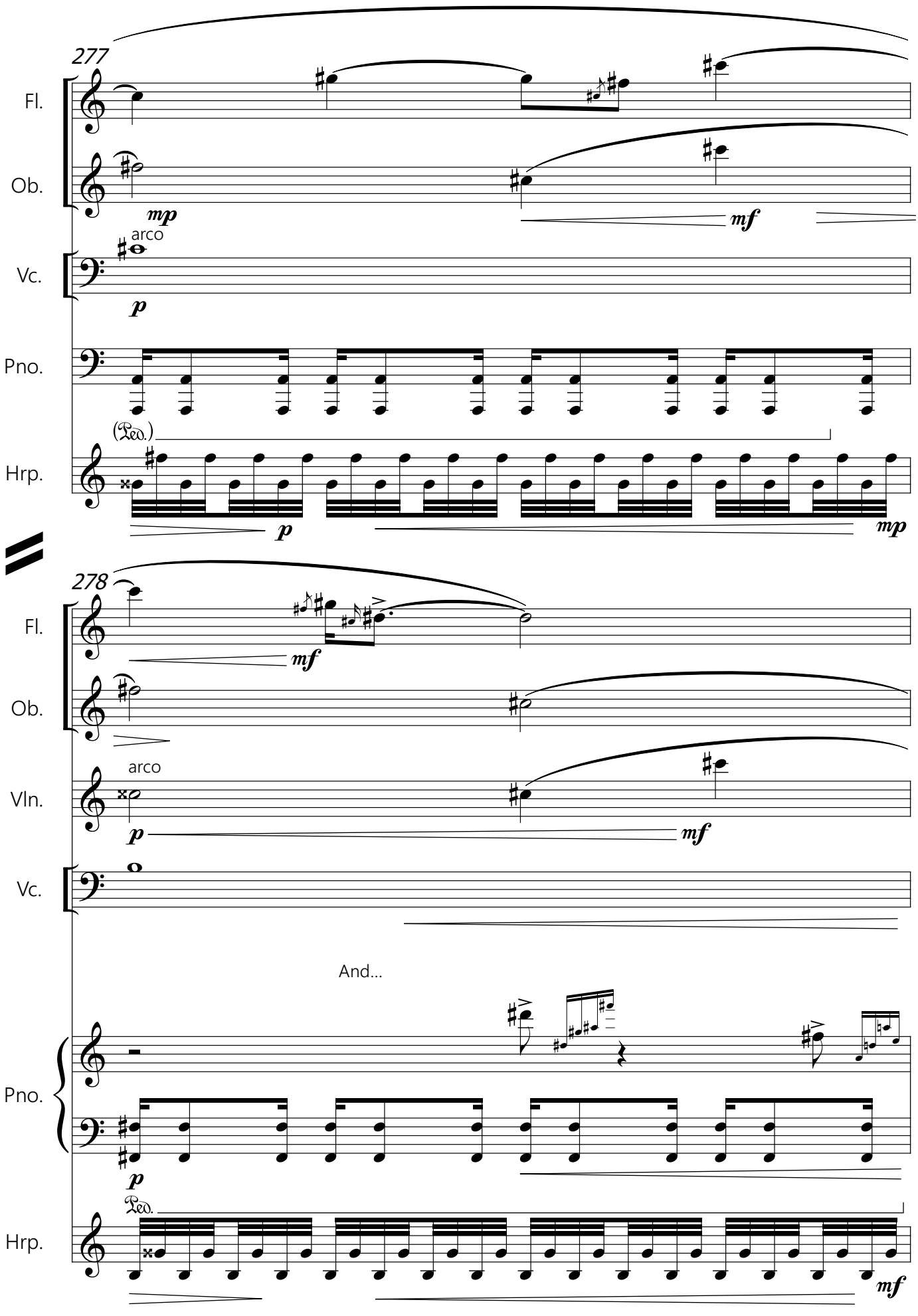

rit.
a tempo
rit.
06:44
253
Fl.
f
Ob.
f
mf
Vln.
mf
Vc.
mp
Luciano Berio, most of all, is and was a musician continuously excited
rit.
a tempo
rit.
06:44
Hrp.
mp

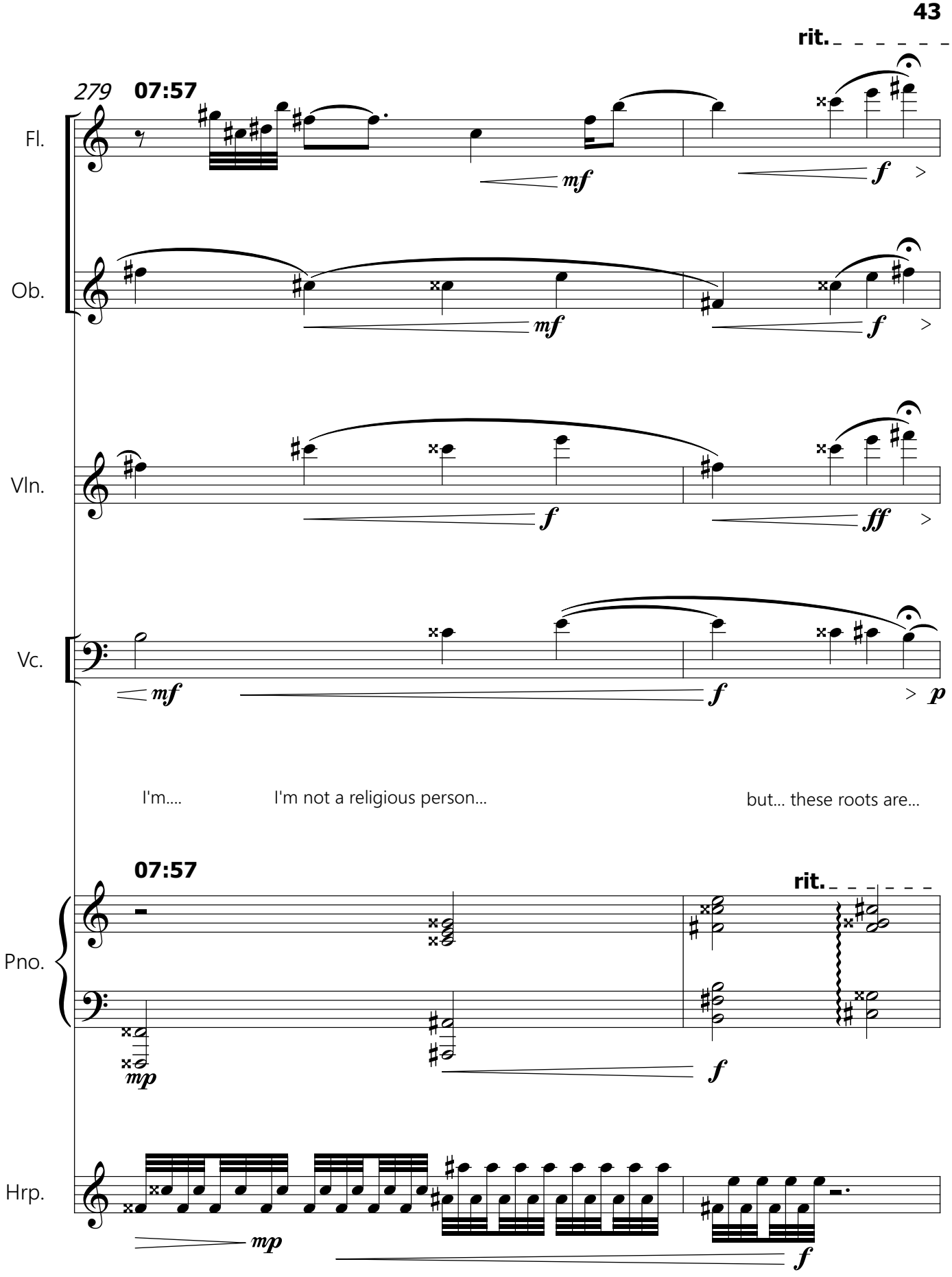

06:50
Fl.
261
Ob.
Vln.
Vc.
by the great cultural problems of our time.
So,
Sinfonia is also a documentary, if you want.
06:50
Pno.
Hrp.
265
Fl.
pp
Pno.

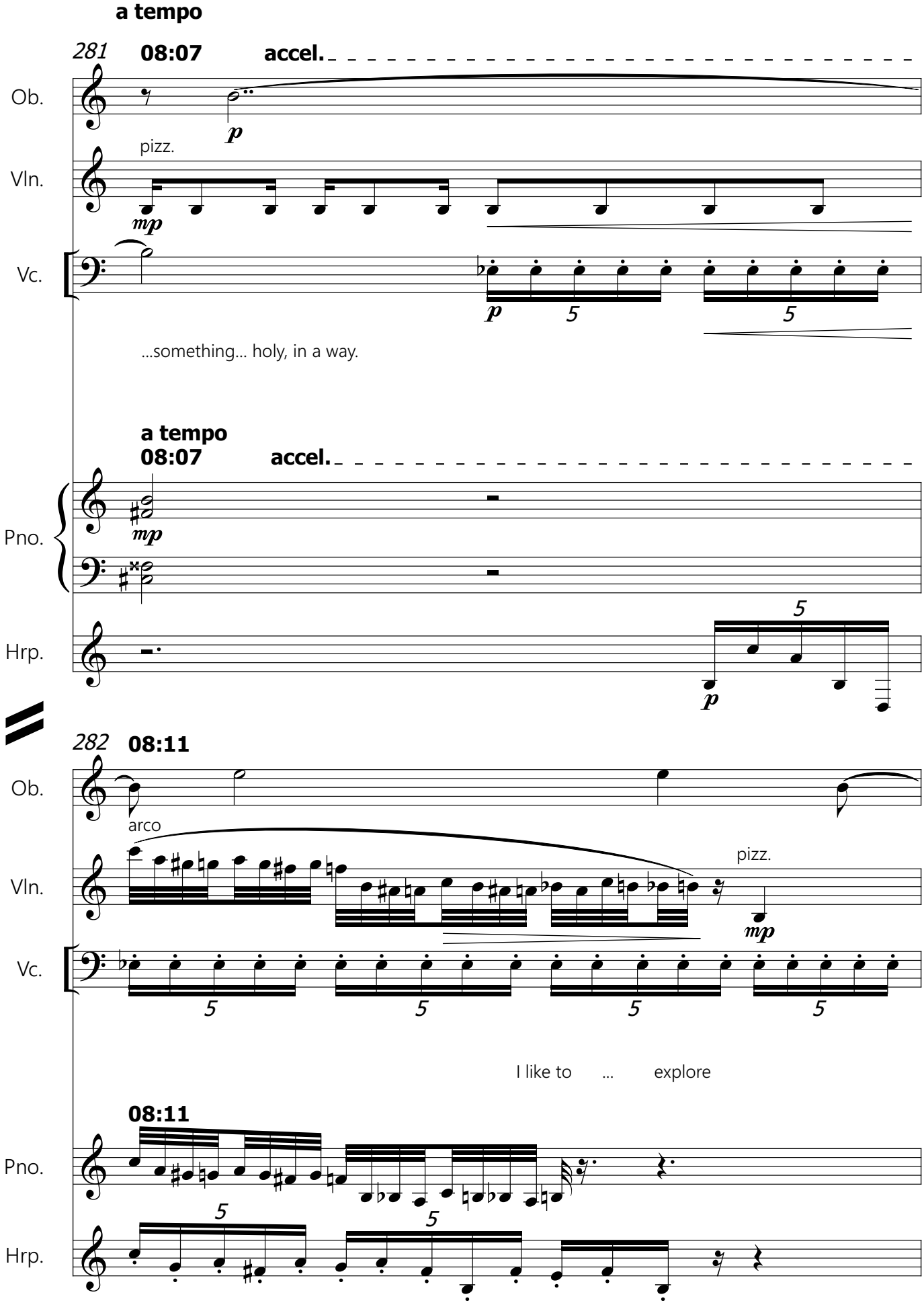

267
♩ = 40
06:57
rit.
Vc.
The people in the village are very nice, very intelligent, very gentle, very sensitive.
♩ = 40
06:57
rit.
3
Pno.
pp clear
Ped.
270
(rit.)
♩ = 50
Vln.
ppp
p
Vc.
Beautiful flowers, I forgot about them.
A reaction, a deep reaction to things...
(rit.)
♩ = 50
3
Pno.
p
(Ped.)
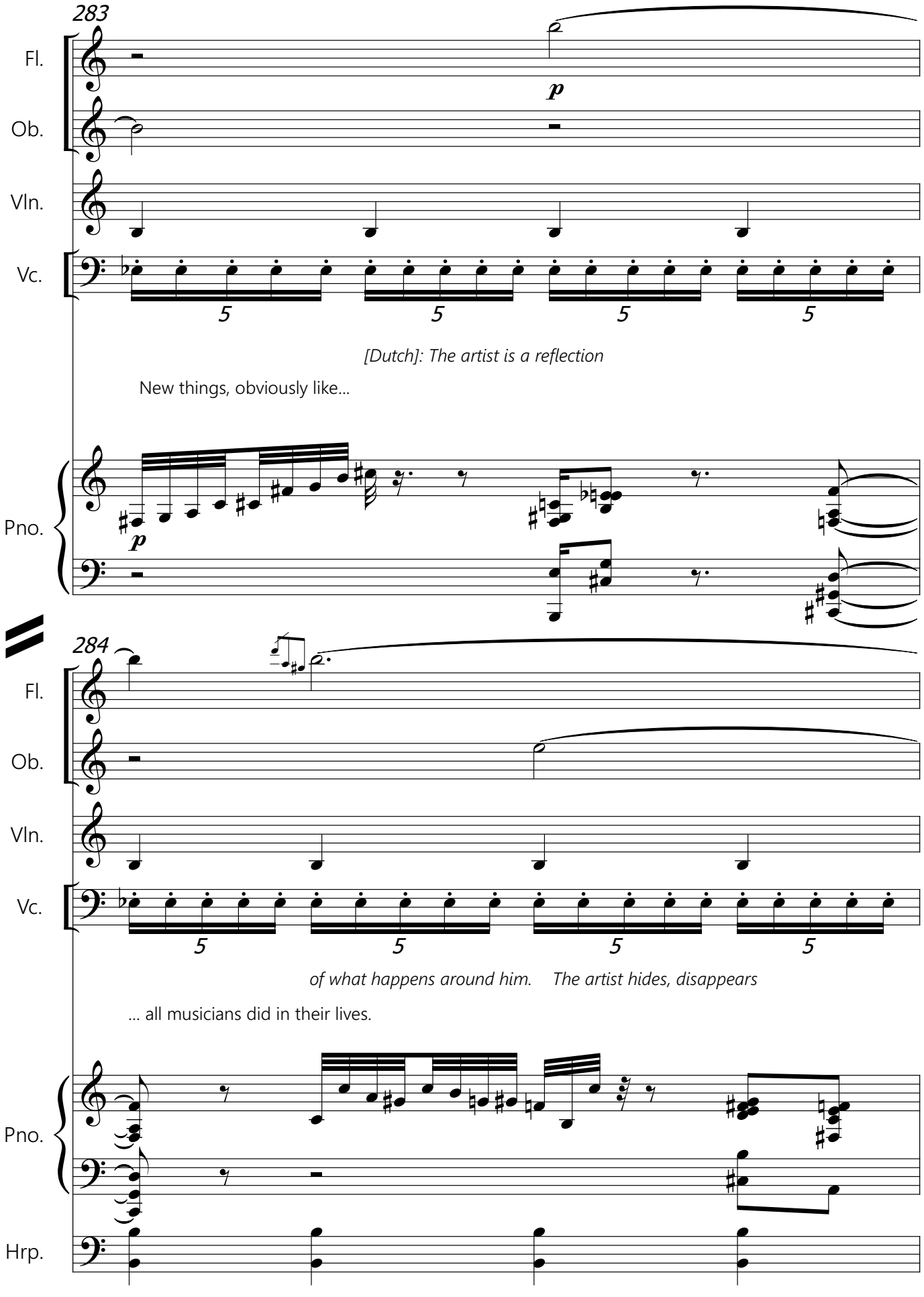

Fl.
271
Ob.
Vln.
arco
Vc.
and music, of course, is sensitive to that
And then I like this contact with nature, with simple things. Also it's part of my music,
Pno.
273
Fl.
Ob.
Vc.
if you want.
The appreciation of the smallest detail in connection with the larger world
But knowing that I have
3
Pno.
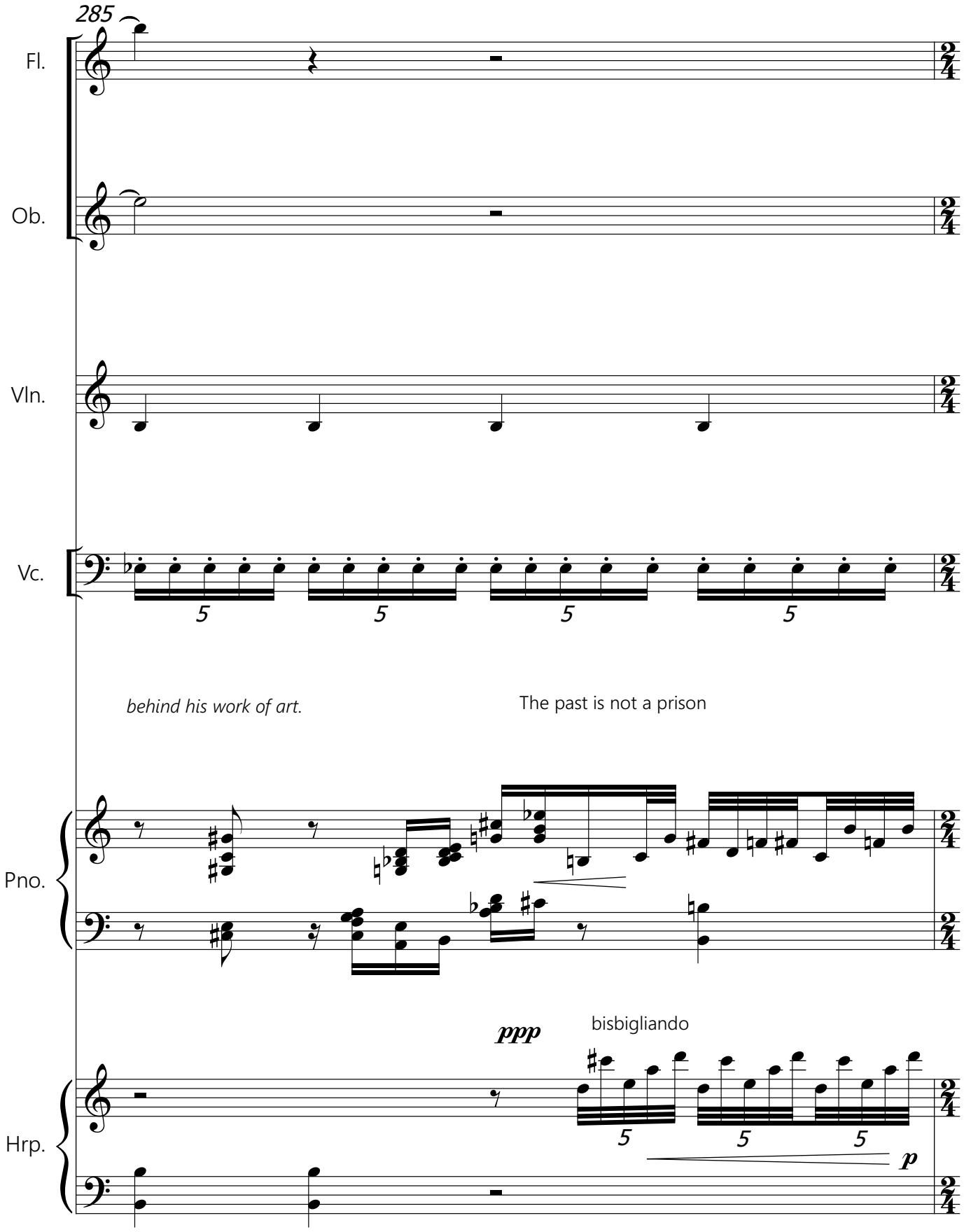

♩ = 55
07:40
275
Fl.
Ob.
pp
pp
mp
p
mf
pizz.
Vc.
roots, very deep
♩ = 55
07:40
Pno.
Hrp.
f
pp
mp
276
Fl.
mp
Ob.
p
mf
Vc.
Pno.
mp
pp
Hrp.
Ped.
p
mp
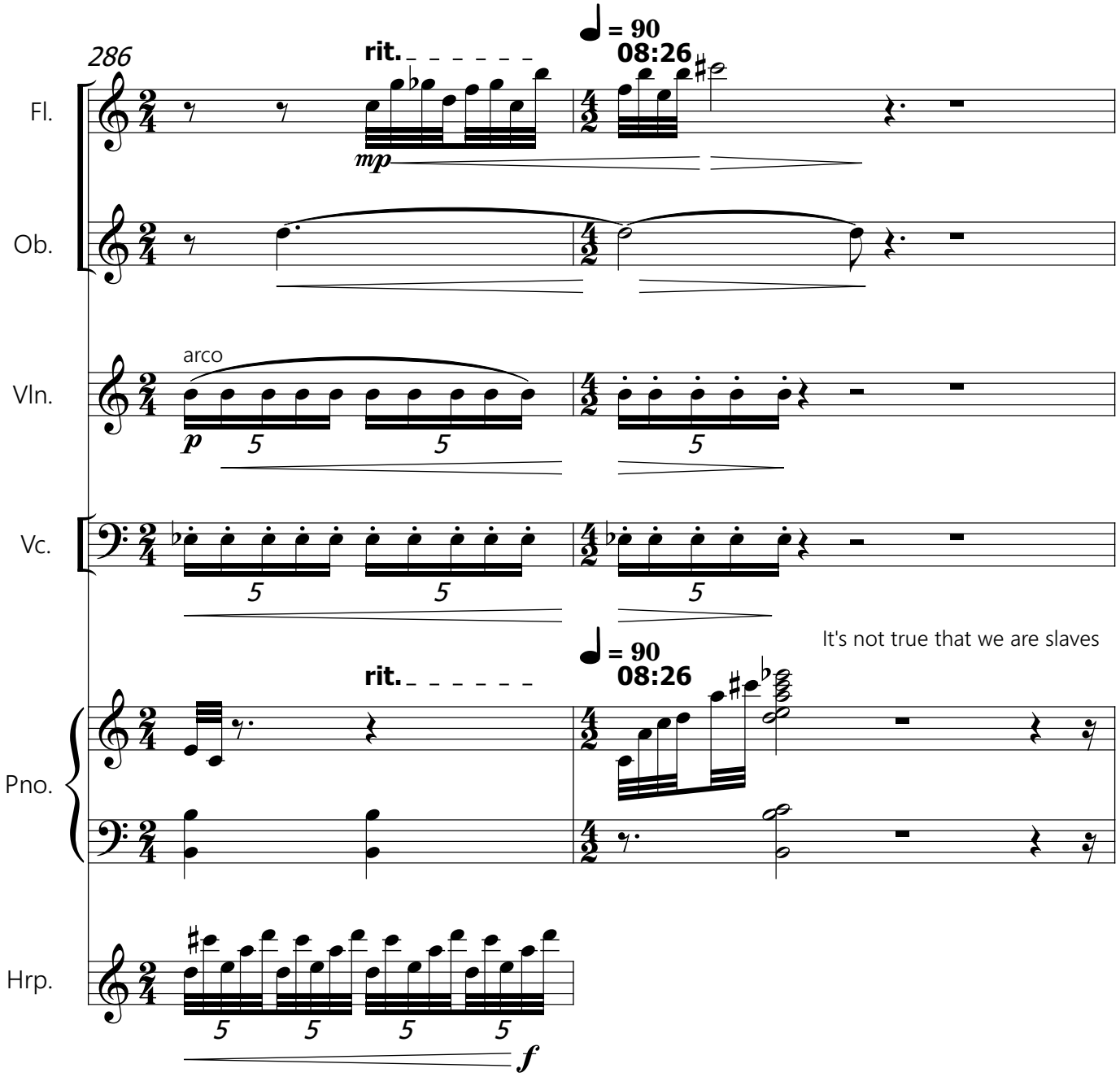

277
Fl.
Ob.
mp
mf
arco
Vc.
p
Pno.
(Ped.)
Hrp.
p
mp
278
Fl.
mf
Ob.
arco
Vln.
p
mf
Vc.
And...
Pno.
p
Ped.
Hrp.
mf


rit.
279
07:57
Fl.
Ob.
Vln.
Vc.
mf
f
ff
p
I'm....
I'm not a religious person...
but... these roots are...
07:57
rit.
Pno.
mp
Hrp.


a tempo
281
08:07
accel.
Ob.
Vln.
Vc.
pizz.
...something... holy, in a way.
a tempo
08:07
accel.
Pno.
Hrp.
282
08:11
Ob.
Vln.
Vc.
arco
pizz.
I like to ... explore
08:11
Pno.
Hrp.

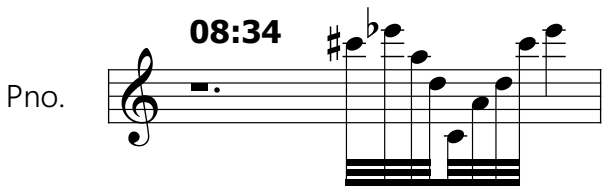

283
Fl.
Ob.
Vln.
Vc.
p
5
5
5
5
[Dutch]: The artist is a reflection
New things, obviously like...
Pno.
p
284
Fl.
Ob.
Vln.
Vc.
5
5
5
5
of what happens around him. The artist hides, disappears
... all musicians did in their lives.
Pno.
Hrp.

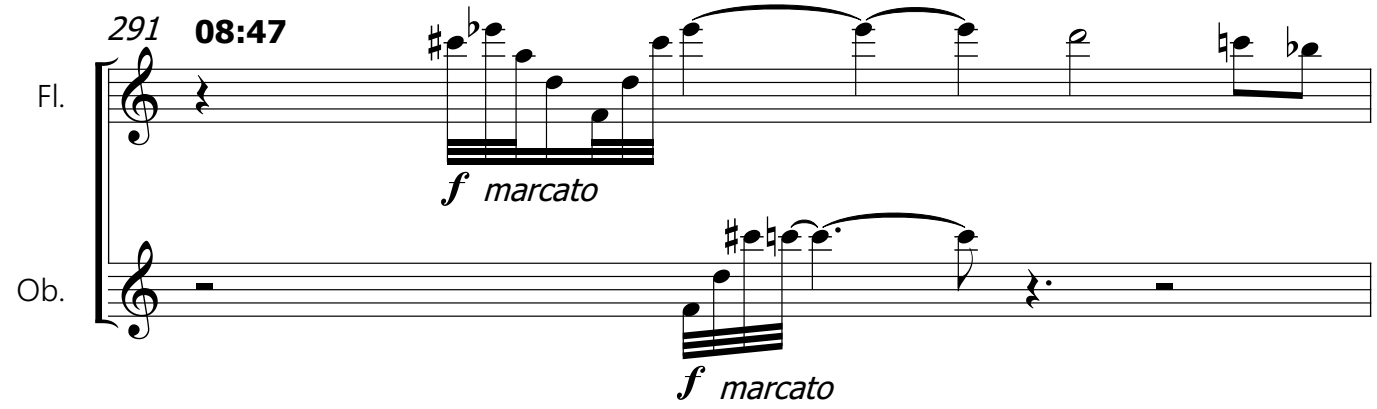

285
Fl.
Ob.
Vln.
Vc.
5
5
5
5
behind his work of art.
The past is not a prison
Pno.
ppp
bisbigliando
Hrp.
5
5
5
p



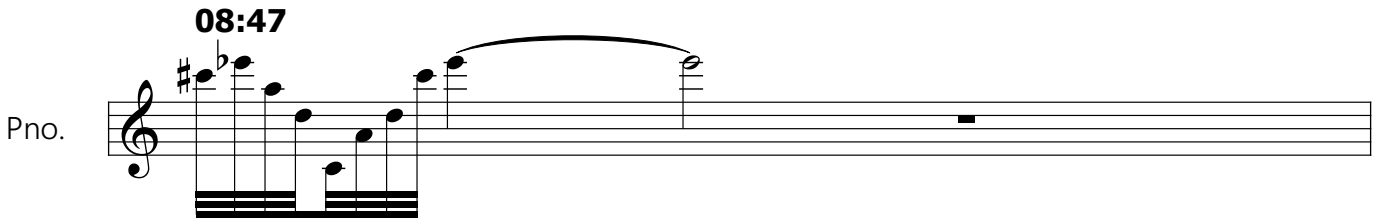
of the product of history It's a space to explore, constantly I feel that...

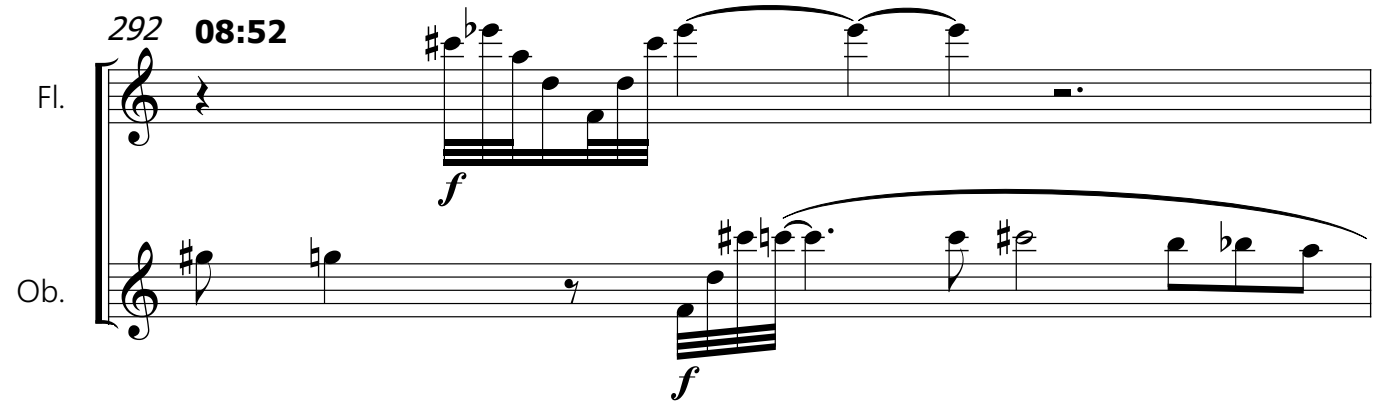
We invent history



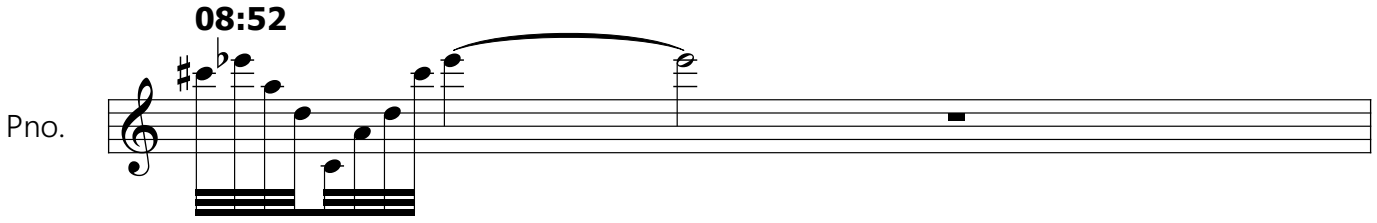


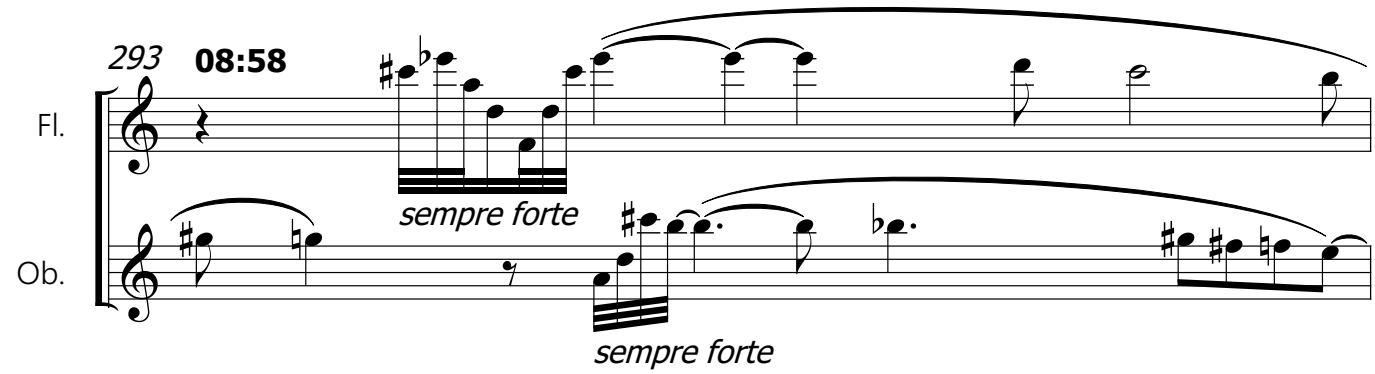
... there is a lot ... ... around us.





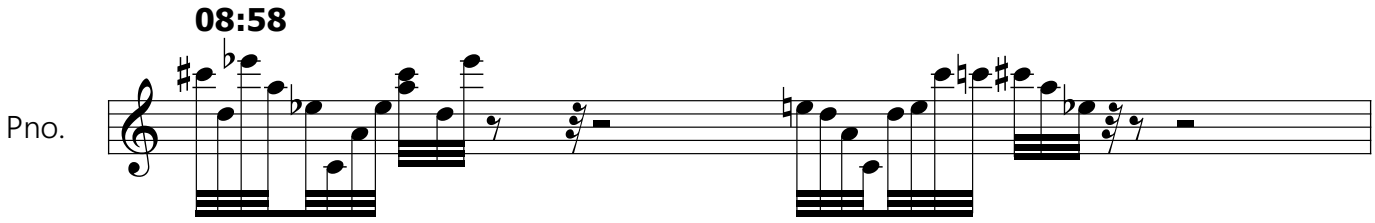
We simply have to be aware of what is there

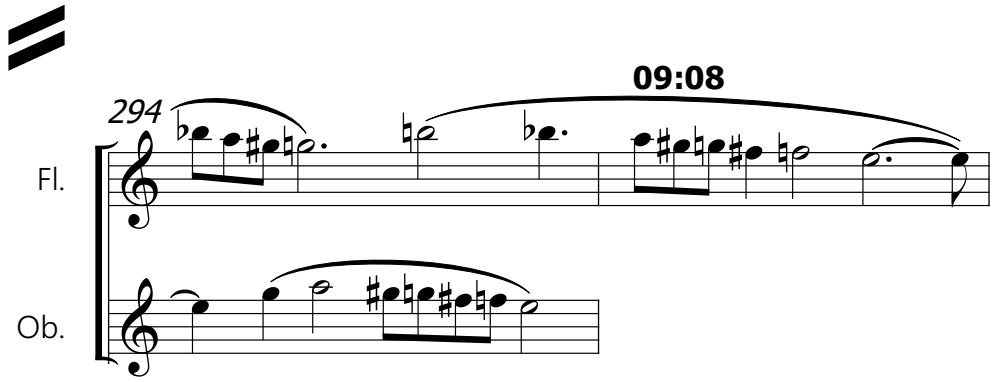




And to extract,

to isolate these things





to bring into light, to develop them...

try to build on the ruins of the past

Listen!

to have a dialogue with the past

Bl-bl-bl-bl-

Certain works take shape because something else happened before

-bl-blooming blooming blooming

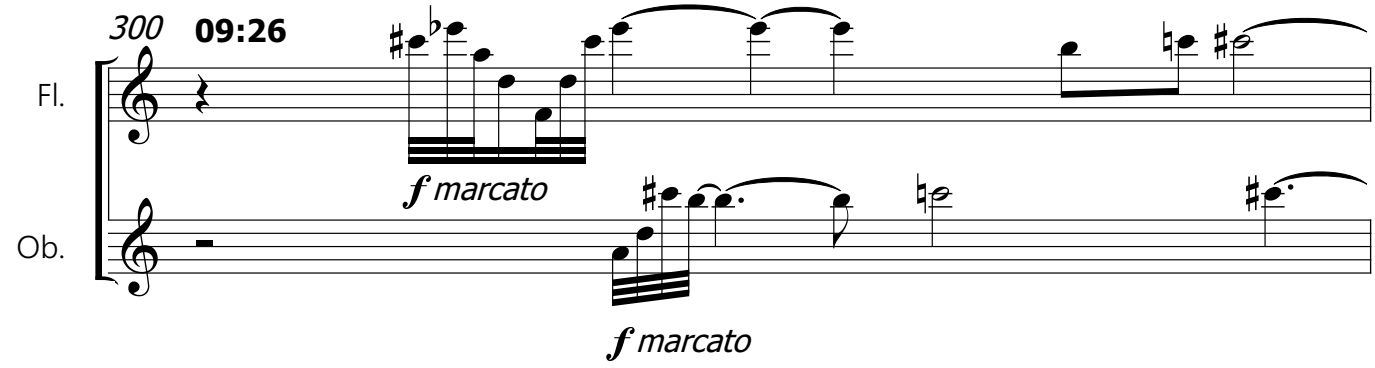
Listen!

We can invent a new vision of the past

Listen!

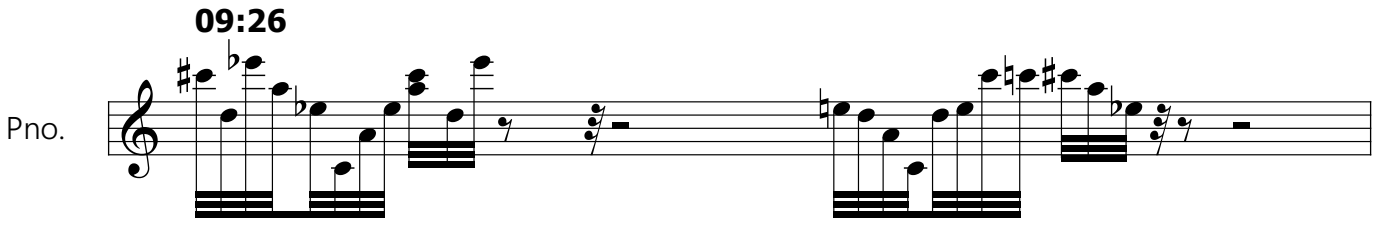
Hisssssss

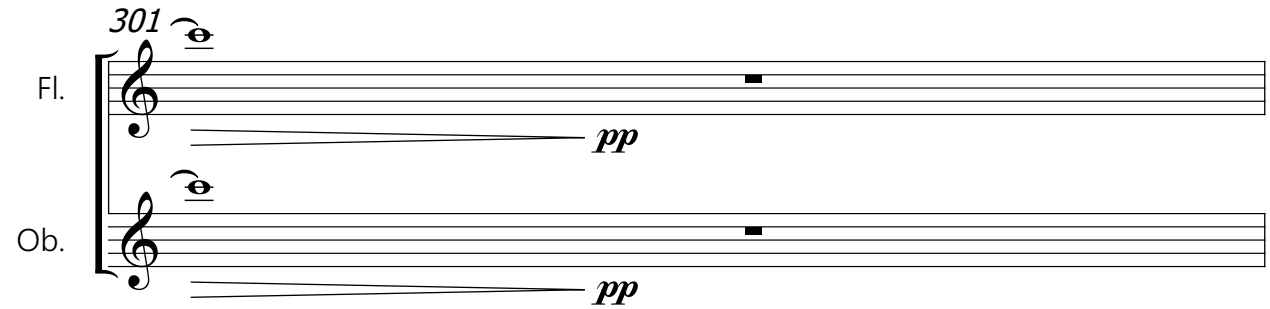
Listen!



Today, music can bring a different idea of the past

To have a dialogue with the past





There's a continuity, it's like a journey...
and these works are simply signalling
the moment of this journey, but the
journey continues.

Stop! Did you hear? Keep going!

It's getting late. Where now? When now?

Did you hear? Stop!

Stop! Keep going!

But I must have said this
before, since I say it now!

just a small murder

blood

they don't know who they are either

Keep going!

hardly worth it, yet what can you expect

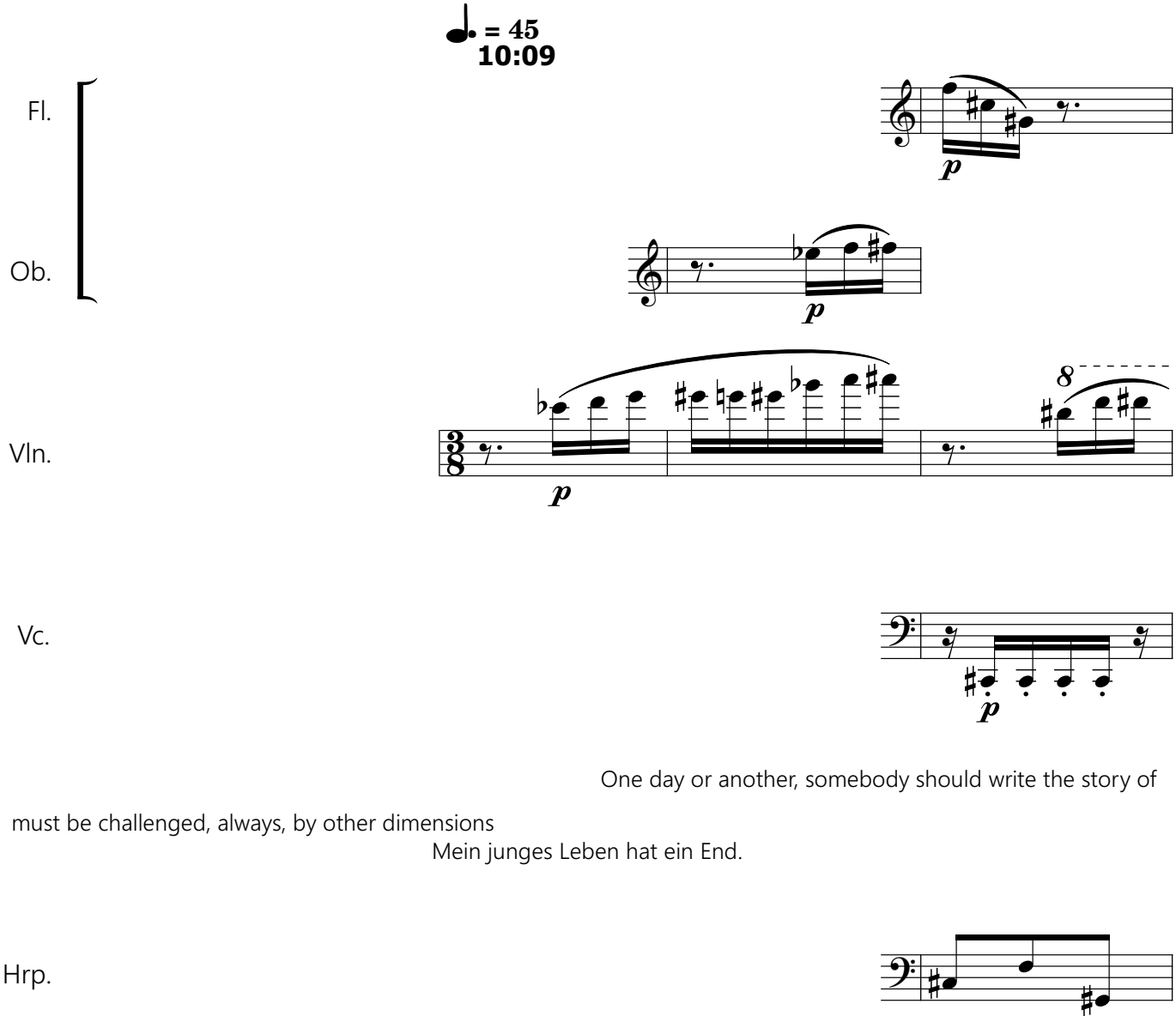
and after each group disintegration the name of Mayakovsky hangs in clean air

since I have a great respect for history

But now it's done, it's over. We've had our chance. There was even, for a second, hope of resurrection, or almost.

resurrection
resurrection
resurrection

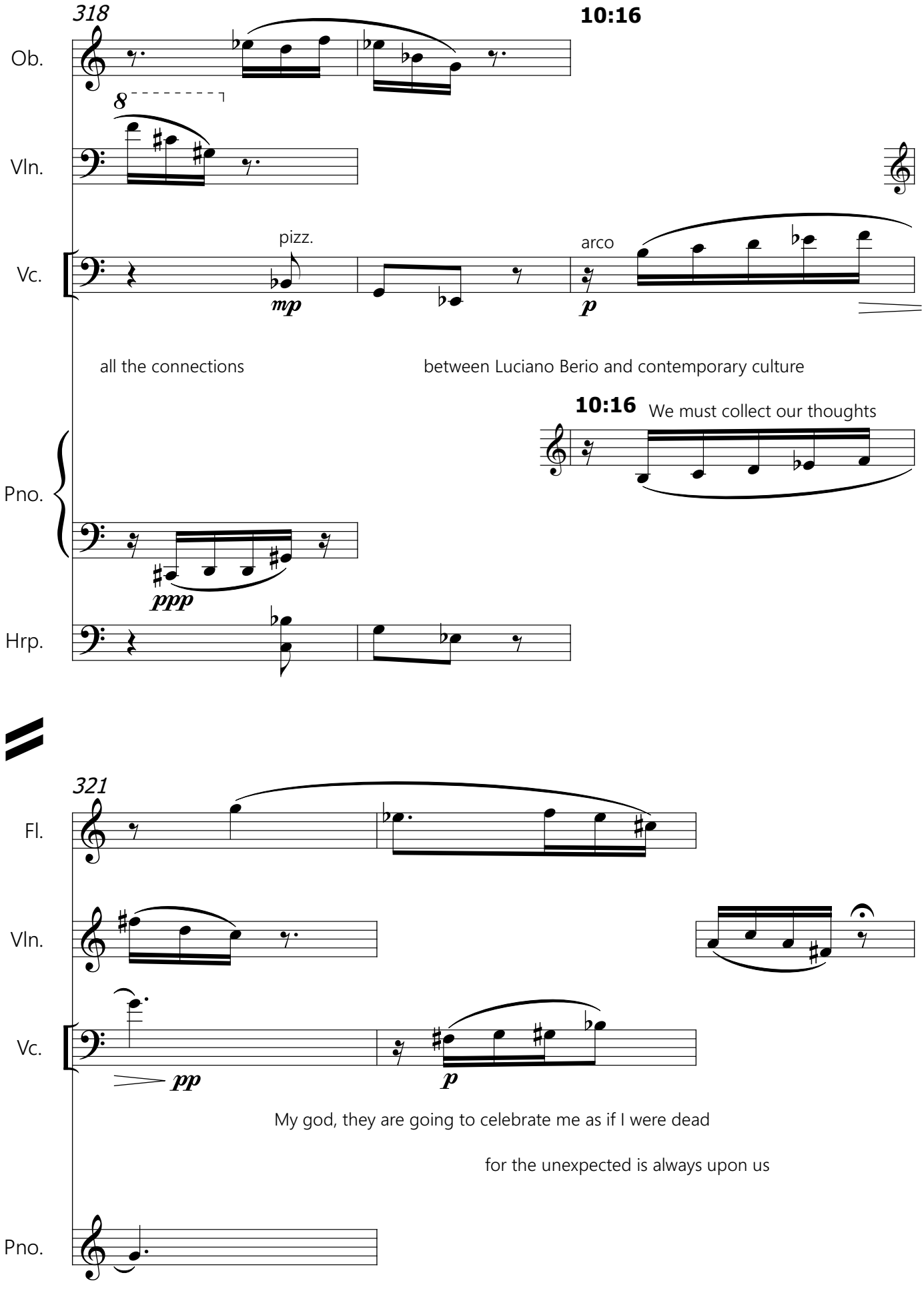
The feeling of communication

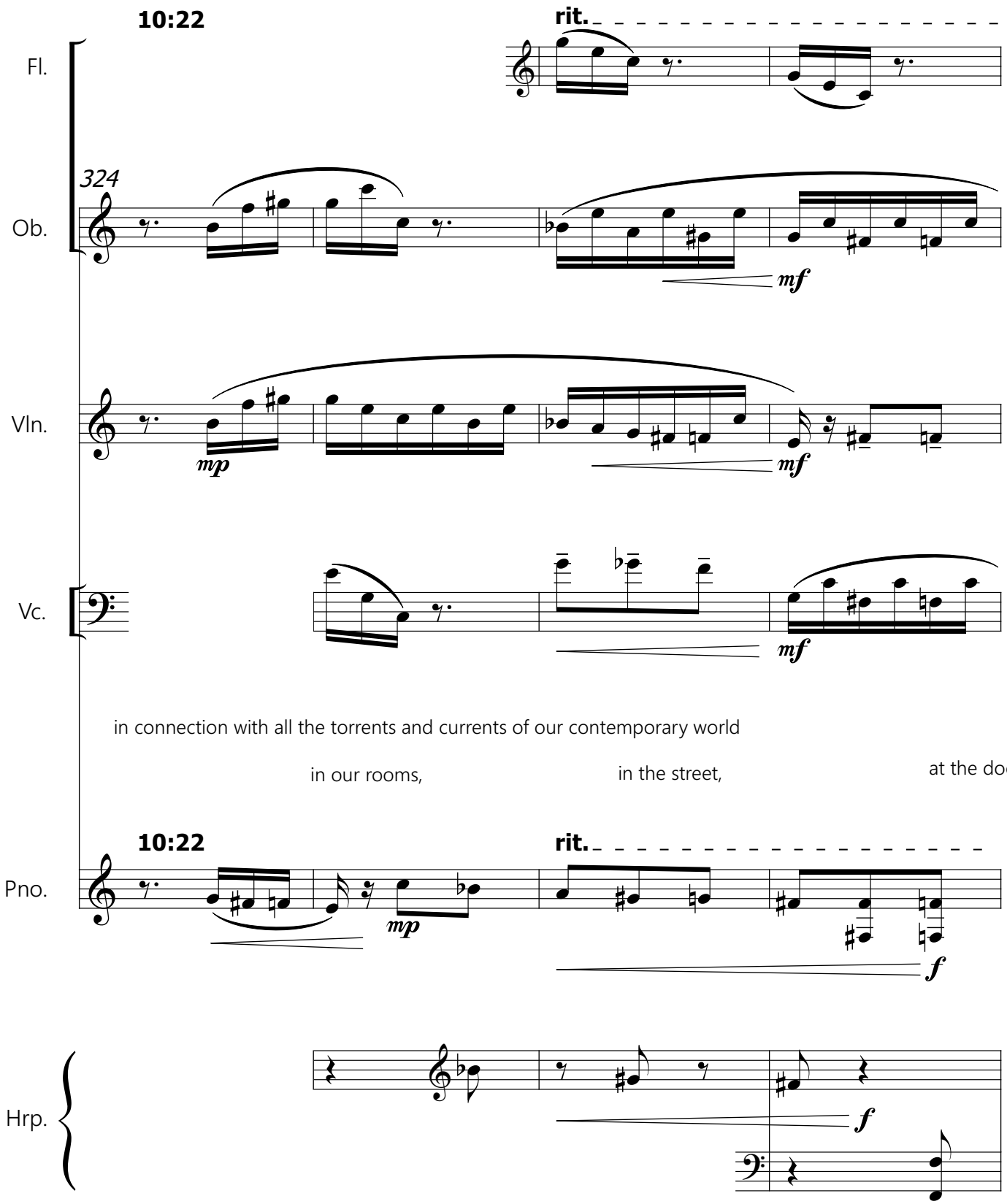


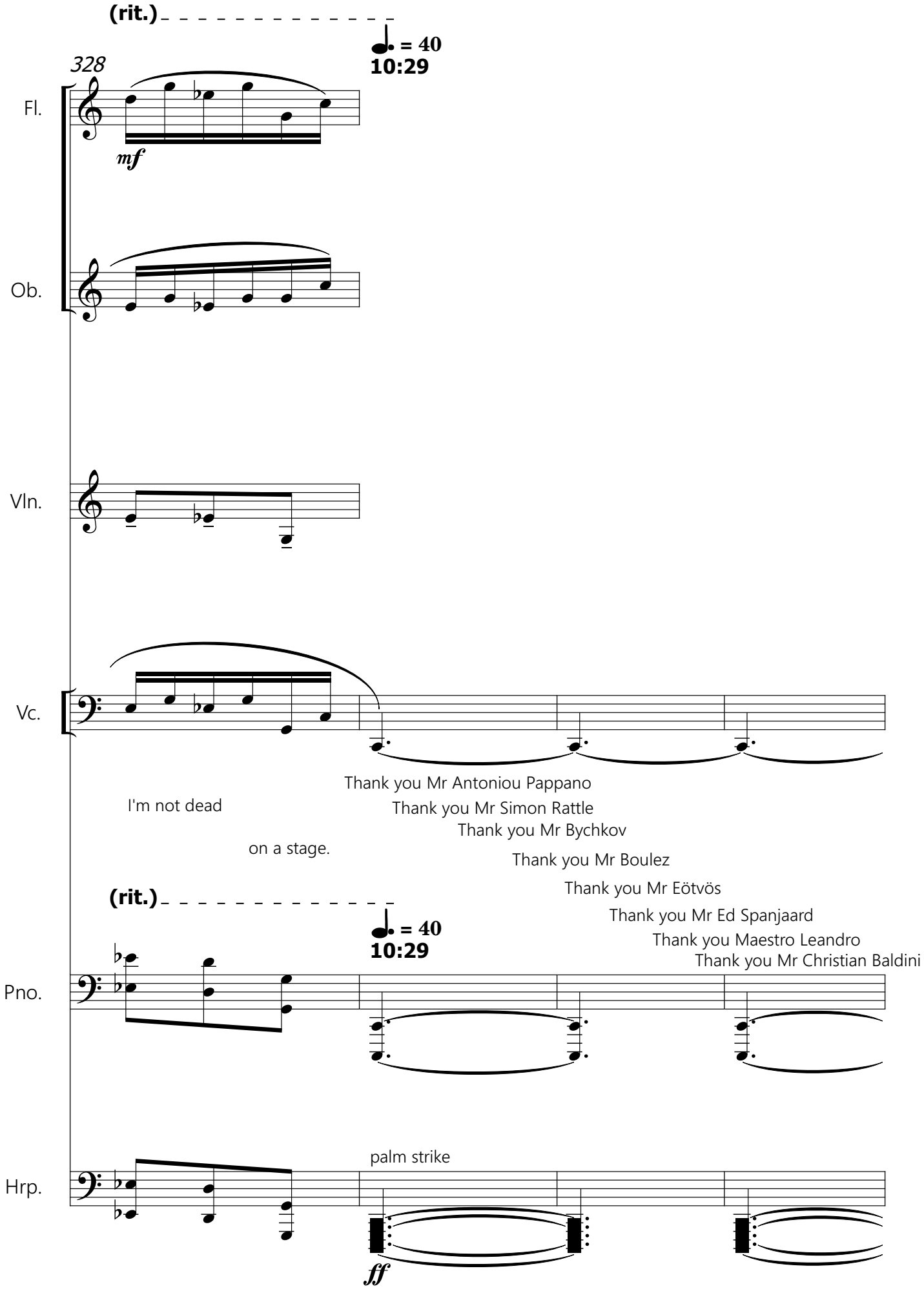
One day or another, somebody should write the story of

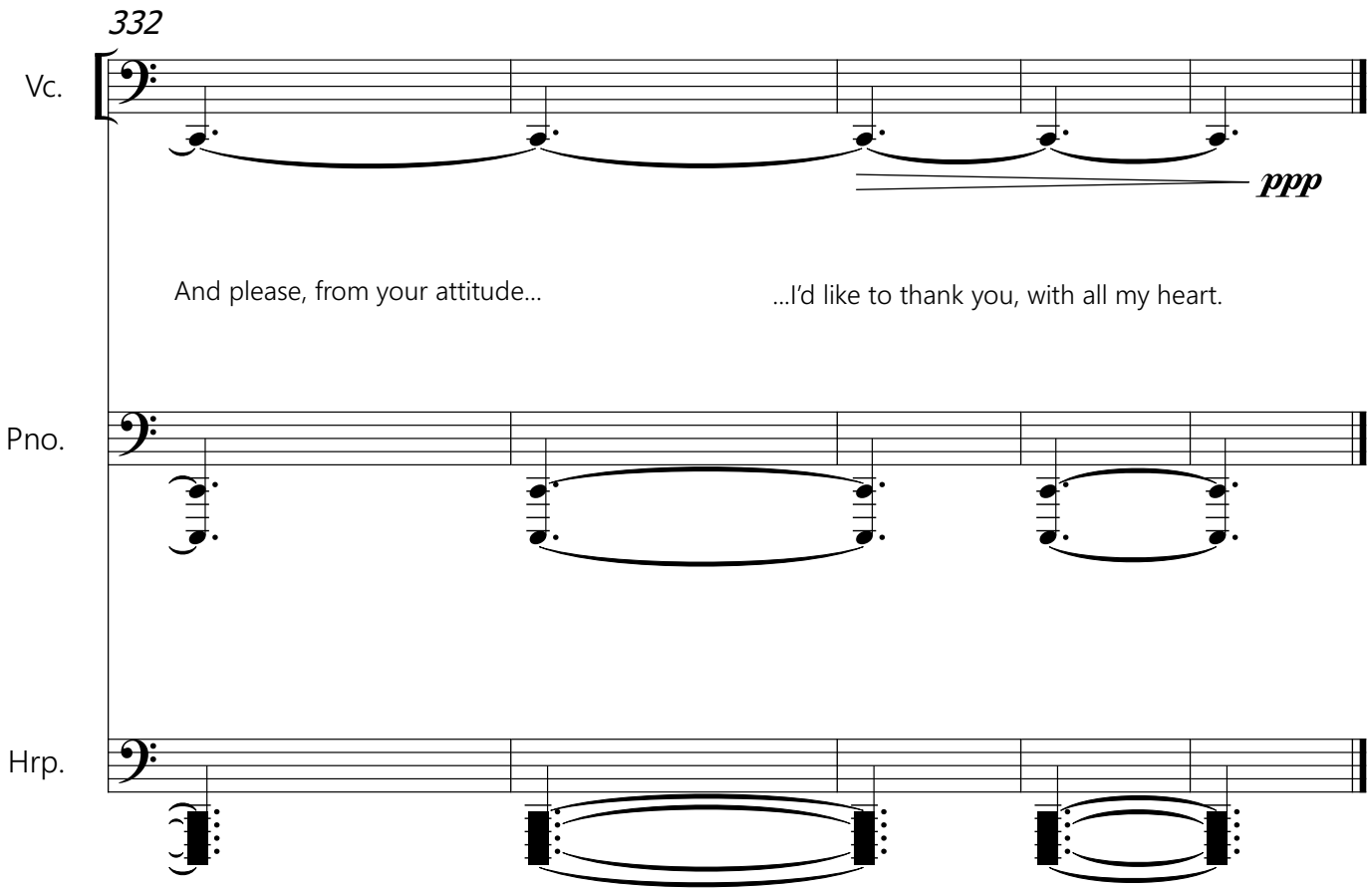
must be challenged, always, by other dimensions

Mein junges Leben hat ein End.


318
10:16
Ob.
8
Vln.
Vc.
pizz.
mp
arco
p
all the connections
between Luciano Berio and contemporary culture
10:16
We must collect our thoughts
Pno.
ppp
Hrp.
321
Fl.
Vln.
Vc.
pp
p
My god, they are going to celebrate me as if I were dead
for the unexpected is always upon us
Pno.


10:22
rit.
Fl.
324
Ob.
mf
Vln.
mp
mf
Vc.
mf
in connection with all the torrents and currents of our contemporary world
in our rooms,
in the street,
at the door,
10:22
rit.
Pno.
mp
f
Hrp.
f


(rit.)
328
♩. = 40
10:29
Fl.
mf
Ob.
Vln.
Vc.
I'm not dead
on a stage.
Thank you Mr Antoniou Pappano
Thank you Mr Simon Rattle
Thank you Mr Bychkov
Thank you Mr Boulez
Thank you Mr Eötvös
Thank you Mr Ed Spanjaard
Thank you Maestro Leandro
Thank you Mr Christian Baldini
(rit.)
♩. = 40
10:29
Pno.
palm strike
Hrp.
ff


332
Vc.
ppp
And please, from your attitude...
...I'd like to thank you, with all my heart.
Pno.
Hrp.